

CM Rekha flags off 200 e-buses, launches Delhi-Rohtak service

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Friday flagged off 200 new electric buses, pushing the city's total fleet beyond 6,300 and strengthening its position as the largest electric bus network in the country.

The Government also launched an interstate electric bus service between Delhi and Rohtak and inaugurated key transport infrastructure projects.

The Chief Minister said the move is part of a broader plan to make Delhi cleaner and reduce pollution through electric mobility. She added that improving connectivity and modernising public transport remain central to the government's agenda.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The event was held at the East Vinod Nagar depot in the presence of Transport Minister Dr Pankaj Kumar Singh and senior officials. Along with the induction of new buses, the Government opened a new bus terminal at Madanpur Khadar and inaugurated an administrative building at the depot.

The Chief Minister said the government aims to provide better transport access, cleaner air, and efficient services for commuters. She noted that several of the newly inducted buses are designed to operate in narrow lanes and underserved areas, improving last-mile connectivity.

She also highlighted that the Delhi Government is working under a long-term plan to expand and modernise the transport system.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A budget of ₹4,000 crore has been allocated over four years to promote electric vehicles. The plan includes incentives such as road tax exemptions and a phased transition of school and commercial vehicles to electric mode.

Transport Minister Dr Pankaj Kumar Singh said the day marked a major step forward for Delhi's transport system. He said the addition of new buses, expansion of interstate routes, and development of infrastructure reflect the government's focus on safe, accessible, and modern public transport.

He added that the department is working to make the system more efficient and commuter-friendly.

According to him, the Delhi Transport Corporation has also recorded an increase in revenue over the past year, indicating improved performance. With the latest addition, Delhi's bus fleet now includes over 4,500 electric buses along with CNG buses.

The Government plans to expand the total fleet to around 14,000 buses by 2028-29.

The new electric buses are equipped with safety and passenger-friendly features such as CCTV cameras, panic buttons, and real-time tracking systems. Facilities for persons with disabilities have also been included.

The newly launched Delhi-Rohtak electric bus service will operate via key routes, including ISBT Kashmere Gate and Peeragarhi, connecting areas such as Tikri Border, Bahadurgarh, and Sampla before reaching Rohtak. Officials said the service will improve regional connectivity and reduce dependence on conventional fuel-based transport.

The Madanpur Khadar bus terminal, located near Kalindi Kunj Metro Station, has been developed with basic passenger amenities. It includes bus bays, shelters, parking spaces, and accessible infrastructure such as ramps. Around 22 buses are expected to operate from this terminal on multiple routes.

The Chief Minister also announced plans to set up an electric vehicle waste disposal plant in Holambi Kalan to manage battery disposal in an environmentally safe manner. The chief minister said that a massive 'EV Waste Disposal Plant' will be established in the Holambi Kalan area to ensure the scientific disposal of electric vehicle batteries in the future, thereby safeguarding the environment.

DERC proposes to amend open access green energy regulations

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a move that will promote cleaner renewable energy consumption by commercial users in the national Capital, the Delhi Electricity Regulatory Commission (DERC) has proposed to amend the open access green energy regulations.

Green Energy Open Access (GEOA) is a regulatory framework through which consumers with a connected load of 100 kW and more can directly purchase renewable energy from the suppliers, excluding local discoms, and thereby save up to 30-40 per cent of their electricity bills.

Under the existing Delhi Electricity Regulatory Commission (Terms and Conditions for Green Energy Open Access) Regulations, 2024, the eligibility for availing GEOA is restricted to consumers connected at 11 kV and above and having a sanctioned load of 100 kW and above.

"The said voltage-based restriction had the effect of excluding consumers who meet the prescribed load criterion but are connected at voltage levels below 11 kV from availing the Green Energy Open Access benefit," said a Delhi Electricity Regulatory Commission (DERC) document.

This is contrary to the GEOA framework's objective to promote a uniform, technology-neutral and load-based eligibility regime, enabling access to renewable energy across consumer categories, the officials said.

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The DERC has now issued a draft Delhi Electricity Regulatory Commission (Terms and Conditions for Green Energy Open Access) (First Amendment) Regulations, 2026 document seeking feedback from stakeholders over the proposed reduction in the voltage criterion from the current 11 kV to less than 11 kV.

The issue of GEOA applicability to consumers connected below 11 kV has emerged, especially in the case of those in telecom sectors, commercial infrastructures and medium, small and micro enterprises (MSMEs) that are characterised by geographically dispersed loads and predominantly low tension (LT) connectivity.

The issue was also discussed in meetings of the Delhi government's power department in which the need to enable wider access to GEOA was stressed, the officials said.



Metro services on Blue Line to be regulated on Sunday morning for maintenance

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Metro services on the Blue Line of the Delhi Metro will be briefly regulated on Sunday morning to facilitate scheduled track maintenance work between Indraprastha and Supreme Court stations, the DMRC said on Friday.

According to the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation, the regulation will be in place during the early morning hours on April 19, affecting train operations on Line 3 and Line 4. As per the revised schedule, the first train from Vaisali towards Dwarka Sector-21 will depart at 6.05 am, while services from Laxmi Nagar towards Dwarka Sector-21 will begin at 6.21 am.

The first train from Yamuna Bank towards Dwarka Sector-21 will start at 5.50 am, it said.

DTC records 21% rise in income to ₹995 crore in 2025-26: Minister

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Transport Corporation (DTC) has recorded about a 21 per cent rise in its income to ₹995.55 crore in 2025-26, Transport Minister Pankaj Singh said on Friday.

As per the latest financial data, DTC's total income has increased from ₹822.53 crore in 2024-25 to ₹995.55 crore in 2025-26 (up to March 26), registering a growth of approximately ₹173 crore.

"This turnaround is the result of the collective effort, commitment and dedication of the entire DTC family. The previous government had left DTC in a financially weakened state, burdened with losses," the transport minister said.

In contrast, the present government has taken decisive steps to revive the corporation, streamline operations, and transform it into a more financially stable and accountable public transport entity, he added.

As per the data, ticketed income has increased from ₹327.23 crore to ₹379.77 crore, registering a growth of ₹52.54 crore on a year-on-year basis, while earnings from special hire services have risen from ₹82.65 crore to ₹99.21 crore, marking an increase of ₹16.56 crore during the same period.

"The most significant growth has been recorded under miscellaneous income, which has increased from ₹342.67 crore to ₹446.59 crore, reflecting a substantial rise of ₹103.92 crore, till March 2026," an official said.

This category includes revenue from advertisements, rent receipts and penalty collections.

"The corporation has also recorded an increase in average monthly income from ₹68.54 crore to ₹82.96 crore, indicating stronger financial discipline and better resource utilisation," the minister added.

He added that the Government's approach goes beyond increasing revenue; it focuses on strengthening institutional capacity.



RD schools achieve 100% pass rate in CBSE Class 10

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The RD Public Senior Secondary School, Krishan Vihar, and RD International School, Rohini, have claimed that they have achieved the 100 per cent pass rate in the Class 10 board examinations declared by the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE), with students achieving high scores and consistent academic performance.

According to a statement, RD Public Senior Secondary School, Krishan Vihar, and RD International School both recorded full pass results in the academic session 2025-26, continuing their track record of strong outcomes in previous years. Chairperson Sushila Jaikishan, along with management members Varun Dhaka and Varuna Dhaka, and Principal Dr Suchitra Katyal, congratulated students, parents, and staff for achieving the result.

NORTHERN RAILWAY
NOTICE INVITING TENDER

Name of Work and its location	75-SRDEE-G-DLI-2026-27 Electrical work in connection with (i) Provision of new Toilet, Bathroom, Suits, Kitchen and other misc. works at RPF Valika Mess Barar Square in the section of SSE/W/S. P. Marg under ADEN/E-II, (ii) Provision of an Indoor Sports Complex (including 2 badminton courts) and an auditorium with a capacity of 200 in the 6BN/RP/S complex, Dayabasti.
Approx. Cost of the works in	[Rs. 6221802.00/-]
Address of the office	Sr. Div. Elect. Engineer/General, DRM Office, Delhi Division, Northern Railway, State Entry Road, New Delhi, 110055
Earnest Money	[Rs 124400.00/-]
Last Date & time of submission of tender	08.05.2026, 16.00 Hrs.
Opening of tender	08.05.2026, 16.00 Hrs.
Website & notice board	www.ireps.gov.in & Sr. Divl. Elect. Engineer/General, New Delhi

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The Pioneer
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CHANGE OF NAME

I, Rekha Yadav, W/o No.15585000K L/Hav Phool Chand Yadav, R/o- Vill & PO- Basari, P.S- Bamita, Teh- Rajnagar, Dist - Chhatarpur, M.P. have changed my name from Rekha to Rekha Yadav, my correct DOB is 01Jan1992, vide affidavit dated 17.04.2026. PD(899)C
I, Radha, W/o JC-813068F Nb/Sub Dinesh Kumar, R/o- Vill & PO- Tigrana, Teh & Dist.- Bhiwani, Haryana- 127021 have changed my name from Radha to Radha Tanwar, vide affidavit dated 17/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi. PD(900)C
I, Kiran Mishra, Mother of- No.8039603K PNR Shivam Kumar, R/o- Vill- Basaha Bhoad, PO- Shrinagar, Dist- Lakhimpur Kheri, U.P.- 261506, have changed my name from Kiran Mishra to Kiran Devi Mishra, vide affidavit No. IN-DL94955385388959Y dated 17/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi. PD(901)C
I, Munni Singh, Mother of- No.16015442Y Hav Bhuvanesh Pratap Singh, R/o- Amavan, Mawai Padiyana, U.P.- 226008, have changed my name from Munni Singh to Munni, vide affidavit dated 17/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi. PD(902)C

I, Sabita Bhen, Mother of- No.4286706Y Hav Chaudhari Nayanbhai Raysingbhai, R/o- Vill- Makanjhar, PO- Sathav, Teh- Mandvi, Dist- Surat, Gujarat- 394160, have changed my name from Sabita Bhen to Chaudhari Savitaben Raysingbhai, vide affidavit dated 17/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi. PD(903)C
I, Sangita Bhen, W/o No.4286706Y Hav Chaudhari Nayanbhai Raysingbhai, R/o- Vill- Makanjhar, PO- Sathav, Teh- Mandvi, Dist- Surat, Gujarat- 394160, have changed my name from Sangita Bhen to Chaudhari Sangitaben, vide affidavit dated 17/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi. PD(904)C
I, Dadi Varalakshmi, Mother of No.6501202F Nk Dadi Nanaji, R/o- H.No. 2-81, Vill- Kattu Bolu, Post- Dimilli, Rambilli Mandalam, Dist- Visakhapatnam, A.P.- 531061, have changed my name from Dadi Varalakshmi to Dadi Varalaxmi, vide affidavit dated 17/04/2026 before Notary Public Delhi. PD(905)C

COSCO (INDIA) LIMITED
CIN : L25199DL1980PLC010173
Regd. Office : 2/8, Roop Nagar, Delhi-110 007
Website : www.cosco.in Email : mail@cosco.in
Tel. : 91-11-23843000 Fax : 91-11-23846000
BSE Trading Symbol: COSCO

NOTICE
Pursuant to the SEBI Circular No: HO/38/13/11(2)/2026-MIRSDPOD/1/3750/2026 dated January 30, 2026 all shareholders are hereby informed that a Special Window is open from February 05, 2026 to February 04, 2027, to facilitate re-lodgement of transfer request of physical shares which were rejected, returned or not attended due to deficiencies in documents/process/otherwise. Shareholders are advised to visit Company website www.cosco.in for SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) (Amendment) Regulations, 2026 https://www.cosco.in/uploads/investors/sebi_circular_ease_of_doing_investment_special_window_for_transfer_and_dematerialisation_of_physical_securities_1772005272.pdf. Investors are encouraged to take advantage of this opportunity by furnishing the necessary documents to the Company's Registrar and Share Transfer Agent i.e. Skyline Financial Services Private Limited at Office Add. D-153A 1st Floor/Okhla Industrial Area, Phase - I New Delhi-110 020. Email-id: admin@skylinertn.com, Tel no. 011-26812682-83, 40450193 to 97. This is for your kind information.

For Cosco (India) Limited,
Sd/-
Sudha Singh
Company Secretary & Compliance Officer
Place: Delhi Date: 17th April, 2026 Membership No.: A33371

1000150/2627

NOTICE INVITING BID
Odisha State Medical Corporation Limited (OSMCL)
In front of Ram Mandir, Convent Square, Unit – III, Bhubaneswar-751 001
Tel.: (0674) 2389050, Website: <https://osmcl.odisha.gov.in> , Email : drugs-osmcl@od.gosn.in
Bid Ref. No.: OSMCL/2025-26/Re -Tender Hydroxyurea/09 Date: 17/04/2026

Online Bids through e-Tender portal (<https://tendersodisha.gov.in>) are invited from eligible bidders for supply of Cap. Hydroxyurea (Re-Tender) as per the particulars mentioned below:

Sl. No.	Particulars	Date and time
1.	Date & time of release of bid	17/04/2026, 3 PM
2.	Date & time for submission of queries by E-Mail id - drugs-osmcl@od.gosn.in	20/04/2026, up to: 5:00 PM
3.	Date & time of Online bid submission	Start Date & Time 21/04/2026, 3 PM. End Date & Time 11/05/2026, 6:00 PM
4.	Date & time for submission of Tender Documents, Tender Document Fee and EMD amount as per section-IV of tender document	Start Date & Time 12/05/2026, 10 AM End Date & Time 19/05/2026, 11:00 AM
5.	Date & time of online Technical bid opening	19/05/2026, 11:30 AM
6.	Date of opening of Price Bid	To be informed to the qualified bidders

The bid document with all information relating to the bidding process including cost of bid document, EMDs, Prequalification criteria and terms & conditions are available in the websites: <https://osmcl.odisha.gov.in> and <https://tendersodisha.gov.in>. The Authority reserves the right to accept / reject any part thereof or all the bids without assigning any reason thereof. All notice will be published in the OSMCL website <https://osmcl.odisha.gov.in> . Hence the bidders are requested to visit OSMCL website <https://osmcl.odisha.gov.in> time to time for any published notice against the tender.

SD/-
Managing Director
OSMCL Ltd., Odisha

OIPR-10001/01121/2627/0001

दिल्ली विश्वविद्यालय
UNIVERSITY OF DELHI

Advt. No. R&P/317/2026 Dated: 17.03.2026

Online applications are invited in the prescribed Application Form from eligible candidates for appointment to the post of **Associate Professor** in the Academic Pay Level-13A of the 7th Central Pay Commission Pay Matrix, in the Departments of **Botany, Commerce, Computer Science, Economics, English, and Psychology**, University of Delhi. The last date for receipt of applications is two weeks from the date of publication of the advertisement in the Employment News. For more details, please visit the University website www.du.ac.in and click "Jobs and Opportunities" under the Head "Work with DU".

Any addendum/corrigendum shall be posted only on the University website.

cbc 21231/12/0004/2627 REGISTRAR

दिल्ली विश्वविद्यालय
UNIVERSITY OF DELHI

Advt. No. R&P/320/2026 Date: 17.03.2026

Online applications are invited in the prescribed Application Form from the eligible candidates for appointment to the posts of **Associate Professor**, in the Academic Pay Level 13A, and **Professor** in the Academic Pay Level 14 as per 7th Central Pay Commission Pay Matrix, in Department of **Computer Engineering, Electrical Engineering, and Electronics and Communication Engineering, Faculty of Technology**, University of Delhi. The last date for receipt of applications is two weeks from the date of publication of the advertisement in the Employment News. For more details, please visit the University website www.du.ac.in and click "Jobs and Opportunities" under the Head "Work with DU".

Any addendum/corrigendum shall be posted only on the University website.

cbc 21231/12/0010/2627 REGISTRAR

कार्यालय, नगर पालिक निगम, कोरबा (छत्तीसगढ़)
ई-प्रोक्वोरमेंट निविदा सूचना

क्र. 15/निर्माण/2026 दिनांक 10.04.2026

एकीकृत पंजीयन प्रणाली अंतर्गत सक्षम श्रेणी में पंजीकृत ठेकेदारों से निमालिखित निर्माण कार्य हेतु (Online) आनलाईन निविदा आमंत्रित की जाती है।

क्र.	कार्य का विवरण	अनुमानित लागत (रु. लाख में)	निविदा डालने की अंतिम तिथि
1.	नगर पालिक निगम क्षेत्रांतर्गत कोरबा जोन में नाली, सड़क, भवन एवं विद्युतीकरण कार्य का मरम्मत एवं संधारण कार्य हेतु वार्षिक दर निर्धारण (मरम्मत एवं संधारण मद) (प्रथम निविदा)	100.00	06.05.2026 (T.No. 188758)

उपरोक्त निर्माण कार्य की निविदा की जानकारी ई-प्रोक्वोरमेंट वेब पोर्टल <http://eproc.cgstate.gov.in> से डाउनलोड की जा सकती है, साथ ही निगम के वेब साइट www.korbamunicipal.in पर भी देखो जा सकती है।
॥ स्वच्छ भारत निर्माण में योगदान दें ॥

(हस्ताक्षर)
अधीक्षक अभियंता
नगर पालिक निगम
कोरबा (छ.ग.)

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given to the General Public on behalf of our client Mahindra & Mahindra Financial Services Ltd. that Mr. Ifran Saifi is the owner of Property bearing No. 88, admeasuring 45 sq. yards, Master Enclave, Kharsa No.190, Village Pasooda, Loni, Ghaziabad, U.P. vide Gift Deed dt. 26.11.2024 executed by Mr. Mustafa Ahmed, Mr. Gulzar Khan, Ms. Salma and Ms. Nizara, duly Regd. SRO-01 Ghaziabad as Doc No. 14372. All persons are hereby informed that above mentioned Owner wants to mortgage the said property and intends to obtain a loan from our client against the said property. If anybody has any objections upon the ownership of above owner over the said property, its Sale, mortgage/lien, and any other objections, kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address within 7 days of the present.
Kumar & Associates (Advocates & Consultants) 200, Ind. Fir. 23, Shivaji Marg, Moti Nagar, N. Delhi-15 legal@kandacol.com Ph: 011-43112527-28

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given to the General Public on behalf of our client L. ICICI Bank Ltd. that Kamlesh Batra is owner of Entire First Floor of Property No. 83, area measuring 130.05 square meters, situated at Priya Enclave, Near Karkandooma Court, Shahdara, Delhi. The said property, vide a sale deed dated 23.11.2020, registration No. 6378, executed by Meenu Mehta & Deepali Mehta. All Persons are hereby informed that above owner want to sale the said property to Anuj Aditya Gupta or his/her nominee who is taking a loan facility from our client against the said property. If anybody has any objections upon the ownership of above owner with respect of the said property he/she is sale (mortgage & any other kind of objection/ litigation, Charge etc., kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address within 07 days of the present.
Kumar & Associates (Advocates & Consultants) 200, Ind. Fir. 23, Shivaji Marg, Moti Nagar, N. Delhi-15 legal@kandacol.com Ph: 011-43112527-28

LOST & FOUND
Notice is hereby given that the Original Conveyance Deed Dated 11.08.2000 duly registered in the name of Late Smt. K. R. Vaikundam for DDA Flat No.12-A, Block-C-3A, Janakpuri, New Delhi – 110058, has been lost/misplaced in and around said Flat. FIR has been Lodged in Police Station, Janakpuri vide LR No. 239699/2026. Any person finding the documents or having claims should contact the inheritor i.e. owner Nirmala Subramanian # 9013351002 within 15 days. Any sale/ mortgage transaction by unauthorized persons will be deemed invalid.

NORTHERN RAILWAY
TENDER NOTICE

Sr. Divisional Mechanical Engineer, Northern Railway, Trainset Depot, Shakurbasti; for and on behalf of President of India, invites (IREPS www.ireps.gov.in) for the under noted work.

Tender No: 2589641SDSSB

Name of work	Comprehensive Annual Maintenance Contract (CAMEC) for Computer controlled Bench Top Rotating Disc Electrode Spectrometer available in Trainset Depot, Shakurbasti for a period of three years.
Approximate cost	₹ 24,60,300.00 including GST
Earnest money	₹ 49,300.00
Completion period of the work	36 Months
Date and time for opening of tender	11.05.2026 at 14:00

Website particulars notice board location complete details of tender can be seen www.ireps.gov.in e.i. 17.04.2026, 13:21 hrs.

No. -25.8.964.TSD.SB.DL 17.04.2026 1275/26

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दिल्ली विश्वविद्यालय
UNIVERSITY OF DELHI

Advt. No. R&P/319/2026 Date: 17.03.2026

Online applications are invited in the prescribed Application Form from the eligible candidates for appointment to the post of **Assistant Professor**, in the Academic Pay Level 10 as per 7th Central Pay Commission Pay Matrix, in Department of **Computer Engineering, Electrical Engineering, and Electronics and Communication Engineering, Faculty of Technology**, University of Delhi. The last date for receipt of application is two weeks from the date of publication of the advertisement in the *Employment News*. For details, please visit the University website www.du.ac.in and click "Advertisement - Departments" under the Head "Work with DU".

Any addendum/corrigendum shall be posted only on the University website.

cbc 21231/12/0008/2627 REGISTRAR

Sudden rain brings respite from heat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi saw an unusual spell of rain on Friday evening, as a blanket of clouds rained light to moderate showers, bringing down temperatures by 7-10 degrees in several places. The showers were scattered across different localities, with intensity varying from place to place.

Motorists and commuters were seen navigating wet roads as the rain continued through the evening hours. The change in weather came after what had largely been a warm and hazy day for the national capital. The unusual rain led to traffic jams in several parts.

Visuals from the national capital's Vikas Marg showed the impact of the unusual spell of rain on daily movement. Motorists and commuters were seen travelling as the showers continued.

The footage reflected typical scenes of traffic moving slowly on rain-slicked roads, with people using umbrellas and rain covers to protect themselves. The showers did not appear



PANKAJ KUMAR

to bring the city to a halt, but they did alter the pace of evening travel for those on the stretch. Explaining the prevailing conditions, meteorologists said the haziness and cloud cover are due to an induced cyclonic circulation over western parts of Rajasthan and neighbouring Pakistan.

"Dust particles from these areas have travelled towards Delhi-NCR, resulting in a layer of dust haze and a deterioration in air quality," they said. Earlier, the India

Meteorological Department (IMD) has upgraded its yellow alert to orange, expecting moderate rainfall, thunderstorms and lightning, along with winds of up to 40-60 km/h, during the night.

According to IMD data, Jafarpur recorded a fall of 8.6 degrees Celsius (from 30.2 to 21.6), while Narayana saw the steepest drop of 10.1 degrees Celsius (from 30.1 to 20).

Janakpuri and Pusa recorded declines of 7.9 degrees Celsius and 9.1 degrees Celsius, respectively, with Pusa also reporting the

highest wind speed of 48 km/h. Pragati Maidan, Jharoda Kalan and Najafgarh saw moderate falls ranging between 6.2 and 6.6 degrees Celsius. Pitampura recorded a smaller drop of 4.3 degrees Celsius, while Lodi Road saw a 9.1 degrees Celsius fall, along with 6.5 mm rainfall.

Ayanagar recorded a fall of 8.9 degrees Celsius and Mayur Vihar 7.4 degrees Celsius, along with 2 mm rainfall.

However, during the day, the city continued to experience the summer heat,

recording this year's hottest day with the maximum temperature settling at 41 degrees Celsius at Safdarjung, the city's base observatory.

The national capital recorded above-normal maximum temperatures across stations, with Palam registering a high of 40 degrees Celsius, 2.6 degrees above normal.

Ridge recorded a maximum of 40.2 degrees Celsius, 2.2 degrees above normal, Lodi Road at 39.4 degrees Celsius, 3.4 degrees above normal, and Ayanagar at 39.9 degrees Celsius, 2.2 degrees above normal.

Minimum temperatures also remained above normal at most stations, with Safdarjung recording a low of 24 degrees Celsius, 2.4 degrees above normal, while Palam settled at 25 degrees Celsius, 3.2 degrees above normal.<Ridge reported a minimum of 24.7 degrees Celsius, 1.7 degrees above normal, Lodi Road 22.4 degrees Celsius, 1.4 degrees above normal, and Ayanagar 22.8 degrees Celsius, 0.7 degrees above normal.

Govt plans flyovers on four key road stretches in south, north Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government plans to decongest four key road stretches in South and North Delhi by constructing flyovers and underpasses, officials said on Friday.

The Public Works Department's (PWD) integrated road corridor project includes the construction of flyovers at Mehrauli-Mahipalpur Road- including Aruna Asaf Ali Road, at Kanti Nagar bridge intersection, a flyover in Bawana and near Kanjhawala Chowk, totalling around 34 kilometres of road stretch decongestion.

"Traffic at these intersections experiences heavy traffic flow, resulting in frequent traffic jams. Construction of an underpass or flyover appears to be a feasible traffic movement. A tender has been floated in this regard," a PWD official said.

The Mehrauli-Mahipalpur road connecting to Aruna Asaf Ali Road near the JNU campus is approximately a 9 km long stretch. To ease traffic conges-



tion on this stretch, the department plans to construct a flyover, an underpass and a U-turn under the flyover.

"Between Kanti Nagar bridge and Telco T-point, which is connected to Mahipalpur road, approximately 6 km in length, also faces traffic due to slow-moving vehicles. At this point of congestion, the PWD plans to construct a flyover," officials added.

In North Delhi's Bawana Road, several complaints regarding heavy congestion due to the mix of slow-moving vehicles and cross movement during peak and even in non-peak hours cause heavy traffic

congestion, officials said. This 9 km stretch will also be decongested after the construction of a flyover.

The PWD plans to conduct a feasibility study for the construction of a flyover from Kanjhawala Chowk to Mangolpuri on Outer Ring Road in North Delhi at a cost of ₹3.44 crore. The study will be conducted for a period of four to five months to decongest a stretch of approximately 10 km in length.

Recently, PWD Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh held a review meeting with officials for the ongoing integrated transit corridor development projects of the Government.

Lok Sabha defeat spills onto Delhi streets; protest, rain choke roads around Parliament

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The defeat of the 131st Constitution Amendment Bill on Friday evening did not stay inside Parliament. It came out onto the streets. NDA women MPs gathered in protest outside the complex within minutes of the vote, and the demonstration, combined with heavy late-evening rain, choked major roads around Parliament for hours, leaving commuters stranded across central Delhi.



NDA MPs, including Kamaljeet Sehrawat and Kangana Ranaut, raise slogans during a protest amid rain in New Delhi

PTI

conditions worse, turning what was already a gridlocked stretch of central Delhi into a slow crawl.

The protest was triggered by the failure of the Constitution Amendment Bill, which sought to amend the existing women's reservation law by removing the condition that its implementation be linked to a census. The bill received 298 votes in favour and 230 against in the Lok Sabha, falling short of

the two-thirds majority required for a Constitution amendment to pass. The House was subsequently adjourned.

NDA leaders placed the blame squarely on the Congress. Union Minister Kiren Rijiju described the outcome as "unfortunate." Women MPs from NDA parties assembled outside Parliament in a visible show of protest, holding demonstrations that drew a large

security presence and effectively sealed off the surrounding road network during peak evening hours.

The bill's defeat came after a marathon 12-hour debate in the Lok Sabha on Thursday, during which the proposed amendment, including the provision to drop the census conditionality on the women's quota law, was argued at length across party lines. Despite the extended deliberation, the numbers on Friday did not hold.

For ordinary Delhiites, the political drama translated into something more immediate: a Friday evening commute that refused to move. Vehicles backed up from Sansad Marg toward Tolstoy Marg and Kasturba Gandhi Marg. The stretch along Rajendra Prasad Road near the Parliament annexe was particularly affected, with cars and autorickshaws queuing well past the usual security perimeter.

Puppy dies after late-night rescue attempt outside Tihar Jail

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Just past midnight outside the heavily guarded Tihar Jail complex, an emergency call set off a rescue effort that had nothing to do with prison security. It was for a trapped puppy. Hours later, despite sustained efforts by multiple agencies, the animal could not be saved.

The incident was reported to the Delhi Fire Service at 12.55 am on Friday. The distress call came from outside Gate No. 1 of the Tihar Prison Complex, where a puppy had fallen into an open pit.

What followed was a coordinated response involving the Delhi Fire Service and the National Disaster Response Force. Teams rushed to the spot with specialised equipment in an attempt to pull the animal out safely.

Officials said the rescuers worked continuously for more than three hours. The operation was carried out



The entrance of Tihar Jail, where a puppy was trapped and died after a late-night rescue attempt.

rescue operation unfolded quietly through the night. Officials focused entirely on retrieving the trapped animal without causing further harm.

Despite the presence of trained personnel and equipment, the situation did not improve. The rescue teams continued their efforts well into the early hours, hoping for a breakthrough. As time passed, the chances of survival reduced. The puppy eventually died before it could be brought out of the pit, officials confirmed.

The incident has drawn attention to safety concerns related to open pits and unattended construction spots in urban areas. Such hazards often go unnoticed until an accident occurs. While no official statement has been issued on the condition of the site, the presence of an open pit near a high-security zone has raised questions about maintenance and oversight.



DDA LAUNCHES TWO-DAY HARIT MANTHAN 2026

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Development Authority (DDA), in collaboration with the Udhmodya Foundation, the startup ecosystem of the University of Delhi, on Friday launched the two-day "Harit Manthan 2026," a national-level hackathon aimed at developing innovative solutions for urban biodiversity and green space management.

Through this event, the DDA is not only seeking solutions but also attempting to build a collaborative ecosystem around urban sustainability — one that bridges government institutions, academic communities, and young innovators.

The initiative reflects a broader shift in how public authorities are approaching environmental challenges: moving from top-down implementation to participatory, innovation-driven models that place citizens and emerging talent at the centre of problem-solving, the DDA said.

The hackathon will feature two parallel tracks — a Technology Challenge, focusing on digital and data-driven innovations for monitoring and managing green spaces, and a Policy Challenge, aimed at strengthening governance and planning frameworks for urban ecology.

Open exclusively to students from recognised universities and higher education institutions across India, the event invites teams of 2 to 5 members, encouraging interdisciplinary participation across fields such as technology, design, environmental sciences, and public policy.

Wildlife SOS Rapid Response Unit rescues Indian flapshell turtle

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

An Indian flapshell turtle has been successfully rescued by the Wildlife SOS Rapid Response Unit from east Delhi's Mandoli on Friday.

The massive reptile, weighing nearly 50 kg, was found with minor abrasions, officials said. "A rescue call came early morning, after a local family spotted a giant turtle struggling near a contaminated water body in their neighbourhood in Harsh Vihar, Mandoli. Recognising the danger, they carefully placed the animal in a container at their residence and immediately alerted Wildlife SOS for assistance," the NGO officials said.

reaching the location, carefully secured the turtle to ensure minimal stress to the animal. The reptile was then shifted to a transit facility in Delhi for further evaluation.

The Indian flapshell turtle (Lissemys punctata) is a freshwater species commonly found across the Indian sub-continent. Known for the flexible skin flaps along the edges of its shell, this species thrives in ponds, lakes, marshes and slow-moving rivers.

It is listed as 'Vulnerable' on the IUCN Red List and receives the highest level of protection under Schedule I of the Wildlife (Protection) Act, 1972, in India.

Upon initial examination, the turtle was found to have minor abrasions on its

shell and body, likely caused by proximity to the asphalt road and surrounding debris. No major injuries were observed, and the animal was released into a suitable habitat," according to a statement released by Wildlife SOS.

Kartick Satyanarayan, co-founder and CEO of Wildlife SOS, commended the family's response, which ensured the safety of the turtle.

He said, "Urban environments can be extremely challenging for aquatic species, especially when natural water bodies become polluted or degraded. We commend the family for their compassionate and responsible action in ensuring the safety of this turtle."

Capital to greet visitors with themed gateways

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Entering Delhi may soon feel less like crossing a border and more like stepping into a story, with themed gateways reflecting the identity of neighbouring regions and a citywide revamp of roundabouts planned over the next six months. In the next six months, 13 major entry points into the capital will be beautified based on themes linked to the geography and history of adjoining cities, a source said.

"If a person is entering from Gurugram or Noida, the entry point will carry elements inspired by the history and landscape of that region," the source said. "The work will be carried out by the Delhi Tourism and Transportation



Development Corporation. The aim is to create a distinct sense of arrival and improve the overall visual experience at these key locations," the official added.

Each entry point will be developed as a thematic space, drawing from the cultural and historical context of the connecting city, for example, the source said. "The idea is that every route into Delhi tells a differ-

ent story, giving commuters a more engaging experience," he added.

Alongside this, roundabouts across the city will also be taken up for beautification with landscaping, plants and decorative installations, he said.

"These spaces are being redesigned to enhance the look of the city and make public areas more visually appealing," the source said.

All accused arrested in brigadier assault case

ABHINAV KUMAR JHA
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police have arrested the four remaining accused who had absconded after the assault on Army Brigadier PS Arora, his son, and wife in the Vasant Enclave area of southwest Delhi, completing the roundup of all persons involved in the incident that triggered outrage across the city.

The four arrested have been identified as Surjit Singh, 36, Sunil Sharma, 53, Ashish, 32, all residents of Mehram Nagar, Delhi, and Satender, 35, a resident of Bhiwani, Haryana.

A Hyundai Aura car, white in colour, used by the group to travel to the spot on the night of the assault, has also



been recovered.

According to police, Surjit Singh is known to be the main accused, Satender alias Sonu, director of Chaudhary Aviation Pvt Ltd, who was arrested earlier along with Sanjay Sharma, 56, the other man found drinking inside the Mercedes that night.

On the night of the incident, all four newly arrested accused were sitting together in Mehram Nagar when

Satender called them regarding a quarrel in Vasant Enclave. They drove to the spot in Surjit's car. After the assault took place, they returned to their homes. When they learned a case had been registered, they fled. They were subsequently traced and arrested.

The arrests bring to a close the manhunt that followed one of the more widely discussed incidents of alleged police inaction to emerge in Delhi in recent months.

The incident happened on Saturday night. Brigadier PS Arora and his son Tejas Singh Arora, a 23-year-old IIT Delhi graduate, were on an after-dinner walk in Vasant Enclave when they spotted two men drinking inside a parked luxury car outside their resi-

dence. When they politely asked the men to leave, the occupants turned hostile and dared them to call the police. The family did exactly that.

When police arrived, Tejas alleged, they declined to record the complaint. One of the men in the car spoke to the responding officer on the phone, after which the officer said he would handle it later. Shortly after, more men arrived and assaulted the brigadier and his son for approximately 15 minutes, in the presence of police personnel who did not intervene.

Tejas sustained injuries to his face, neck, and palm. The brigadier's wife alleged that when she pleaded with the responding officer to step in, he told her he could act

only after his team arrived. After the attackers left, she alleged, the officer refused to take the family to the police station, saying: "You are not the kind of people who deserve to sit on the seats."

At the police station, the family alleged they were made to wait for about half an hour. The brigadier eventually drove his son to the Army Hospital himself for treatment and X-rays.

A case vide FIR No. 50/26 under Sections 115(2), 126(2), 351(2), 79, 191(2), and 190 of BNS was registered on the complaint of the brigadier's wife. The inspector who handled the initial investigation was found to have been negligent during the preliminary inquiry and was suspended.

US President Trump congratulates Sandhu on appointment as Delhi LG

SAGAR KULKARNI
■ Washington

US President Donald Trump on Friday congratulated diplomat Taranjit Singh Sandhu on his appointment as the Lieutenant Governor of Delhi and wished him success.

"Congratulations to Taranjit Sandhu on becoming the new Lt Governor of Delhi! As a seasoned Diplomat and former Ambassador to the United States, he has always shown deep commitment to strengthening the US-India relationship," Trump said on Truth Social.

Sandhu served as India's Ambassador to the US from 2020-24.



"Wishing him success in leading Delhi's progress, and furthering global ties," Trump said.

Sandhu was appointed as the Delhi Lieutenant Governor on March 5.

After retiring from the

Indian Foreign Service, Sandhu joined the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) months before the 2024 Lok Sabha elections.

The BJP fielded Sandhu as its Lok Sabha candidate from Amritsar, which he lost. (PTI)

IN FOCUS



Vice-President CP Radhakrishnan paying floral tribute to the portrait of former President Dr Sarvepalli Radhakrishnan on his death anniversary, at the Vice President's Enclave in New Delhi

India drops to 6th largest economy: WEO report

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

India has slipped to the sixth position among the world's largest economies in 2025. According to the latest World Economic Outlook (WEO) released by the International Monetary Fund (IMF), India is no longer the fourth largest economy in the world.

Although India has remained the fastest-growing major economy, the rupee has depreciated against the US dollar in recent months.

According to the latest WEO, in 2026 India's gross domestic product - the total value of all goods and services produced inside the country - will be around



\$4.15 trillion (up from \$3.92 trillion in 2025), while the UK's GDP will be \$4.27 trillion (up from \$4 trillion in 2025), and Japan's GDP will actually fall from \$4.48 trillion in 2025 to \$4.38 trillion in 2026. Despite India's nominal rupee growth of about 9 per cent during the year, the country's position has dropped. However, the rate of expansion was slowed in

dollar terms by a stronger US dollar and lower revisions to GDP under a new data series. According to estimates, the rupee depreciated from 84.6 to 88.5 per dollar in 2024 and 2025. Gains in domestic output have, therefore, resulted in a lesser increase when measured in dollars.

In rupee terms, at current prices, GDP was pegged at ₹318 lakh crore in 2024 and rose 9 per cent to nearly Rs 347 lakh crore last year. It is projected to increase almost 11 per cent this year to ₹385 lakh crore. Notably, the same IMF report clarified that this is a "nominal" shift. In terms of real GDP growth, India remains the fastest-growing major economy at 6.5 per cent for 2026, com-

pared to the UK's projected growth of just 0.8%. The report's medium-term projections suggest India will regain the 4th spot by 2027 and is on track for 3rd place by 2031.

India had secured the fifth rank in 2024, with a GDP of \$3.5 trillion, surpassing the UK, which stood at \$3.4 trillion. In 2026, India is expected to remain at the 6th position, and after that, it is expected to rise in the rankings. Earlier this month, the World Bank raised India's growth outlook for this fiscal to 6.6 per cent from 6.3 per cent, citing robust domestic demand and export performance. Similarly, the Asian Development Bank revised its estimate to 6.9 per cent from 6.5 per cent.

Adani overtakes Mukesh Ambani as Asia's richest

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Gautam Adani is now the richest person in Asia. The billionaire has overtaken Mukesh Ambani. This comes on the back of gains in Adani Group stock values. Ambani was Asia's richest for many years before this shift.

As per Bloomberg Billionaires Index latest data, Gautam Adani's net worth has climbed to \$92.6 billion, helping him secure the top spot in Asia and placing him 19th globally. Mukesh Ambani, who had long held the position, now follows closely with a net worth of \$90.8 billion, ranking 20th in the world. Interestingly, the share price of Adani Group companies surged on Friday. The Adani Power share price was up nearly 1 per cent. Adani Total Gas was up over 2 per cent.



Adani Green Energy gained 0.44 per cent while Adani Ports & Special Economic Zone were up 1.6 per cent. Many other Adani firms were also trading in the green.

While the gap remains narrow, the change highlights the volatile nature of global wealth movements. The latest shift between Adani and Ambani underlines how closely contested the top ranks remain, with market movements continuing to influence the balance of power among the world's richest individuals.

Modi and Shah likely to visit Ahmedabad

PIONNER NEWS SERVICE
■ Ahmedabad

As Gujarat gears up for the upcoming local body elections scheduled on April 26, political activity across the State has intensified, with parties ramping up their campaigns.

In a significant development, Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Union Home Minister Amit Shah are expected to visit Ahmedabad to cast their votes.

According to preliminary information, preparations are underway for the visit of both senior leaders. Prime Minister Modi is likely to cast his vote at a polling booth located at Nishan School in the Ranip area, while Amit Shah is expected to vote in the Naranpura locality. However, the official schedule for their visit is yet to be formally announced.

The anticipated visit has generated considerable



enthusiasm among BJP workers and supporters across the state.

The April 26 polls are being closely watched, and the possible participation of both Modi and Shah is expected to add momentum to the electoral atmosphere in Gujarat. Their visit is also seen as a strategic move to energize party cadres at both the state and grassroots levels.

Further details regarding the official itinerary of the leaders are awaited.

203 contractors face action in Noida over labour violations

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Noida

In a sweeping crackdown on labour law violations, the Uttar Pradesh Government has moved to cancel the licences of 203 contractors linked to 24 factories in Gautam Buddha Nagar. The action comes amid allegations of denial of worker benefits and irregularities in wage payments, officials said.

Authorities have also issued penalty notices amounting to 1.16 crore against the contractors, directing that the amount be paid to affected workers.

Alongside licence cancellations, the Government has initiated the process of blacklisting the agencies involved and is preparing for recovery proceedings in cases where workers' dues remain unpaid. The action follows findings by the Labour Department that several contractors had failed to comply with statutory requirements.

Additional Labour Commissioner Rakesh Dwivedi said some contractors were also under scrutiny for their suspected role in incidents of unrest during recent worker protests. "The identification of other contractors is still underway.

Strict action will be taken in all such cases. The Government is clear that violations of workers' rights will not be tolerated," Dwivedi said. Officials said the enforcement drive is part of a broader effort to ensure compliance with labour laws and restore



accountability among contractors and employers. In cases of delayed or incomplete wage payments, responsibility will be fixed not only on contractors but also on principal employers.

The Labour Department has made it clear that workers must receive all statutory ben-

efits, including overtime at double rates, bonus, and gratuity.

It has also directed that no deductions apart from Employees' Provident Fund and Employees' State Insurance contributions will be allowed from wages. Any violation of these norms will invite legal action. The crack-

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met with its Commander Major General Ali Abdollahi, according to Iran's official IRNA news agency. During the meeting, he discussed with the IRGC commander the steps taken under the framework for ending the war and their recent talks in Tehran. The two sides discussed the situation in the region and the prospects for peace and stability, Iranian official media said.

Munir stressed that ongoing efforts to end the war should continue.

Sources in Islamabad said that Munir held detailed discussions to bring Iran and the US to the negotiating table for the second round of talks in Islamabad.

"As a confidence-building measure ahead of more talks, Iran agreed to open the Strait of Hormuz," a Pakistani source said.

The US media reported that Iran was ready to address US concerns regarding nuclear material and, in return, get access to USD 20 billion stuck up due to restrictions imposed by the US.

It was also being reported in the US that the second round of talks may be held as early as Sunday. However, officials said that it is likely that the talks would be held next week. The timing and place of the next round of talks have not been confirmed yet.

The US and Iran held rare direct talks in Pakistan over the weekend aimed at ending their conflict, but the talks ended early Sunday without any agreement.

Meanwhile, Pakistan has started preparing to host the second round of high-stakes talks between the US and Iran next week.

TCS row: Probe deepens as accused seek bail

SIT has described Nida Khan as the link who suppressed complaints despite sitting on the Internal Complaints Committee and trained victims in Islamic practices.

SIT is investigating financial links, digital footprints and possible external funding. CCTV cameras from a resort where the alleged assault took place have been confiscated by the SIT.

Eight people including team leaders Asif Ansari, Shafi Sheikh, Raza Memon, Danish Sheikh, Tausif Attar and one Ashwini Ashok Chainani the Head of Operations at the TCS Nashik office have been arrested. A local court has remanded two accused in police custody till April 18. Nida Khan remains the ninth accused listed as absconding by police, though her family disputes this. The SIT is also examining possible funding links and POSH Act lapses at TCS.

Meanwhile, Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis, addressing the media in Kolkata on Friday termed it extremely serious and done under a module. He vowed, "We will bust the module. No one will be spared," and confirmed the state has sought assistance from central agencies including the National Investigation Agency (NIA) to trace wider trafficking or organised-crime angles. He lauded TCS top management for its commendable zero-tolerance response, immediate suspension of the accused, internal probe and strengthening grievance mechanisms.

Bill to give women quota fails

"I would like to appeal to all members of Parliament... Please reflect upon your conscience, remembering the women in your own families. Please do not deprive our nari Shakti of new opportunities," Modi had said.

Shah said this "insult to the women of the country will not stop here but will travel far and wide". "The opposition will have to face the wrath of women not only in the 2029 Lok Sabha elections, but at every level, in every election, and at every place," he said.

According to the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill, Lok Sabha seats were to be increased to 816 from the current 543 following a delimitation exercise based on the 2011 Census to operationalise the women's reservation law before the 2029 parliamentary polls. Seats were also to be increased in state and Union territory assemblies to accommodate 33 per cent reservation for women.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi, senior ministers Rajnath Singh and Amit Shah, Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi were among those present during the voting.

After the legislation was defeated during the voting, Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla adjourned the House for the day and announced that it would meet again on Saturday. The three-day special sitting was convened from April 16 to 18 for getting the Parliament's approval to the bill.

When the Constitution Amendment Bill was defeated, Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju conveyed to the Speaker that the government has no intention to move ahead with the two other bills -- the Delimitation Bill and the Union Territories Laws (Amendment) Bill -- as both the legislations were interlinked with the Constitution Amendment Bill.

Rijiju said the Opposition lost a historic opportunity to honour the country's women but the Modi government's struggle to give rights to women will continue. "We will not take rest till we ensure that the country's women get reservation in legislatures," he said.

"Now, the women of the country will not get the 33 per cent reservation in the Lok Sabha and state assemblies, which was their right. The Congress and its allies have done this not for the first time, but repeatedly. Their mindset is neither in the interest of women nor of the country," Amit Shah said in a social media post.

Earlier, in a bid to get the bill passed, while replying to the two-day long debate, Shah assured the opposition of an official amendment mentioning a 50 per cent increase in Lok Sabha seats in all states and Union territories if the opposition parties support the women's reservation bill.

"If anyone hears this discussion carefully, one will realise that nobody opposed the constitutional amendment for women's reservation. Everyone said 'we welcome this move'. But all the members of the INDIA group clearly opposed women's reservation," Shah said. The home minister said the Constitution provides for periodic delimitation and that includes provisions for

increasing the SC and ST seats in proportion to their growing population.

The home minister also said that there are 127 seats where there are more than 20 lakh voters and it goes against the spirit of the principle of 'one person, one vote and one value'.

"At some places, 45 lakh voters have one representative, and at some places, six lakh voters have one representative. As a result, the value of each vote is not equal across constituencies," he said, adding therefore there was a need for rationalisation of voters in every constituency. Shah also dismissed the claim that the Constitution amendment bill brought for providing women reservation in legislatures was aimed at delaying caste enumeration during census. "A meeting of the Union Cabinet in 2025 decided to carry out caste enumeration along with the census exercise and the process has already started," he said.

Iran opens Strait of Hormuz, US blockade...

Minutes later, President Trump shared the announcement in a post on Truth Social.

"Iran has just announced that the Strait of Iran is fully open and ready for full passage. Thank you!" Trump said, referring to the Strait of Hormuz. Iran effectively blocked the Strait of Hormuz following its conflict with the US and Israel, crippling global energy supplies. In response, Trump earlier this week announced the blockade of Iran's ports in the Strait of Hormuz. Trump said the Strait of Hormuz "is completely open and ready for business and full passage, but the naval blockade will remain in full force and effect as it pertains to Iran, only, until such time as our transaction with Iran is 100% complete. This process should go very quickly in that most of the points are already negotiated."

He also said Iran, with help from the US, is working to remove all sea mines from the Strait of Hormuz. He added that Iran has "agreed to never close the Strait of Hormuz again. It will no longer be used as a weapon against the World!" Trump said the deal with Iran is not tied, in any way, to Lebanon. "But we will make Lebanon great again!" he added.

The development comes a day after Pakistan's Chief of Defence Forces Field Marshal Asim Munir held talks with top Iranian leadership in Tehran as part of Islamabad's efforts to resolve the conflict between the US and Iran.

Munir, who led a high-level political-security delegation to Iran, met Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian, Parliament Speaker Mohammad Bagher Ghalibaf and top Revolutionary Guards commanders on Thursday.

Ghalibaf, who had led the Iranian delegation to Pakistan for talks with the US over the weekend, had urged the US to commit to any peace agreement in Lebanon.

Tamil Nadu Chief Minister and DMK President MK Stalin hailed the defeat of the bill and said the southern State defeated Delhi and that the DMK would together defeat Delhi's arrogance and the slaves who support that arrogance on the polling day, April 23. Stalin to lodge his protest had burnt the copies of the Bill a day earlier and his party held massive protest across the State.

PM to chair CAPF leaders meet

Senior officials describe the May conference as an opportunity to address both external threats and internal administrative challenges. The IB is finalising the agenda based on inputs from the respective CAPF Directors Generals.

"Intelligence sharing and real-time coordination, technology integration, drones, AI, cyber defences, joint training and operational synergy, policy gaps in counter-insurgency, border management and providing support to the state police forces in maintaining law and order," an official said.

The event signals the Centre's recognition of CAPFs as the "First Line of Defence" in an era of dynamic, asymmetric threats. Yet, it also occurs against the backdrop of potential morale issues stemming from the new Act enacted by the parliament for the CAPFs. Proponents of the legislation argue sustained IPS leadership is indispensable for national security; critics warn that unresolved cadre grievances could erode the very operational effectiveness the conference seeks to enhance.

This initiative reflects a broader evolution in India's internal security strategy: moving from ad-hoc coordination to institutionalised, high-level dialogue. Whether the conference successfully bridges strategic vision with ground-level concern or whether lingering administrative frictions persist will shape the effectiveness of India's paramilitary forces in the coming decade.

As India confronts multifaceted challenges to its internal and external security challenges as well, the May 2026 confluence, could mark a pivotal moment in balancing unity of command with institutional fairness ensuring that the forces safeguarding the nation's internal frontiers remain motivated, cohesive and operationally ready to meet the internal security challenges.

Number 16 mystery: Rahul leaves LS guessing

Rahul Gandhi was purportedly indicating that the TDP, being a party from South India -- a region that fears loss of seat share in an expanded Lok Sabha -- may not be on board with the Modi government on its plans.

He did not say that, though, when later asked about the "riddle of 16" outside the House too.

For the record, Andhra minister and newly appointed TDP working president Nara Lokesh, who is Naidu's son, had on Thursday thanked Prime Minister Modi for "assuring the nation on behalf of the NDA that no injustice would be done to any state through the delimitation exercise".

PM made fervent appeal for support to women’s bill

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi, in a last-minute appeal on Friday, urged all the Lok Sabha members to vote in favour of the Women's Reservation bill, saying "crores of women across India are watching," and appealed to lawmakers to come together to "create history."

In his plea, hours before the Lok Sabha voting on Friday, Modi said "I would like to appeal to all members of Parliament... please reflect upon your conscience, remembering the women in your own families. Please do not deprive our 'nari shakti' of new opportunities."

He also underlined that the time has come to ensure that half of the nation's population receives its rightful due in decision-making. Modi urged all members not to do anything that may hurt the sentiments of women across India.

"Crores of women are



PM Narendra Modi speaking in the Rajya Sabha during the Special session of Parliament in New Delhi on Friday

watching us... our intent and our decisions. I once again request that everyone support the amendments to the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam," Modi said in his appeal posted on social media.

He said the proposed legislation to ensure reservation for women in legislative bodies is a significant opportunity to do justice to them.

The Prime Minsiter said Parliament is discussing the historic legislation that paves the way for reservation for women in legislative bodies.

He said the discussions, which began on Thursday, went on till around 1 am this morning and resumed after the House reconvened at 11 am on Friday.

Modi stressed upon the point that the Government

has addressed all apprehensions and misconceptions relating to the legislation with facts and logic. All concerns and information gaps have been addressed.

"For nearly four decades, this issue of women's reservation in legislative bodies has been inordinately delayed. Now is the time to ensure that half of the nation's population receives its rightful due in decision-making. Even after so many decades of independence, it is not right that women in India have such limited representation in this area," he said. In a short while from now, voting will take place in the Lok Sabha and "I urge and appeal to all political parties to reflect carefully and take a sensitive decision by voting in favour of women's reservation", the prime minister said.

"On behalf of our nari shakti, I also request all members not to do anything that may hurt the sentiments of women across India," Modi said.

He said if this amendment

is passed unanimously, it will further empower women and strengthen the country's democracy.

"Let us come together today to create history. Let us ensure that the women of India, who are half of the nation's population, receive their rightful due," the Prime Minister said.

The Congress-led Opposition, particularly parties from southern states, has alleged that a flawed and biased delimitation law is being pushed through while using the women's quota as a "smokescreen."

Modi, in his post argued, "Even after so many decades of independence, it is not right that women in India have such limited representation in this area."

The Women's Reservation Act 2023, which provides a 33 per cent quota for women in legislatures, was enacted on Thursday to facilitate the proposed amendment being discussed in Parliament.

Although the Constitution amendment Bill became law,

it did not become part of the Constitution as it was not enforced by the Government. The notification specified April 16, 2026, as the date for the Act's provisions to come into force.

In September 2023, Parliament passed the 'Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam', commonly known as the Women's Reservation Act, to enhance women's representation in legislative bodies. The Act reserves one-third of the seats for women in the Lok Sabha and state legislative Assemblies.

Under the 2023 law, the reservation will not be enforceable before 2034, as it is contingent upon the completion of the delimitation exercise post-2027 Census.

The Government introduced three bills: The Constitution (One Hundred and Thirty-First Amendment) Bill, 2026, The Delimitation Bill, 2026 and The Union Territories Laws (Amendment Bill), 2026, to ensure the women quota can be implemented in 2029.

BJP attacks Pawan Khera after SC relief refusal

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The BJP sharpened its attack on Congress leader Pawan Khera on Friday after the Supreme Court refused to extend protection to him from possible coercive action in a case linked to his allegations against Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma's wife and asked him to seek relief from a competent court in the state. The ruling party asserted that the Supreme Court's order has exposed a "baseless and politically-motivated" campaign run by Khera.

In a video posted on social media, Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla accused him of relying on fabricated material.

"Pawan Khera has got a second jolt from the Supreme Court in the last few days.... Those documents (used by Khera) turned out to be forged, fake, photoshopped, AI-generated and in half an hour, the entire truth came out. Yet he continued with fake documents. In fact, he even presented forged documents in court," Poonawalla alleged in the video.

He further accused the Congress leader of relying on fabricated material aimed at the "political assassination" of Sarma and his family "at the instance of Pakistan".

"Khera used forged documents given at the instance of Pakistan in Islamabad in



order to conduct a political hit job — a political assassination — of Himanta Biswa Sarma and his wife, the daughter of Assam," Poonawalla said.

He alleged that the campaign was backed by Congress leader Rahul Gandhi and accused the opposition party's leadership of harbouring hatred towards Assam and its people.

"Now, it is clear as daylight that this was all done at the instance of certain forces inimical to Assam in order to remove the chief minister by running a hit-and-run campaign against him. And Rahul Gandhi came out in endorsement of this campaign. So the documents which were forged came from Islamabad and were supported and patronised by Rahul Gandhi," the BJP leader alleged.

"They (Congress) wanted to give up Assam in the 1960s. They have targeted the Assam gamosa. Rahul Gandhi has hatred for Assamese people and now, they have shown this hatred even by targeting the daughter and the son of Assam using fake, forged documents," he added.

Chadha targets AAP top brass over absence in Rajya Sabha

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Amidst the ongoing war of words between Raghav Chadha and top brass of the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP), he took a dig on Friday at his party's leadership drawing attention to the absence of key leaders in the Rajya Sabha while noting his own presence.

Chadha remarked that neither the party's leader nor its newly appointed deputy leader was present in the House, even as he, who was recently removed from the deputy leader's post, was in attendance.

"The leader of the party I belong to is not present in the House. The newly appointed deputy leader of the party I



AAP MP Raghav Chadha speaking in the Rajya Sabha during the Special session of Parliament in New Delhi on Friday

belong to is also not present in the House. I am the recently removed deputy leader, and I am present in the House. Thank you so much for giving me the opportunity to speak," he said.

He then went on to congratulate Harivansh Narayan Singh on his re-election as the Deputy

Chairman of the Rajya Sabha. Chadha was removed as AAP's deputy leader in the Rajya Sabha, with the party also allegedly curtailing his speaking time in the House. The development had sparked speculation about differences within the party over the decision.

Sanjay Singh is the leader

Kashmir valley on high alert ahead of Pahalgam attack anniversary

MOHIT KANDHARI ■ Jammu

The security grid across the Kashmir valley has been kept on high alert, and the security personnel have been directed to intensify cordon and search operations, particularly in sensitive areas across the Valley and along National Highways ahead of the first anniversary of the horrific Pahalgam terror attack.

26 civilians, including 25 tourists, were killed by Pakistan-based terrorists after ascertaining their religious identities on April 22, in the Baisaran valley of Pahalgam.

These directions were passed by the Inspector General of Police, Kashmir

Zone, VK Birdi, during a high-level security review meeting at PCR Kashmir on Friday.

The meeting focused on a review of security arrangements in anticipation of the forthcoming events.

IGP emphasised strengthening security arrangements around vulnerable installations, including prominent tourist destinations, to ensure a safe and secure environment for visitors. He further emphasised strict surveillance along inter-district boundaries to prevent any suspicious movement. IGP Kashmir directed officers to intensify surveillance on anti-national elements and to enhance area domination in their respective jurisdictions.



The meeting was attended by IG CRPF Srinagar Sector, IG CRPF KOS, Additional Commissioner SB Srinagar; DISG of CRPF (North Srinagar & KOS); DIG Traffic Kashmir; DIG CKR; DIG SKR; DIG BSF Ops Fr; DIG SSB Srinagar, DIG ITBP; all District SSSP of Kashmir Zone; Assistant Director SIB Srinagar;

Colonel GS 15 Corps; SSSP of PCR Kashmir, Traffic Rural Kashmir, Railways Kashmir, Security Kashmir, SDRF 1st Bn Srinagar, CID CI Kashmir, APCR, Traffic City Srinagar and other senior officers.

A police spokesman said that during the security review meeting, suggestions

Nation Focus



FOUR MAOISTS KILLED IN HAZARIBAGH ENCOUNTER

Four Maoists were killed in a gunfight with security forces in Jharkhand's Hazaribagh district on Friday, police officials said. The encounter took place in the Batuka forest area within the Keredari police station limits, following a tip-off, they said. One of the ultras killed has been identified as Sahdeo Mahto, who carried a bounty of ₹15 lakh on him. SDPO of Barkagaon, Pawan Kumar, said, "Four Maoists have been killed in the gunfight. No security personnel were injured in the operation." The development comes close on the heels of a fierce exchange of fire between a Maoist squad headed by Misir Besra, who carries a bounty of ₹1 crore, and police personnel on April 15 in Jharkhand's West Singhbhum.



VICE-PRESIDENT ON 2-DAY VISIT TO SRI LANKA FROM SUNDAY

Vice President CP Radhakrishnan will undertake a two-day visit to Sri Lanka beginning Sunday as part of India's efforts to further shore up ties with the island nation. In Colombo, Radhakrishnan will meet Sri Lankan President Anura Kumara Disanayaka, Prime Minister Harini Amarasuriya and other senior leaders.

"This will be the first bilateral visit by the Vice President of India to Sri Lanka," the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) said, announcing the trip. "Sri Lanka is a key partner in India's vision MAHASAGAR as well as its Neighbourhood First Policy," it said.

"The visit of the Vice President to Sri Lanka follows recent high-level engagements between the two nations and will further reinforce the millennia-old people-to-people ties that bind India and Sri Lanka," it said.

PM hails Harivansh’s re-election as Rajya Sabha deputy chairman

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Friday said the election of Harivansh as Deputy Chairman of the Rajya Sabha for an unprecedented third consecutive term reflects the House's deep trust in the journalist-turned politician and the valuable experience he has brought to the institution.

Harivansh, a nominated member, was elected unopposed as Deputy Chairman after the house adopted with a voice vote a motion moved by leader of the house, JP Nadda, for electing him to the post.

"Being elected for the third

consecutive term is a stamp of approval from the House on his experience, his inclusive approach, and his dignified work style," Modi said in the Rajya Sabha while facilitating Harivansh on his re-election.

Extending his heartfelt congratulations to Harivansh, Modi also noted the special significance of April 17, coinciding with the birth anniversary of former Prime Minister Chandra Shekhar.

Recalling Harivansh's close association with Chandra Shekhar, Modi observed that the Deputy Chairman had worked as the former Prime Minister's close associate throughout his political journey and authored books



on his life. "Beginning your third term on Chandra Shekhar ji's birth anniversary makes this occasion particularly meaningful," Modi said.

Recalling Harivansh's distinguished career in journalism, the prime minister praised his commitment to

high standards and impactful writing. Modi said that even during his tenure in Gujarat, he regularly read Harivansh's articles, which reflected deep study and firm conviction.

"His writing had sharp edges, but his speech and conduct always remained gentle and courteous," he said. bThe prime minister highlighted the pioneering work of Harivansh through his column series 'Hamara Sansad Kaisa Ho' (What should our Parliament member be like) during his journalism days. Emphasising the value of this experience, PM Modi suggested that new Members of Parliament from both Houses could learn

immensely from Harivansh's insights on parliamentary conduct, dignity, and responsibilities.

"Perhaps he never knew then that he himself would one day occupy this chair, but his writings covered the subject with remarkable depth," he said.

Modi also commended Harivansh's exemplary punctuality, disciplined life, and seriousness towards duties as key factors behind his universally accepted personality.

He noted that since becoming a Rajya Sabha member, Harivansh has maintained a full-time presence in the House, attending sessions even when not presiding over the proceedings.

Air India pilot sent back from US for allegedly possessing marijuana

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

An Air India pilot, travelling as a passenger on a flight from the national capital to San Francisco, was allegedly found in possession of marijuana and was sent back by the US authorities this week, according to sources.

The pilot has been derostered, one of the sources said.

"One of our crew members travelling from Delhi to San Francisco on 14 April, for positioning to operate a subsequent flight, was found to be inadmissi-



ble as per local laws and has been sent back to India," an airline spokesperson said in a statement on Friday. According to the sources, the co-pilot was allegedly found in possession of marijuana. The pilot was "dead-heading" to San Francisco.

An internal probe has been initiated by Air India, sources added.

Generally, 'deadheading' refers to a flight crew travelling as a passenger to his or her base station or to another place for duty.

The airline said appropriate strict disciplinary action would be taken as per laid-down company policies.

"Air India maintains zero-tolerance towards any violation of the law and upholds the highest standards of safety, compliance, and professional conduct," it said in the statement. Further details could not be ascertained.

Global Heat and Cooling Forum to focus on extreme heat

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Government officials, policymakers, scientists, development institutions, and industry leaders will convene here next week to discuss addressing the issue of extreme heat and sustainable cooling. The Global Heat and Cooling Forum (GHCF) 2026 will take place on April 20 and April 21 at Bharat Mandapam.

It is being organised by the



Natural Resources Defence Council (NRDC) in partnership with the National Disaster Management Authority, the Department of Science and

Technology, and the Coalition for Disaster Resilient Infrastructure (CDRI). The NRDC is an international non-profit environmental organisation with more than three million members and online activists.

The forum will focus on moving from frameworks to implementation, advancing scalable solutions that protect vulnerable communities while meeting growing cooling demand in sustainable ways.

In a statement, Manish Bapna, president and CEO of the NRDC, said, "Meeting the rapidly growing demand for cooling while keeping emissions under control will be one of the defining climate and development challenges of the coming decades. Governments and industry will need to act quickly to scale solutions that protect people from dangerous heat while building resilient and sustainable energy systems."

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

India on Friday said that the Bangladesh Government's request for the extradition of former prime minister Sheikh Hasina is being examined as part of ongoing judicial and legal processes.

Hasina, 78, has been living in India after she fled Dhaka following the collapse of her Government in August 2024 in the face of a massive anti-



Government agitation.

In his recent visit to New Delhi, Bangladesh Foreign Minister Khalilur Rahman, during his talks with

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, had raised the issue of Dhaka's request to extradite Hasina.

"The request is being examined as part of ongoing judicial and internal legal processes. We will continue to engage constructively on the issue with all stakeholders," Jaiswal said at his weekly media briefing.

The previous Government, led by Muhammad Yunus, had requested India to extra-

dite her as she was convicted of "crimes against humanity" for the brutal crackdown on the student-led protests.

Hasina and former Home Minister Asaduzzaman Khan Kamal were handed the death penalty by the International Crimes Tribunal, a domestic war crimes court, last year after convicting them of crimes against humanity during the crackdown on the anti-Government protests in 2024.

■ States Focus ■



MAMATA LEADS COLOURFUL ROADSHOW AHEAD OF POLLS

Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Friday led a colourful roadshow here in support of Trinamool Congress candidates ahead of the West Bengal assembly elections. People gathered on both sides of the road, and those standing on balconies and rooftops waved at the TMC supremo as she greeted them with folded hands. Banerjee walked from the Steel Market crossing to Bhiringi More, a distance of nearly two km, flanked by TMC candidates from Durgapur and adjoining constituencies. The chief minister was also greeted with flowers and scarves by party supporters amid chants of 'Didi Didi' and 'Joy Bangla'.



UDHAYANIDHI STALIN URGES VOTE AGAINST BJP IN TN POLLS

Tamil Nadu Deputy Chief Minister Udhayanidhi Stalin on Friday asked people to utilise the April 23 Assembly elections to "give back" to the BJP-led Central Government for not providing adequate funds to the state. He said people should retaliate by denying space to the saffron party and its ally, the AIADMK, and instead give a decisive mandate to the DMK. Addressing a poll campaign in Tiruppur district in support of the DMK-led Secular Progressive Alliance candidates, he claimed that the pace of development in the industrial district could be sustained only if the DMK returned to power. "Did the BJP Government provide funds or projects to Tamil Nadu? People should retaliate against the vindictive BJP for not providing central schemes or funds, he said."

Fadnavis alleges TMC added infiltrators to voter rolls

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Kolkata

Alleging that the TMC had conspired to include names of infiltrators in the electoral rolls, Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Friday claimed that while the party was objecting to the Special Intensive Revision (SIR), people whose names had been deleted for "rightful reasons" had not protested. Addressing a press conference in Kolkata, Fadnavis claimed the border areas of West Bengal have witnessed demographic changes due to infiltration, which was a threat to national security. "Those whose names were deleted for rightful reasons did not protest. Why does only the TMC have an issue? The Supreme Court made certain observations about

SIR but did not stop it, yet the TMC wanted to halt the process altogether," he said. "The SIR has constitutional provisions that till the end, if any wronged person seeks redressal, they can take legal recourse and appeal. I hail the Supreme Court order in this regard," he said, adding that illegal immigrants have been found to be involved in many incidents of attacks in the country. Fadnavis said an exercise like the SIR should be conducted every 10 years to remove names of the dead, shifted and unauthorised voters, alleging that the ruling TMC opposed it to win the upcoming assembly polls through "fraudulent means". Accusing the TMC of unleashing a reign of terror in West Bengal, Fadnavis alleged that BJP workers had been killed, tortured



and harassed, while women were brutalised after the previous elections. "This injustice will not be allowed to happen anymore. People have resolved that it won't be accepted anymore. TMC will be defeated this time," he asserted. Responding to TMC's allegations of attacks on Bengali-speaking migrants in BJP-

ruled states such as Maharashtra, he denied the claims and said it was worth examining why people from West Bengal were leaving the state for work. "The TMC Government should feel ashamed if people of Bengal have to leave the state for every kind of job. It reflects a failure on the part of the Government. I am not talking

only about high-end jobs, but all kinds of work," he said. Fadnavis said cities like Pune, Mumbai and Nagpur have thriving Bengali communities who celebrate festivals such as Durga Puja and Kali Puja in a grand manner, with pandals comparable to those in Kolkata. "Our party was founded in Bengal by Syama Prasad Mookerjee. We are very much part of Bengal. Our leaders in Bengal are all sons and daughters of the soil," he said, responding to a question on TMC calling BJP leaders "bahiragoto" (outsiders). Questioning TMC's claims of concern for West Bengal, Fadnavis alleged the state was marked by "atrocities, irregularities and corruption" under the ruling dispensation. He said the state had slipped in attracting invest-

ments, as industrialists are afraid to invest here because of the TMC. "The entire ecosystem is not industry-friendly in Bengal under TMC, if you take into account past happenings, including Singur. BJP will bring ease of doing business here," he said. "If an investor has any issue with ED, he can move to court. If an investor has any issue with TMC, he cannot redress the grievance as the ruling party is over and above the law. He has to surrender to their diktat. But not anymore," he said. Claiming that West Bengal was at the bottom in attracting foreign direct investment, Fadnavis said he was confident that the state would regain its position as a leading investment destination in the country under a BJP CM.

Bengal candidates see massive rise in assets since 2021

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

The TMC's Jangipur candidate Jakir Hossain had, in the 2021 West Bengal Assembly polls, declared owning assets worth ₹7 crore. Five years later, his 2026 poll affidavit showed assets doubling to more than ₹133 crore, making him one of the wealthiest candidates. And he is not alone. The BJP's Purulia MLA Sudip Kumar Mukherjee, who is seeking re-election from the same seat, saw an eye-watering 2,344 per cent rise in assets from ₹45 lakh in 2021 to ₹11 crore in 2026. Several prominent candidates seeking reelection in the first phase of the West Bengal Assembly polls have declared a sharp rise in assets, data compiled from their affidavits show. Trinamool Congress' Krishna



Kalyani, seeking re-election from Uttar Dinajpur district's Raiganj, saw his assets jump from around ₹5.8 crore in 2021 to over ₹20 crore in 2026, an increase of about 247 per cent. His party colleague Manas Ranjan Bhunia, contesting from Paschim Medinipur district's Sabang, has more than doubled his assets to nearly ₹15 crore. In contrast, the Leader of Opposition in the outgoing Assembly, Suwendu Adhikari, reported a decline in his movable assets. The 2026 poll affidavit of the

BJP leader, seeking reelection from Nandigram and also locked in a tough fight with Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee in her south Kolkata bastion of Bhabanipur, showed that his income has risen from about ₹8.13 lakh in 2020-21 to nearly ₹17.38 lakh in 2024-25. However, his movable assets are valued at approximately ₹24.57 lakh, a decline from ₹59.31 lakh reported in 2021. In some cases, the rise in assets has been steep in percentage terms. The BJP's Sukumar Ray, contesting from Cooch Behar

Uttar, saw his assets surge by over 300 per cent, while candidates such as the BJP's Chinmoy Deb Barman in the Tufanganj seat and the TMC's Baharampur candidate Subrata Maitra posted a rise in assets exceeding 150 per cent. However, not all candidates reported an upward trajectory in the value of their assets. Besides Adhikari, Bharatiya Gorkha Prajatantrik Morcha candidate in Kalimpong, Ruden Sada Lepcha, TMC's Suti candidate Emami Biswas and the BJP's Moyna candidate, cricketer-turned-politician Ashoke Dinda, have declared a fall in the value of their assets compared to 2021. The data, based on self-sworn affidavits submitted to the Election Commission, reflects the financial profiles of candidates contesting again in the April 23 first phase of polling.

Mamata alleges BJP using women's bill to push delimitation



West Bengal CM and TMC chief Mamata Banerjee addressing a public rally in support of the party candidates ahead of the State Assembly elections at Dinhat in Cooch Behar district on Friday

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Cooch Behar (West Bengal)

Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee on Friday alleged the BJP-led NDA Government at the Centre was using the proposed amendment to the women's quota law in Parliament as a front for the Delimitation Bill that would "break the country into pieces". The TMC will fight this Central Government's move at every step, she asserted at her party's poll rally here. The Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill to tweak the women's quota law, along with the Delimitation Bill and the Union Territories Laws (Amendment) Bill, to implement the proposed amended women's quota law in the Union territories of Delhi, Puducherry and Jammu and Kashmir, were introduced in the Lok Sabha on Thursday. Opposing the Centre's move, Banerjee alleged that "the BJP brought the Delimitation Bill while keeping the women's reservation bill at the front". "The BJP is trying to increase the number of seats in the Lok Sabha to

nearly 850 through the Delimitation Bill. It will break the country into pieces," the TMC supremo said. Accusing the NDA Government at the Centre of resorting to "illegality" in introducing the bills, Banerjee said, "As a former MP, I know that without a two-thirds majority, a Constitution Amendment bill cannot be passed." The TMC chief informed the gathering at the Cooch Behar rally that she has been informed by her MPs that an attempt was being made to pass the Bills with a simple majority. Maintaining that her party already has 37 per cent women MPs, she asked the BJP to emulate this and ensure its women candidates win this state assembly election. "After winning in Bengal, we will bring down their Government in Delhi," the TMC chief asserted. Banerjee alleged that Prime Minister Narendra Modi did not speak the truth about the development of north Bengal at a BJP rally last week. "The prime minister said nothing was done for the development of north Bengal.

IT raids TMC leaders, party hits back

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Kolkata

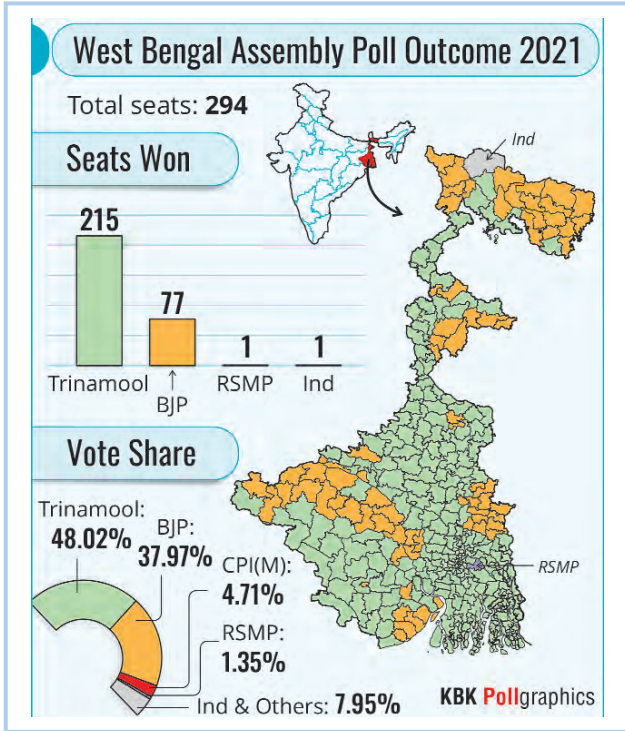
The Income Tax Department on Friday conducted searches at multiple locations in the city, including the residence of TMC MLA Debashis Kumar who is contesting from Rasbehari assembly seat, and Miraj Shah, a proposer of West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee's candidature from Bhabanipur constituency. The TMC alleged that the raids, conducted days before the voting on April 23 and 29, were intended to "harass and intimidate" the ruling party of West Bengal. Different groups of Income Tax officials started searching at the residence, the election office and several other properties linked to Kumar around



6 am, and the raids are continuing, an I-T official said. In simultaneous searches, the premises of Miraj Shah were searched at his Elgin Road residence in south Kolkata. Shah is known to be associated with a local educational institution and was among the four individuals from different faiths who proposed the TMC supremo's name in

the poll nomination. Debashis Kumar's close aide, TMC leader Kumar Saha's residence at Kalighat was also raided by the IT around the same time. The raids were part of a wider operation to unearth unaccounted, unaudited money flow in the run-up to the assembly polls covering several locations across the city, the official said.

Kumar had recently been summoned multiple times by the Enforcement Directorate in connection with a land fraud case. He was called for questioning at the CGO Complex in Salt Lake on April 1, 3 and 9, and had appeared before the agency. The ED aimed to determine whether Kumar had any financial transactions with a businessman, whose property was recently searched by the central agency, officials said. Deploing the raids, senior TMC leader Jaiprakash Majumdar said, "The vindictive nature of the Narendra Modi-Amit Shah regime stands exposed by the raids targeting the TMC and even prominent figures who are not directly associated with the TMC."



Debate over CM face in UDF not appropriate now: IUML

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Malappuram (Kerala)

Indian Union Muslim League (IUML), a key constituent of the UDF and a major ally of the Congress in Kerala, on Friday said the public discussions and arguments on who should be the CM candidate of the front was not appropriate. IUML leader PMA Salam said that it was his party's view that such public discussions on the matter would lead to discontent among the front workers and the general public. "Not against discussions, but it should not be done



publicly. It will harm the mental strength of the workers. It will create discontent among them. The leaders need to keep that in mind," he said. Currently, the arguments

and discussions which are going on are unnecessary, he said. He said that the IUML knows that the Congress was capable of deciding their leaders and they will do it at the appropriate time.

Salam also said that the League's view has not been sought on who should be the CM candidate. "The League will accept the Congress' decision on who should be the CM candidate. It will come as the UDF decision," he said. He also said that the IUML will not be making any demands with regard to the number of ministerial posts or a Deputy CM position. "We will discuss and take a joint decision," he asserted. The Kerala Assembly polls were held on April 9, and the results will be declared on May 4.

BJP slams Stalin over opposition to Union Govt policies

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Erode (Tamil Nadu)

Tamil Nadu BJP president Nainar Nagenthiran on Friday criticised Chief Minister MK Stalin for adopting a stance of constant Opposition toward every initiative and policy put forth by the central Government. The State Government's frequent protests are a result of a fear of defeat in the April 23 elections, he said. "Our chief minister starts an Opposition protest for every single thing. In these five years, he hasn't created any scheme for the people,



only tended to his own family's comfort. All he has been saying is there's competition between us and Delhi," Nagenthiran said.

Speaking at a press conference here ahead of Prime Minister Narendra Modi and Home Minister Amit Shah's visit to Tamil Nadu, he said

Modi is scheduled to speak at a "grand gathering" in Coimbatore on April 18 and Shah is scheduled to conduct a roadshow in the Modakkurichi constituency on April 19. Addressing the issue of Women's Reservation Bill, Nagenthiran defended the timing of the legislation, noting that it had been under discussion for over a decade and was necessary given the country's population growth since independence. He dismissed the state Government's claims that the bill was being rushed through Parliament.

AIADMK'S Palaniswami promises drug-free Tamil Nadu if voted to power

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Salem (Tamil Nadu)

AIADMK general secretary Edappadi K Palaniswami on Friday assured a drug free Tamil Nadu if his party comes to power in the upcoming Assembly elections. During a poll campaign at Sangagiri here, he said, "Students are addicted to drug abuse and time has come to put an end to it. Once the AIADMK assumes power, the sale of ganja will be com-

pletely eradicated. We will transform Tamil Nadu into a drug-free state". Reiterating that law and order has deteriorated significantly in Tamil Nadu, he alleged that there is no safety for women and the general public as a whole. "The situation has become so dire that even a two-year-old child is not spared, they are subjected to sexual violence and murder," he said, adding, "If women in Tamil Nadu are to be safe, the

AIADMK Government must be restored to power". He further said even the police force, whose duty it is to protect the people, are not safe under the current administration. "In the last six months alone, six police personnel have been murdered," he said. Palaniswami alleged that not a single day passes without incidents of murder, robbery, and sexual violence being perpetrated by drug addicts.



The AIADMK chief said despite announcing 525 electoral promises, the DMK has failed to fulfill even a quarter of them. He said nearly 2,000 "Amma Mini Clinics" were established across Tamil Nadu to provide medical care to people residing in rural areas. However, Tamil Nadu Chief Minister MK Stalin has "shut them down". Once the AIADMK Government is formed, the clinics will be relaunched, he added.

Regarding the NEET examination, Palaniswami said that the DMK has failed to secure an exemption for the state. "Tamil Nadu Deputy CM Udhayanidhi Stalin had previously claimed that there was a secret strategy in place to achieve this. However, Chief Minister Stalin, speaking in the Assembly, exposed the secret strategy by stating that, given the Supreme Court's verdict on the

matter, it is simply not possible to obtain an exemption from NEET. "This is a Government that came to power by propagating false information," he added. Stating that the April 23 Assembly election is a contest between a single family, "which survives by exploiting" Tamil Nadu, and the people of Tamil Nadu, Palaniswami said, "We must put an end to those who exploit eight crore people merely to sustain one family".

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Order Order

Supreme Court refuses to protect Pawan Khera, asks him to move Assam court



The Supreme Court on Friday refused to entertain a plea of Congress leader Pawan Khera seeking protection against possible coercive action till April 20 in a case lodged against him for levelling allegations against Assam Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma's wife.

The top court asked Khera to move a court of competent jurisdiction in Assam for anticipatory bail in the case.

At a press conference on April 5, Khera alleged that the Assam CM's wife, Riniki Bhuyan Sharma, had multiple passports and foreign property, which were not declared in Sarma's election affidavit for the April 9 Assembly polls in that state. The CM and his wife rejected the allegations as false and fabricated.

A bench comprising Justices JK Maheshwari and Atul S Chandurkar on Friday took note of the submissions of senior advocate Abhishek Singhvi, appearing for Khera, and asked the Assam court that will hear the Congress leader's plea to not consider adverse remarks, if any, made by the top court and the Telangana High Court in the case. The bench also asked the courts in Assam to take up Khera's plea expeditiously.

Allu Arjun moves Delhi HC for protection of personality rights



Telugu actor Allu Arjun on Friday urged the Delhi High Court to stop the unauthorised use of his name, voice and likeness by several entities for commercial use and impersonation. Justice Tushar Rao Gedela heard the lawsuit by the "Pushpa" star and indicated that the court would pass an interim order in his favour.

Seeking the protection of Arjun's personality rights, senior counsel Swathi Sukumar, representing the actor, submitted that his personality traits were being misappropriated for the sale of merchandise bearing his image and signature, operating voice-cloning platforms, AI chatbots and generation of obscene content. "There is a 'fake-call Pushpa' app... What is frightening is that there is an app where you can speak to the AI likeness of this person. This is fertile ground for any kind of scam that involves the plaintiff. That's the concern. It's his face video calling..." submitted Sukumar. The senior lawyer also informed that Arjun has several registered trademarks for his name.

The counsel for one of the defendant platforms hosting certain offending merchandise said the products have already been taken down. Lawyers appearing for Meta and Google also said that several offending links, including apps, have been removed.

Punjab wants MP Amritpal Singh to remain in Assam jail

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Chandigarh

The Punjab Government on Thursday filed a fresh plea before the Punjab and Haryana High Court, seeking confinement of Khadoor Sahib MP Amritpal Singh at Dibrugarh jail in Assam as his detention under the National Security Act comes to end on April 22.

Amritpal Singh has been kept in the prison in Assam in connection with the 2023 Ajnala Police Station attack case. In a separate order, the High Court on Thursday dismissed Amritpal's plea, challenging the third detention order under the NSA issued by the Punjab Government in April last year.

In the latest plea, a counsel representing the Punjab Government informed a bench of Chief Justice Sheel Nagu that the state intended to arrest Amritpal and continue his custody in Dibrugarh jail, citing intelligence inputs and security concerns. Amritpal's counsel, Iman



Singh Khara, said the state Government filed a plea that the lawmaker should continue to be lodged in the Assam jail. Khara said the High Court will hear the Punjab Government's plea on Friday. Amritpal has been under detention under the National Security Act since April 2023.

His detention is going to come to an end on April 22 and the state Government is unlikely to extend it.

According to the plea, Amritpal is likely to be arrested on April 23. The Amritsar Rural Senior Superintendent of Police, who filed the plea



EWS can't seek relaxations like SC, ST, OBC: Delhi HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court has held that aspirants belonging to the economically weaker section (EWS) cannot claim parity with the SC/ST/OBC categories for seeking age relaxation or enhanced attempts in relation to direct recruitment or employment under the Central Government.

A bench of Justices Anil Kshetarpal and Amit Mahajan observed that the deprivation faced by EWS individuals was not comparable to caste-based discrimination, and the policy not to extend age and attempt relaxation to the EWS category was not "mala fide, arbitrary or unconstitutional"



merely because it accorded different relaxations to different reserved categories.

The bench passed the judgment while dismissing a petition by certain individuals belonging to the EWS catego-

ry seeking the same relaxation in the upper age limit and number of attempts as available to candidates belonging to the Scheduled Castes (SC), Scheduled Tribes (ST) and Other Backward

Classes (OBC) in direct recruitment or employment under the Central Government.

Under UPSC's notice of examination dated February 19, 2019, candidates belonging to SC/ST categories were allowed age relaxation of up to a maximum of five years and candidates belonging to the OBC category were allowed age relaxation of up to a maximum of three years.

It also provided certain relaxation to them with respect to the maximum number of attempts.

In the judgment passed on April 16, the court observed that since the handicaps faced by socially backward classes and economically deprived classes were not the same,

different ancillary concessions and relaxations ought to be provided to the two categories.

It explained that the hardship faced by individuals under the EWS category arose from a lack of financial resources whereas the disadvantages associated with SC, ST, and OBC categories were rooted in "deep and long-standing social and educational backwardness".

"These groups have suffered discrimination and ostracism for generations, solely on account of their caste, such a disadvantage is structural and enduring. Caste, unlike economic status, is not a variable; it is fixed by birth and cannot be changed,"

the court said. It said a person born into a disadvantaged caste continues to face its consequences throughout life. Economic status, on the other hand, is fluid. It can change over time, within years or across generations. A person may move in or out of poverty depending on circumstances, the court added.

"For this reason, the deprivation faced by EWS individuals is not comparable to caste-based discrimination, which carries to some extent a long-lasting social stigma. The EWS category cannot claim automatic parity with SC/ST/OBC in ancillary considerations such as age relaxation or enhanced attempts," it concluded.

Assam Govt's arguments in Zubeen's case open

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Guwahati

Advocate General Devajit Saikia on Friday opened the Assam Government's arguments in charge framing hearing before the special fast-track court in the Zubeen Garg death case.

He said the Government side is likely to take six to seven days time to place its arguments to ensure that no

death in Singapore." "I placed our counter (argument) that there were no lapses in taking the sanction.

It is now for the honourable court to decide on it," Saikia said. On the rest of the charges in the case, he said special public prosecutor Ziaur Kamar and his team will place the arguments.

"It will take six to seven days time as we want to



loopholes are left. Talking to reporters after appearing before the court, Saikia said, "Charge framing hearing has been going on for the last 15 days now.

I commenced the arguments on behalf of the Assam Government side, and it will be taken forward by our team." He said a "technical issue" was raised in the court by some of the defence lawyers regarding the sanction received by the Assam Government from the Centre, as the case involves Garg's

ensure there is no lapse and no point is left unaddressed," the advocate general added. Garg had drowned while swimming off Lazarus Island on September 19, a day before he was slated to perform at the North East India Festival in Singapore.

A Special Investigation Team of Assam Police's CID probed the death and filed its charge sheet before a sessions court here in December, naming seven accused. Four of them are facing murder charges.

HC refuses to quash FIR against two students for religious conversion in UP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Prayagraj

The Allahabad High Court has refused to quash an FIR lodged against two class 12 students accused and booked under the Uttar Pradesh anti-conversion law for allegedly forcing their classmate to wear a burqa and attempting to convert her to Islam.

Dismissing the petition, a bench comprising justices JJ Munir and Tarun Saxena also took note of the 'disturbing trend' of young people 'thrusting' their religion/belief upon others, a tendency sought to be curbed by the UP



Prohibition of Unlawful Conversion of Religion Act, 2021.

"We must be alive to the situation that the Act of 2021

was enacted to curtail an emergent situation in society where certain persons go about not professing or propagating their religion, but

thrusting it upon others in the belief which somehow makes it to their mind the religion they believe in must be followed by others."

"If this kind of a trend comes to be seen amongst young people, it is all the more disturbing. This is time in their lives when they should be thinking more towards developing their skills in different fields of education and dedicate themselves in the service of the society and the nation.

The Act of 2021 was brought to curtail this emerging problem, which is heard from different quarters in

the country these days, and of which we must take judicial notice," the court added.

The court on Thursday said, "A statute that is enacted to curtail an emergent mischief, if stopped in its tracks at the very early stages of its enforcement, would bog down the statute and frustrate its purpose. This does not mean that false implications under a new statute are to be encouraged, but, at the same time, the purpose, for which the statute has been enacted, cannot be subverted by snuffing out prosecutions brought on tangible materials at the threshold."

HC says approvals to applications for higher FAR in Goa subject to ruling in ongoing case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Panaji

The Bombay High Court has directed Goa's Town and Country Planning Board to flag all pending and future applications for enhanced floor area ratio (FAR) and height permissions as subject to an ongoing legal challenge.

A division bench of justices Valmiki Menezes and Amit S Jamsandekar issued the directions after noting that as many as 255 applications are currently pending before the Board, while refusing to grant interim relief in a PIL against amendments to building regulations in the State.

The Goa bench of the HC on Wednesday ordered that all these appli-



cants, as well as those who may apply in future, be informed about the pendency of a petition challenging the amended Regulation 6.1.1 of the Goa Land Development and Building

Court denies anticipatory bail to Congress leader in sexual assault case in Kerala

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Palakkad (Kerala)

A court here on Friday dismissed the anticipatory bail plea of an expelled Congress leader accused of sexually assaulting a Dalit woman, officials said.

Mannarkad Special Court for SC/ST cases judge Jomon John rejected the plea filed by Prashob C Valsan, councillor of the 24th division of Palakkad Municipality. Last month, Palakkad South Police



Prashob C Valsan

registered a case against Valsan after a woman filed a complaint alleging that he had sexually assaulted her multiple times on the promise of securing her a job and mar-

rying her. She also alleged that the accused forced her to terminate a pregnancy and later began avoiding her. After the case was registered, Valsan went into hiding. During the Assembly election period, the BJP and CPI(M) raised the issue, claiming that Valsan was a close aide of expelled Congress MLA Rahul Mamkootathil, also facing similar charges.

Following the filing of the anticipatory bail plea, the complainant approached the

court seeking that a decision be taken only after hearing her. On Thursday, the court summoned and heard the complainant.

The prosecution argued that Valsan is an influential person who could tamper with evidence and influence the complainant if granted anticipatory bail.

It also submitted that he had not cooperated with the investigation and had been absconding for the past three weeks.

Court seeks ED's response on Jacqueline Fernandez's plea to turn approver

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A Delhi court on Friday sought a response from the Enforcement Directorate on a plea by actor Jacqueline Fernandez seeking to turn approver in a ₹200 crore money laundering case involving alleged conman Sukesh Chandrasekar.

Special Judge Prashant Sharma issued notice to the



agency and posted the matter for further proceedings on April 20. Fernandez, who was summoned by the ED several times in connection with the investigation, was named as an accused for the first time in a supplementary charge sheet filed by the agency. On July 3, last year, the Delhi High Court dismissed her petition for quashing the Enforcement Case Information Report (ECIR) in the money laundering case.

Two months later, the Supreme Court refused to interfere with the High Court's order. Delhi Police had booked Chandrasekar for allegedly duping the spouses of former promoters of Ranbaxy, Shivinder Singh and Malvinder Singh, of ₹200 crore. There are other ongoing investigations against him in several cases across the country.

Chandrasekar and his wife, Leena Paulose, facing proceedings in a money laundering case, were arrested by the Delhi Police along with others.



cerned district and the divisional forest officer.

It said these officers shall ensure continuous and effective monitoring of the CCTV feeds by designating appropriate officers.

"It can't be gainsaid that the issues involved are of great concern in as much as the rampant illegal mining activities in the river bed have created an environmental crisis and havoc in the National Chambal Gharial Sanctuary causing a grave risk to the very project of gharial preservation of which the State

Governments themselves were proponents and were under an obligation to foster and promote," Justice Mehta said while pronouncing the order.

The bench directed the authorities in these three states to initiate prompt and necessary action under law if any instance of illegal mining or allied activities comes to light.

It said the authorities shall ensure seizure of vehicles or machinery found involved in illegal sand mining and also initiate prosecution of persons

involved in it. The bench, which passed several other directions, posted the matter for hearing on May 11.

The top court passed the order in a suo motu case titled 'In Re: Illegal sand mining in the National Chambal Sanctuary and threat to endangered aquatic wildlife'.

The National Chambal Sanctuary, also called the National Chambal Gharial Wildlife Sanctuary, is a 5,400-sq km tri-state protected area.

Besides the endangered gharial, it is home to the red-crowned roof turtle and the endangered Ganges river Dolphin.

Located on the Chambal river near the tripoint of Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh and Uttar Pradesh, the sanctuary was first declared a protected area in Madhya Pradesh in 1978 and now constitutes a long and narrow eco-reserve co-administered by the three States.



Editor's
TAKE

Israel-Lebanon 10-day ceasefire: A fragile pause

A 10-day ceasefire between Israel and Lebanon, announced by Trump, offers a fleeting pause, but with past instances of Israeli defiance, its credibility remains uncertain

There is yet another positive development in the ongoing volatile situation in West Asia. US President Donald Trump has announced a 10-day ceasefire between Israel and Lebanon, brokered by him. It would be premature to celebrate it as a definite step towards lasting peace in the region, but it does provide a break from ongoing attacks and counter-attacks that are killing innocent people. With over a million displaced in Lebanon, even a temporary halt allows humanitarian relief and creates diplomatic space. It also offers a sigh of relief for displaced Lebanese families, who are returning hesitantly to their homes reduced to rubble by air attacks. It is indeed a window of hope.

Yet, the big question is: will this last? And if it does, what happens after it is over? Will it lead to lasting peace? The key player here is not the US, which has brokered this ceasefire, but Israel, which remains adamant about continuing hostilities.

Since the US and Iran agreed to a month-long ceasefire, Israel opened its Lebanon front to technically avoid violating it, while at the same time provoking Iran into launching a counter-offensive. Within hours of the US-Iran ceasefire, Israel reportedly sabotaged it with a massive 100-missile strike on Lebanon, killing over 250 people. Iran's swift retaliation almost jeopardised the truce.

That said, this 10-day window is significant. It indicates that the conflict has reached a point where active players are exhausted and seeking relief, even if it is momentary. More crucially, Tehran has made de-escalation in Lebanon a precondition for engaging in talks. In that sense, the ceasefire is less a standalone event and more a piece of a larger West Asian puzzle. However, its credibility remains deeply uncertain. Ceasefires in the Israel-Lebanon conflict have historically been fragile. The involvement of Hezbollah further complicates matters, as it is aligned with Iran rather than purely Lebanese state interests. The key question, therefore, is how credible Trump's assurances are and whether they can be taken at face value. While the US remains Israel's principal ally, Netanyahu has not always complied with Washington. Past instances of Israeli defiance show that US influence, though significant, is not absolute. If Israel perceives its security interests to be at stake, it is unlikely to adhere to a time-bound ceasefire, regardless of who announces it. Analysts have already warned that any breach could derail parallel US-Iran negotiations, which remain tentative. The linkage between Lebanon and broader regional diplomacy means that failure here would have consequences far beyond its borders. The conflict has already triggered economic anxieties, disrupted supply chains, and raised concerns about maritime security.

A sustained ceasefire could stabilise energy markets and reduce the risk of a wider confrontation involving Iran and US forces in the region. Conversely, a collapse would intensify polarisation, draw in more actors, and deepen the instability that has long defined West Asia.

India-Iran: A partnership of strategic necessity

As sanctions and regional instability redraw global equations, India-Iran relations – anchored in connectivity, energy, and strategic autonomy – have evolved into a pragmatic alignment where calculated statecraft takes precedence over sentiment



SANTHOSH
MATHEW

India and Iran share a relationship that stretches across centuries-two of the world's oldest and most majestic civilisations, bound not merely by trade routes but by cultural memory and strategic necessity. For years, this partnership carried a quiet resilience. It was only after 2019 that visible shifts began to emerge. India recalibrated its global engagements under mounting geopolitical pressures, but it would be naive to assume that Iran has not forgotten the depth of past cooperation. International relations are not driven by nostalgia; they are governed by national interests, survival instincts, and calculated statecraft.

In today's globalised economy, no country-however resource-rich-can afford isolation. Iran, despite its vast oil reserves, finds itself constrained by sanctions, strategic rivalries, and regional instability. It is within this context that India's importance becomes not just relevant, but indispensable. The Chabahar Port stands as a powerful symbol of this interdependence. Located on Iran's south-eastern coast, it is far more than a commercial hub; it is Iran's economic lifeline. Under heavy sanctions imposed by Western powers, particularly the United States, Iran has struggled to maintain access to global markets. India's investment and operational involvement in Chabahar have provided Tehran with a crucial window to the world. Beyond trade, the port facilitates connectivity to Afghanistan and Central Asia, bypassing Pakistan entirely. This not only secures India's strategic interests but also ensures a steady stream of transit revenue for Iran.

Energy remains the lifeblood of the global economy, and Iran's oil needs reliable buyers. India has long been one of the most trusted customers of Iranian crude. Even amid international pressure, India explored mechanisms to sustain this trade. The rupee-rial arrangement, for instance, allowed transactions to continue without reliance on the US dollar, offering Iran a critical cushion against foreign exchange constraints. Such financial ingenuity reflects not sentimentality but pragmatic diplomacy.

The International North-South Transport Corridor (INSTC) further deepens this partnership. By linking India with Russia and Europe through Iran, the corridor transforms Iran into a pivotal transit hub. In times of economic uncertainty and shifting alliances, this strategic geography becomes a source of leverage and survival for Tehran.

Equally significant is India's role in sustaining Iran's domestic economy during difficult times. Essential commodities such as basmati



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FOR GLOBAL
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rice, tea, and sugar from India help stabilise Iranian markets. When Western pharmaceutical supplies become inaccessible, India-the "pharmacy of the world"-steps in with affordable, life-saving medicines. This humanitarian-economic dimension adds another layer to the bilateral relationship.

India's diplomatic maturity in handling such complexities deserves attention. Under the stewardship of External Affairs Minister S. Jaishankar, India has demonstrated a rare ability to maintain balanced ties with adversarial blocs. It engages Iran while strengthening relations with Israel and the United States. This doctrine of strategic autonomy allows India to act not as a subordinate ally, but as an independent pole in global politics. Even critics like Shashi Tharoor have acknowledged the professionalism underpinning this approach.

Security concerns in the Arabian Sea and the Red Sea further reinforce the need for Indo-Iranian cooperation. Maritime attacks and regional conflicts disrupt trade routes that are vital to both nations. Ensuring the safety of shipping lanes, particularly through critical choke-points like the Strait of Hormuz, requires coordination and dialogue. In such turbulent conditions, Iran increasingly recognises India as a stable and reliable partner-one that does not abandon its friends in times of crisis.

Speculation often fills the gaps left by secrecy in international affairs. There are whispers of discreet assistance-technical, logistical, even humanitarian-extended by India to Iran, including support for infrastructure such as water purification systems or port development. While such claims remain unverified, they reflect a broader perception: that India's engagement with Iran is deeper than what meets the eye.

Meanwhile, Pakistan's credibility deficit is well known, particularly in Tehran. In contrast, India's consistent and measured approach has earned it a degree of trust that few others enjoy. There are even suggestions that, in the context of escalating tensions between Iran and the United States, Tehran sees New Delhi as a potential mediator-capable of playing a constructive role in de-escalation.

At the same time, global conflicts carry economic consequences back home. A prolonged Iran-US confrontation could significantly impact Indian corporate giants like Reliance Industries. Its Jamnagar refinery, the largest in

the world, accounts for a substantial share of India's petroleum exports. Disruptions in global supply chains, currency fluctuations, and policy interventions-such as restrictions on exports to prioritise domestic supply-could result in massive financial losses. This underscores the delicate balance India must maintain between strategic diplomacy and economic stability.

Ultimately, India-Iran relations are not a tale of emotional solidarity but of mutual necessity. Iran needs India for economic access, trade, and diplomatic balance. India, in turn, engages Iran as part of a broader geopolitical calculus-securing energy routes, countering regional adversaries, and expanding its strategic footprint.

Dharma diplomacy, as it is often described, is not about moral grandstanding. It is about calibrated restraint, principled engagement, and the ability to act with both wisdom and realism. In a world increasingly defined by conflict and fragmentation, India's approach offers a model of balance-one that even a nation like Iran, under immense pressure, appears to be seeking.

PIC TALK



Humayun's Tomb in Delhi, illuminated under the night sky, an enduring symbol of India's rich cultural heritage on World Heritage Day. PHOTO: PANKAJ KUMAR

DIGITAL EXPERIENCE

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WOMEN'S RESERVATION MUST BE DELINKED FROM DELIMITATION DEBATE

The three-day special Parliament session on Bills concerning amendments to the Women's Reservation Act and the Delimitation Bill is likely to be stormy, as battle lines between rival benches are clearly drawn. The timing of the introduction of these important Bills is politically significant, and one cannot expect discussions to rise above partisan considerations.

It defies logic to argue that these amendments are so urgent that they cannot wait a few more days, especially after being delayed for decades.

For the smooth passage of the Women's Reservation Act, it must be delinked from the delimitation exercise. The Delimitation Bill, owing to its inherent complexity, requires a far more detailed and thoughtful

debate.

If genuine political resolve exists-which presently appears lacking-there is no need to wait for constitutional amendments to create greater opportunities for women in legislative bodies. The fact that women constitute less than 15 per cent in Parliament and around 10 per cent in State Assemblies clearly reflects the urgent need for corrective measures.

Women's representation should not become a casualty of political bargaining or procedural bundling.

A focused and sincere approach is essential to ensure meaningful progress in this long-pending reform.

SANKARA RAO | ANDHRA PRADESH

Please send your letter to the info@dailypioneer.com. In not more than 250 words. We appreciate your feedback.

When stress is not just a passing phase



ASHA IYER
KUMAR

2ND OPINION

I remember the initial days of recognising 'something abnormal' in the way I was living my life. My first instinct was to dismiss it as my imagination, and then, when the condition persisted, I chalked it up to the S-word that is casually woven into our lives-stress. "Who is not stressed these days?" is the modern-day maxim, making the word reductive and the condition itself more dangerous than it seems. What in the beginning looked like a common-place response to everyday pressures slowly settled in, taking residence in my nervous system and body, and before I knew it, the condition had crossed the line. From mere stress, it had leapt into a territory that became a long drawn-out health crisis. Prolonged stress, I realised, was not a state that moves on with time. It persists, finds places in our system to lodge, and slowly becomes a health chal-

lenge of unthinkable proportions. Stress by itself may not be dangerous if it rises and recedes with work and life situations, but when it becomes a habit to be constantly on edge, it turns into an anxiety disorder, putting us in a spiral of psychosomatic illnesses. The difficulty, however, is not in understanding this intellectually. It lies in recognising the moment of shift and taking action to prevent further deterioration. Because the line does not announce itself. It slips in quietly. One day, you are dealing with pressure; another day, you are unable to return to yourself even after the pressure has passed. What was once a reaction becomes a state of being. And that is perhaps the first sign that something has altered beneath the surface.

It is not always the large breakdowns that warn us. It is often the smaller, more persistent disturbances-sleep that refuses to come easily; a mind that will not switch off; a body that feels perpetually tense, as though bracing for something unnamed; irritability that has no clear cause; a heaviness that lingers through the day; the loss of interest in things that once offered ease; and a quiet dependence on distractions, stimulants, or substances to feel momentarily better. None of these seem alarming in isolation. Together, they form a pattern we are too quick to overlook.

We tell ourselves it is a phase, that it will pass. We tell ourselves this is simply what modern living looks like. In

doing so, we normalise what is, in truth, a slow erosion of well-being. From being a hindrance, it becomes a series of ailments that can leave one indisposed both mentally and physically. Pre-emptive care, in this context, is not a grand corrective step taken after collapse. It is a series of small acknowledgements made before we get there. It begins with taking our own signals seriously, instead of dismissing them as weakness or exaggeration. It requires us to step back from the pace we have unquestioningly accepted and ask whether it is sustainable for the mind and body that must carry it.

It may mean allowing ourselves pauses without guilt, setting boundaries, and speaking openly instead of remaining silent. Most importantly, it means seeking help early and restoring basic rhythms-rest, movement, and quiet-without the pressure to be constantly productive.

Mental health is often addressed only in crisis, but its preservation lies in early attention. Not everything overwhelming is a disorder, yet not everything persistent is merely stress. Recognising this difference is crucial. When stress becomes a way of living rather than a response, it turns into an early warning. How we respond to it can shape our long-term well-being.

The writer is a Dubai-based author, columnist and children's writing coach

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Intelligence without restraint

God made man in His image and likeness, says the Gospel, and the Vedas affirm that man was endowed with divinity as well. Now, man is creating a machine, in silicon and code, that would replicate him in thought and action.

What began as simulation now edges towards sensation-a paradox where machines begin to mimic not just cognition, but presence. Worryingly, this is now moving beyond the surreal into the realm of touch and feel. Intelligence, human and artificial, could soon become indistinguishable.

Are we not witnessing the ongoing Trump-Iran dynamic, which thrives on unpredictability and impulse, where signalling strength often means amplifying uncertainty? Each side, in trying to outwit the other, intuitively the opponent's thought pattern, adding layers of complexity rather than clarity of purpose. Juxtapose this with the dilemma faced by AI firm Anthropic over its Claude Mythos. A system designed to probe vulnerabilities now risks becoming inseparable from the very threat it scans. Excessive anticipation of an opponent's moves, when internalised, triggers aggression rather than analysis.

R NARAYANAN | NAVI MUMBAI

A fair path for India's delimitation

India's debate on delimitation and women's reservation has reopened a deeper question: how should representation be fairly distributed in a country where some states controlled population growth while others did not? As the government pushes for expanding seats alongside future reservation, concerns about regional imbalance have intensified. A rigid population-based system risks rewarding higher growth while penalising states that invested in education, healthcare, and family planning.

A more balanced approach lies not in reducing representation, but in refining how additional seats are created and distributed. The key principle must remain intact: every citizen's vote carries equal value. No existing seats should be reduced. Instead, Parliament can be expanded, creating a fresh pool of seats. These additional seats can be allocated through a dual formula-70 per cent based on population, preserving fairness, and 30 per cent based on a population performance index. This ensures responsible states are rewarded, not sidelined. With safeguards like caps on excessive gains and expert oversight, delimitation can evolve into a tool that promotes responsible governance and strengthens national unity.

RS NARULA | PATILA

Social media's dangerous new reality

The proposed expansion of the Lok Sabha to nearly 850 members raises a fundamental concern: is this genuine democratic reform or a politically convenient adjustment?

While increasing seats is justified in the name of better representation, the current functioning of Parliament already suffers from limited debate time, fewer sitting days, and constrained participation of Members of Parliament. Expanding numbers without addressing these structural issues risks weakening deliberation rather than strengthening it.

The move also coincides with the implementation of the Women's Reservation Bill. It appears that increasing seats may allow reservation to be introduced without requiring existing Members of Parliament to relinquish constituencies. This raises questions about whether the reform is driven by principle or political accommodation.

A larger House, without institutional reform, may become less effective and more symbolic. True democratic strengthening lies not in numbers, but in improving the quality of legislative functioning-ensuring meaningful debate, accountability, and participation.

MOHIT RAWAL | UJJAIN

Nari Shakti at the heart of new India’s MSME revolution

The Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam told the world that India’s women belong in its Parliament. The MSME policies of this government are telling the world that India’s women belong in its marketplaces, factories, export chains, innovation hubs, and boardrooms



SHOBHA KARANDLAJE

When Prime Minister Narendra Modi stood before Parliament and championed the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam in September 2023, reserving one-third of seats in the Lok Sabha and State Legislatures for women, he articulated a conviction that India cannot rise unless its women rise with it. That same intent is visible every single day in the work done by the Government in the MSME sector.

The MSME sector is often called the backbone of India’s economy. But if we look closely, at its heart stands the quiet force of women entrepreneurs. Today, that quiet force is finally receiving the national recognition, institutional support, and policy momentum it has always deserved.

The numbers tell the story

The scale of women’s participation in India’s MSME ecosystem is constantly expanding. As of early 2026, over 3.11 crore women-led enterprises are registered on the Udyam Registration Portal and the Udyam Assist Platform. As per these registrations, women-owned enterprises account for approximately 40 per cent of all registered MSMEs in the country and play a significant role in employment generation.

One of the most consequential reforms for women entrepreneurs has been the simplification of registration through the Udyam Registration Portal. Fully online, paperless, and based on self-declaration, it removed the bureaucratic gatekeeping that disproportionately disadvantaged women. The Udyam Assist Platform, launched in January 2023, went further in reaching women in the informal economy who lacked PAN or GSTN and brought them within the ambit of Priority Sector Lending and government scheme benefits.

This is the direct result of a government that chose to place women at the centre of its economic agenda as drivers of growth.

Nari Shakti as an economic force

Prime Minister Modi has consistently emphasised that empowering women is not merely a social obligation but a national strategy. In his words, when women are



WE ARE NOT THERE YET. BUT UNDER THIS GOVERNMENT’S WATCH, AND WITH THIS PRIME MINISTER’S COMMITMENT, WE ARE UNMISTAKABLY ON OUR WAY

The writer is Union Minister of State for Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises and Labour and Employment

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The Pioneer

empowered, families are empowered, and when families are empowered, the nation grows from strength to strength.

The Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam is the most visible expression of this philosophy in the political sphere. In the economic sphere, especially in the MSME sector, the government’s commitment to women has been translated into a comprehensive, multi-pronged policy framework that addresses credit, skill, market access, recognition, and dignity.

A policy architecture built for women

The Ministry of MSME has systematically woven women’s empowerment into every major programme and scheme it runs. Together, they support entrepreneurs through key intervention categories on the supply side: access to technology, access to credit and finance, promotion of digitalisation, infrastructure support, formalisation and inclusion, access to markets, and industry-grade skilling.

Over 3.2 lakh women-owned enter-

prises have been supported under the Prime Minister’s Employment Generation Programme (PMEGP) over the past five years. As per recent data, 39 per cent of all PMEGP beneficiaries are women, a testament to both the scheme’s design and women’s determination to build.

The Credit Guarantee Fund Trust for Micro and Small Enterprises (CGTMSE) offers women borrowers enhanced guarantee cover of up to 90 per cent, making banks more willing to extend credit without collateral requirements.

Further, the Public Procurement Policy mandates that Central Ministries, Departments, and Public Sector Enterprises procure at least 3 per cent of their annual procurement from women-owned micro and small enterprises. This creates a guaranteed and predictable market for women entrepreneurs, thereby converting government spending into business growth. It is encouraging to note that in the financial year 2025-26, 3.5 per cent of total procure-

ment by Central Ministries, Departments, and Public Sector Enterprises was from women MSMEs.

Under the ZED (Zero Defect Zero Effect) Certification Scheme, women-owned MSMEs receive 100 per cent subsidy on certification costs. These details matter, as they demonstrate a Ministry that has carefully identified the barriers women face and placed targeted support at those precise pressure points.

The Mahila Coir Yojana offers exclusive skill development and financial support to women artisans in the coir sector. Special focus is being given to handholding women for market preparedness through MSME-TEAM (Trade Enablement and Marketing), under which 50 per cent of its 5 lakh beneficiaries are targeted to be women.

The Yashasvini Campaign runs nationwide awareness drives to inform women about MSME schemes and registration benefits. Under the MSME Idea Hackathon 3.0, organised exclusively for women

entrepreneurs, over 18,888 ideas were received, clearly reflecting a surge of creative and entrepreneurial energy.

Additionally, the Ministry has a dedicated Women Entrepreneurship Cell (WEC), which serves as the nodal point for advancing women’s entrepreneurship by coordinating across schemes, monitoring outcomes, and engaging with ecosystem stakeholders.

All these initiatives reflect a transition from viewing women’s inclusion as a subsidy component within individual schemes to building a comprehensive, gender-responsive entrepreneurship ecosystem.

Skill, confidence, and community

Beyond credit and markets, the government recognises that entrepreneurship is also about skill and confidence. In the North-East, where women have traditionally been the backbone of local economies, targeted Entrepreneurship Development Programmes have ensured that women form the majority of trained participants.

Self-Help Groups have been integrated with MSME support systems, creating communities of women entrepreneurs who support one another—building not just businesses but networks of collective strength. This is a government in forward motion. Each budget, each scheme, and each portal simplification is a building block in an edifice that Prime Minister Modi began constructing with a simple yet transformative premise—that India’s women are a potential to be unleashed.

The spirit of Nari Shakti in every enterprise

The Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam told the world that India’s women belong in its Parliament. The MSME policies of this government are telling the world that India’s women belong in its marketplaces, factories, export chains, innovation hubs, and boardrooms. These are two expressions of the same truth that Prime Minister Modi has made the cornerstone of his vision for a Viksit Bharat by 2047. A developed India is one where more than 3 crore women entrepreneurs—counting-form the very engine of development.

We are not there yet. But under this government’s watch, and with this Prime Minister’s commitment, we are unmistakably on our way.

The wound that equality cannot heal



ACHARYA PRASHANT

Feminism, in its original impulse, was a refusal—a refusal to accept that a woman’s worth could be settled by her body, her compliance, or her usefulness to the purposes of others. Whatever one thinks of the movement’s later directions, that original impulse deserves recognition. It named something real.

What has not changed is something harder to legislate and harder to measure: the way a woman sees herself when no one else is watching, what she finds at the centre of her self-esteem, and what happens to her sense of worth when her body changes or a particular kind of attention is withdrawn. The wound that produced the movement turns out to be deeper than the movement has so far been willing to go.

India’s Women’s Reservation Act, passed near-unanimously by Parliament in September 2023, has in recent days returned to the centre of parliamentary attention. When the Act takes effect, a third of all seats in the Lok Sabha and state assemblies will be reserved for women. Across party lines, the argument proceeds with familiar certainty: more women in legislatures will mean better governance, greater representation, and a more just republic. Yet something in this certainty deserves examination rather than applause.

What is being asked is a different question: whether the woman who occupies those seats has changed her relationship with herself, or only changed her position in a transaction that was always conducted on someone else’s terms—whether she has left the building or simply moved to a better floor of it.

The wound is real

What patriarchy does to a woman is particular and worth stating precisely. It assigns her a value anchored entirely in her body: her body’s labour, her body’s reproductive capacity, her body’s availability for male pleasure and display. Open any major Indian newspaper’s matrimonial section. The entry for a prospective bride will specify her complexion, height, weight, and domestic accomplishments, in roughly that order. The entry for a prospective groom will specify his income, profession, and property. The exchange being negotiated is not between two people; it is between a body’s display value and a household’s economic position. This advertisement runs today, placed with complete sincerity by educated, modern families. The patriarchal pricing of a woman has not disappeared; it has simply been



standardised. Think of what often happens when a woman enters a room. She knows, in a way she did not consciously learn and cannot consciously unlearn, whose eyes are on her and what those eyes are measuring. The knowledge is not external; it has been internalised so deeply that it operates as a continuous inner assessment, preceding any external one. The gaze she protests in the world is the gaze she has already absorbed within herself. The oppression she can name in a seminar is the oppression she conducts privately, against herself, before the seminar begins.

This is the real depth of the wound: the woman who diagnoses patriarchy in the world carries it intact within herself, where no legislation and no seat in any assembly can reach it. It is easier to count the empty seats in the legislature than to examine the occupied seat behind the mirror.

The cure that confirms the disease

Here is where most of what calls itself feminism makes its decisive error. Having correctly identified the wound, it proposes a horizontal cure: move the woman from this position to another, from subordination to equality. The slave, if this logic holds, is freed by becoming the master. But note what remains constant in this exchange: the body remains the primary reality, gender the primary identity, and the transaction continues in the currency of power and social position. The woman who fought her way to the boardroom has changed her address within the same building; she has not left it.

Gender equality, for all the energy expended in its pursuit, is a limited objective. It asks the wrong question. Men have held political, economic, and institutional power for centuries; the record speaks for itself. To aspire merely towards parity with that record is not ambition—it is a request to repeat the same errors.

Three decades after the 73rd and 74th Amendments reserved a third of panchayat

seats for women, the phenomenon candidly known in villages as sarpanch-pati has become commonplace: the woman wins the seat, the husband runs the office. The seat moved; the inner arrangement did not.

What no reservation can reserve

The Women’s Reservation Act will soon reach implementation. More women will enter legislatures, which is preferable to the alternative. But the more uncomfortable question remains: has anything changed in the relationship between a woman and her own sense of self?

The strongest evidence against the sufficiency of external liberation is not political. It exists in private comparisons, in the anxiety that follows bodily change, in the disappointment when desired approval is withheld. None of this yields to legislation. It yields only to a deeper inquiry—into who is looking, from where, and why what is seen never quite satisfies.

Patriarchy survives not only because men enforce it, though they do, but because the beliefs that sustain it are internalised. Consider a scene observed in Raipur: two young women walking by a lake, followed by a group of men, until one woman turned and said directly, “Why are you following us? Walk alongside.” The men, startled, withdrew. Most would have continued silently. What keeps many in fear is not only external threat, but an internalised belief about themselves that reform alone cannot erase.

India’s spiritual traditions offer examples often overlooked. Saint Lalleshwari, the fourteenth-century Kashmiri poet-saint, transcended the social scripts governing women. Akka Mahadevi, the twelfth-century Veerashaiva poet, left an imposed marriage and composed verses that endure centuries later. Their freedom did not lie in rebellion alone, but in transcendence of the body as the basis of identity.

There is a word for such orientation: not merely naariwadi, but chetanawadi—one grounded in self-inquiry, where gender becomes secondary to the deeper question of identity.

Without such inquiry, feminism risks reproducing the very structure it opposes. Patriarchy without self-awareness is domination; feminism without self-awareness risks becoming the same impulse in another form. Real freedom does not lie in shifting positions, but in questioning the premise that position defines identity.

The first woman was shaped by compliance; the second defines herself by resistance. Neither has fully found what both seek. Whether that discovery happens depends on a question no parliament can legislate and no movement can resolve: who, beneath the constructed identity of the woman, is truly present?

Acharya Prashant is a teacher and author whose work centres on self-inquiry and its application to contemporary life

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Women, youth and India’s democratic promise



MALIKA PANDEY

There are moments in a republic’s life when a reform is less about policy and more about self-recognition. The passage of women’s reservation in Parliament belongs to that category. It does not arrive as a sudden innovation, but as the culmination of a long, uneasy democratic hesitation that dates back to the early years of the Republic.

In 1951-52, when the first elections to the Lok Sabha were held, 489 elected representatives spoke for a population of roughly 36 crore. The architecture of representation was modest, but it carried an implicit promise that political voice would evolve alongside the nation’s demographic and social transformation. Seven decades later, that promise has been only partially fulfilled. India today has 543 elected MPs representing over 140 crore citizens. Each MP now represents, on average, nearly 25 lakh people, compared to about 7 lakh in the 1950s. The expansion of citizenship has far outpaced the expansion of representation.

This imbalance was not accidental. In 1976, through the 42nd Constitutional Amendment Act, India froze the redistribution of parliamentary seats to protect federal balance, ensuring that states which controlled population growth were not penalised politically. That logic had its own wisdom. But over time, what was meant to preserve equity has also produced a certain rigidity—one that sits uneasily with a young, expanding electorate.

It is in this context that the women’s reservation amendment must be understood. Too often, it is reduced to a symbolic gesture or, worse, a delayed promise. But in truth, it is a structural intervention. By linking reservation to delimitation, the law recognises a deeper constitutional reality: that representation cannot be meaningfully altered without first recalibrating the units through which it operates. This is not procrastination masquerading as reform; it is sequencing.

Globally, democracies have grappled with similar questions, though with different instruments. France, for instance, chose to compel political parties to field equal numbers of men and women candidates through its parity laws. The result was gradual but incomplete progress, with women’s representation rising steadily but unevenly. Rwanda, by contrast, embedded quotas directly into its Constitution, producing one of the most dramatic transformations in



gender representation, with women now constituting over 60 per cent of its legislature. India’s approach sits somewhere between these models—constitutional in its ambition, but cautious in its execution.

What distinguishes the Indian case, however, is not merely the method, but the moment. This reform arrives at a time when India is both demographically young and politically aspirational. Nearly two-thirds of its population is under the age of 35. Yet the structures through which this generation is represented have remained largely unchanged since the 1970s. The reservation of one-third of seats for women, when implemented, will not only correct a long-standing gender imbalance, it will also reshape the composition of political leadership in ways that reflect the energies of a younger India.

Critics are right to raise concerns about timing, federal balance, and inclusion. These are not trivial questions. But they are questions born of a deeper truth—that India has deferred the recalibration of representation for too long. The present moment, therefore, is less about the politics of a single Bill and more about the inevitability of adjustment.

In the end, the measure of this reform will not lie in legislative arithmetic alone. It will lie in whether India can align its democratic institutions with the scale, diversity, and youthfulness of its society. On that count, the women’s reservation amendment is not just timely; it is necessary.

The writer is a public policy expert with years of experience working across key ministries of the Government of India, including the Ministry of Women & Child Development

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BLASÉ CAPITAL

ADANI VS AMBANI

Here is the big news. Gautam Adani, the patriarch of ports-to-power empire, went past Mukesh Ambani, the second-generation part-patriarch of gas-to-digital fiefdom, as far as the wealth circus is concerned. According to the Bloomberg Billionaires Index, the former is ranked 19, with a net worth nearer to \$93 billion, and an addition of more than \$8 billion this year. The latter is biting at Adani’s heels, and is ranked 20, with a personal wealth of under \$91 billion, with a loss of nearly \$17 billion this year. In a sense, this year, Adani made up almost \$25 billion, his additions plus his rival’s subtraction. Obviously, the race has not finished, and is still on. It is not a sprint or dash. It is a marathon that may go on for years, even decades. The unexpected gains landed at Adani’s feet, as he added more than \$3.5 billion in a single day (yes, a single day), even as Ambani lost some millions of dollars. If Ambani gains a billion, and Adani loses a billion even as we write this piece, the rankings will change. According to a media report, “Adani has benefitted from a recovery in group stocks, and improving investor sentiments, while Ambani’s wealth has come under pressure amid volatility in energy markets, and broader equity movements, particularly in the backdrop of the Russia Asia crisis.”

But here is another big news that went unreported because it did not signify a change. According to the Forbes Real-Time Billionaire List, Mukesh Ambani is way ahead of Gautam Adani in the wealth race. When we last checked, in the afternoon just after the Indian stock markets closed, the former was ranked 20, with a wealth of \$95 billion, or an addition of \$1.3 billion (1.36 per cent) for the day. Forget about biting the heels, Adani was nowhere in the immediate vicinity, ranked 26, with a net worth of just under \$73 billion, with a daily accretion of \$3.8 billion (5.55 per cent). This is not a small difference, a billion here and there, as is the case with the Bloomberg list. As per the Forbes’ list, Ambani is ahead by more than \$22 billion which, even in the cases of billionaires, apart from rare black-swan events, do not change in a day. Yes, there was a day, when Elon Musk, the richest of them, added \$200 billion, according to media reports, and another one, when Oracle’s Larry Ellison added \$100 billion. But as we said, they are rare.

Since, in the present context, as it is true in the present days, wealth is ephemeral, driven by paper valuations, or prices of the listed stocks that the billionaires own, one is not unduly concerned about who is richer, Adani or Ambani. Obviously, one will watch the two lists, and others, just for curiosity’s sake, as to who finally trumps the other without a debate or dispute. Now, we are more bothered about the credibility of the two lists, Forbes and Bloomberg, their methodologies, and which one to believe. For years, even decades, Forbes’ one has been the front-runner, which has the first-movers advantage. Bloomberg’s eminence came later, but it is as well respected as Forbes. Another crucial list, Fortune, has sort of vanished from media mentions. There are some new lists, which have gained prominence in the recent past. But for most of us, who have more than 2-3 decades of journalistic experience, Forbes is the billionaire bible. For the younger generation, Bloomberg is the king of the list of the wealthiest. So, it is not just a matter of lists. It is a clash between the oldies and newbies, maybe the proponents of the brick-n-mortar businesses, and builders of new-age tech empires.

Of course, everyone knows that it is not easy to prepare a list of the wealth of the richest. Despite the listed firms that they own, whose stock prices are tracked on a second-by-second basis, when the relevant markets are open, the billionaires seem to own stocks in unlisted firms, many of which may be hidden under heavy corporate veils in secretive tax havens, as well as assets that are strewn around the globe, many of which they sometimes forget that they own and control. Even the assets under the various firms are hidden, or they are locked away in undisclosed entities, like Enron did to hide its losses. The money, assets, shares, and others in the tax havens are never revealed for the obvious purposes. The prices of the assets change, and it is extremely tough, even for media empires like Forbes and Bloomberg to track them. Thus, as is evident, the methodologies are not perfect, and they cannot ever claim to present true pictures. They are approximations, impressions of impressions, even as the estimates possibly improve over the years. Many experts and analysts consider the lists to be incomplete, and partly inaccurate, and “often miss a significant amount of wealth, leading to ‘suspect’ rankings at the lower and middle tiers.” Knowing this may not deter the egos of the billionaires, many of whom fight tooth and nail to either reach the top, or remain at the top.

The Pioneer

NEW DELHI | SATURDAY | APRIL 18, 2026

BUSINESS

10

In gold we trust, silver we must

Recent bullion policies reflect concerns about trade deficit, rupee

The two decisions yesterday, or rather an indecision and a super-quick decision, showed the best and worst of the bureaucracy. In the morning, an agency report rocked the bullion market, as it stated that tonnes of gold and silver were struck at the customs, and other places due to a lack of an official order. Within an hour or so of the news, a circular emerged that enabled the import trade, after a possible lag of more than two weeks. The delay seems inexplicable. The charitable explanation is mere oversight, or some delays in the red-tape process, which is usual. The conspiratorial theory is that it was a deliberate move to curb bullion imports to give an additional breathing space to the rupee. The second one gains credence after the Government earlier imposed strict restrictions on gold imports, and the central bank took severe, unexpected, unimaginable, and anti-reforms measures to support the rupee. The links between bullion imports and rupee are logical.

But first, let us look at the two orders, rather a non-order, and a circular. Generally, the directorate general of foreign trade, issues an order at the start of each financial year (April 1, but it is not to make a fool of people) that lists the banks that are authorised by the central bank to import gold and silver. The previous order was valid till March 31, 2026, and there was not a new one, or a new list of the banks, until yesterday morning. Hence, what normally takes a few days, lasted for 16 days. In the process, the banks were unable to import, and the shipments were struck at the various locations. One of the bullion dealers said more than five tonnes of gold were struck, and

the agency which reported the delay estimated that eight tonnes of silver was floating around without customs clearances. This raised immediate concerns about shortages, as India is among the largest importers, although imports fell to just over 700 tonnes of gold in 2025, the lowest level in the past five years, as per the World Gold Council.

Immediately, in less than an hour, if one looks at the timing of the media reports (non-order and order), the directorate general issued the order with a list of the banks that are allowed to import the bullion. The order permits 15 banks, which include SBI, HDFC, and Bank of India, to import the bullion up to March 31, 2029. In between, a spokesperson of the bullion association made a statement that there was a “need to bring clarity, and ensure imports resume.” If the initial agency report is to be believed, the normal period mentioned in such past orders was for 12 months, April-March. This order seems to be for three years, or an aggressive indication that the delay was not deliberate but oversight, and the three-year period proves that there was no conspiracy. Most of the stakeholders, whether officials, banks, and dealers, maintained silence once the order was issued, and everything seemed normal. It was as if the earlier 16 days did not exist, or mattered. It was back to normal bullion-banking business without any delays.

However, if one connects the bullion-bank order with the moves that the central bank made on the rupee in the recent past, one can estab-

lish a connection, even if it is indirect and maybe a bit tenuous. Over the past 2-3 weeks, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has been jittery, even scared, about the weakening of the rupee. This was especially visible when the rupee stood at over ₹95 to a dollar, with the expectations that it was a matter of when, not if, before it was at ₹100. Scared of the free fall within weeks, which normally takes 1-2 years, the RBI reacted like a wounded central banker. It imposed a series of bans, restrictions, and limits, which reminded experts of a situation that happened more than decade ago. Experts said that the actions were anti-reforms, and reduced India’s credibility in the world arena. But the RBI was adamant

because the rupee at ₹94 to a dollar was sacrosanct. The rupee strengthened, and moved to ₹92-93 to a dollar, and settled around the ₹93 mark. The fear of it breaching ₹95 again in a few days, and going towards ₹100 in a few weeks were gone.

It was during this period that the order listing the bullion-importing banks, which generally moves from the RBI, was stalled. It was during these critical two weeks that the bullion imports stood at a standstill due to the lack of legal clarity, and bureaucratic delays. Since the central bank was the originator of the moves related to the bullion and rupee, and since gold and currency are inter-linked, one can smell a rat, or sense a cat among the pigeons. One of the reasons for the weakened rupee, apart from several others, is the looming trade deficit, which is the result of lower exports, and more expensive imports due to the Iran war, and other reasons. Gold is one of the most important ingredients among the imports, and is perhaps among the least significant products in the economic sense. A curb on gold imports, even if for 16 days, was a huge boon for the trade deficit, and rupee. Do not forget that less than two weeks ago, the same directorate general imposed other curbs on bullion imports, with the ostensible reason to check the deficit, and boost rupee.

At that time, the official reason was not about the deficit or rupee, but misuse of imports. Media reports indicated that traders imported the gold into India “by routing them through partner nations with which India has Free Trade Agreements. They would make only minor modifications to the metal arriving from these countries. Subsequently, they would claim duty benefits or exemptions. This practice was causing significant harm to the country’s domestic industry, and was also adversely affecting government revenue. By addressing these loopholes, the central government aims to ensure that only legitimate trade takes place within the country, and that the import of precious metals can be regulated more effectively.” What is crucial to note is that the curbs were immediate, instant, and applied to everything, whether the import contract was signed, or letter of credit issued for the deal. This hinted that the move was to reduce imports of gold immediately, as was the case with the delay in the order that listed the banks later.

A Contrarian Investor

Defence stocks offer best defence

As the Iran war drags on, focus has shifted again on this sector

Index Fund, which was among the first to track this theme. Over the past 12 months, its returns were nearly 30 per cent, as was the case with two other funds and ETFs. Over a three month-period, the last three, the three funds offered returns of just over nine per cent each. During the same period, the Sensex, the Bombay Stock Exchange Index, lost more than 5,000 points. Since January 1, 2026, the overall index shed a massive 6,500 points.

One of the advantages of defence index funds is the simplicity. Investors get exposure to a curated basket of sector-related firms without a need to research on the individual stocks. They are cost-efficient, as passive funds typically have lower expense ratios compared to the actively-managed funds. The rules-based approach ensures transparency and discipline, with periodic rebalancing that is aligned with the Nifty Defence index. Defence funds offer thematic diversification. Since these stocks may not be heavily

represented in broader indices, the funds allow investors to tap into a specific growth segment.

Despite the strong narrative, these funds come with notable risks. The main one is the obvious concentration risk. The index that they mirror, and replicate, includes a limited number of stocks. As one knows, defence is highly prone to policies and regulations, which include changes in official spending, or geopolitical dynamics. Valuations offer another area of concern. In the recent past, the stocks witnessed sharp rallies, as well as strenuous periods of corrections. The reason is that they are synced with specific events related to wars and conflicts. Thus, the sector per say behaves in a volatile manner.

Being passive in nature, and as per their strategy, these defence funds cannot actively avoid overvalued stocks, or adjust allocations based on the market conditions. Yet, experts believe in long-term structural play,

supported by multiple tailwinds. B Gopkumar, MD & CEO, Axis AMC, explains, “India’s defence sector is undergoing a multi-year transformation, supported by rising budgets, strong policy intent, and expanding export opportunities. We (through our fund) offer investors a low-cost, rules-based way to participate in this structural growth theme. This (Axis’) fund is well-suited for investors with a long-term perspective who are looking to align their portfolios with India’s strategic and manufacturing priorities.”

Hence, one can look at the defence funds in two ways, which are essentially the two sides of a coin. When one looks at the heads, one sees a compelling growth story, which is driven by global factors (multi-polar world), and domestic situations (tense borders). There is transparency, and lack of gimmicks, as the sector is simple and straightforward. Defence will invariably remain on the top of any regime’s agenda. Yet, if one looks at the tails side, the investors need to be willing to remain invested in the funds, or have confidence in the sector through ups and downs, and volatile cycles.

As of now, the defence-themed index fund space remains small and niche. As mentioned earlier, there are only a handful of funds that track the sector-specific Nifty index. Hence, investors with less risk appetite, or safety issues, may wait for a while to understand how these funds perform, and what are the benefits and pitfalls. For those with a little bit of courage, and confidence in India’s security strategy, the defence funds may offer an early, lucrative entry into a new area. Policy support, growing global relevance, and focus on local production may help the sector to emerge as a significant investment theme.

Globally, there is a buzz around the defence stocks. In the US, for example, the Iran war has “depleted certain munitions, and increased demand for replenishment.” Experts reckon that bases store 50 million gallons of jet fuel each month, and tanks in drills consume 1,000 gallons of fuel per mile. “Defence contracts regularly invest \$3 billion in armoured carriers that feed off the diesel round the clock,” states a media report. This is why the shares of Lockheed Martin, which won a \$5-billion defence contract, are up nearly 29 per cent this year.

The Pioneer

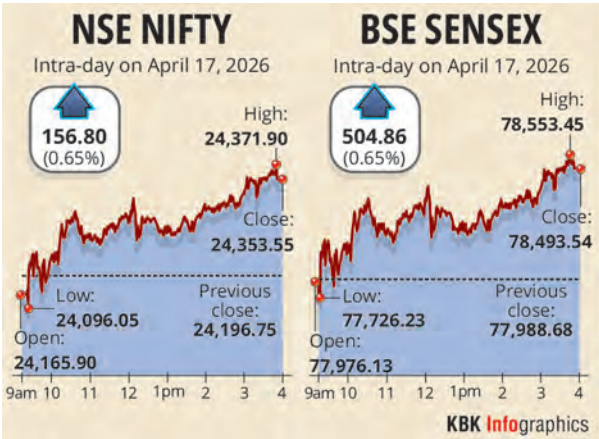
SINCE 1865

Markets rally amid easing West Asia tensions

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

Stock market benchmark indices Sensex and Nifty rallied nearly 1 per cent on Friday, driven by optimism surrounding easing geopolitical tensions and fresh foreign fund inflows.

Renewed hopes of a diplomatic resolution between the US and Iran, along with a 10-day ceasefire between Israel and Lebanon, have materially improved global risk appetite, a market analyst said. The 30-share BSE Sensex jumped 504.86 points, or 0.65 per cent, to settle at 78,493.54. During the day, it surged 564.77 points, or 0.72 per cent, to 78,553.45. The 50-share NSE Nifty climbed 156.80 points,



or 0.65 per cent, to end at 24,353.55.

From the 30-Sensex firms, Hindustan Unilever, Power Grid, Reliance Industries, Bharat Electronics, Tech Mahindra and Titan were

among the major winners.

In contrast, Sun Pharma, Mahindra & Mahindra, Larsen & Toubro and HCL Tech were among the laggards.

Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, dropped 3.07 per

cent to \$96.34 per barrel.

“The primary catalyst for today’s strength was the de-escalation in West Asia. Renewed hopes of a diplomatic resolution between the US and Iran, along with a 10-day ceasefire between Israel and Lebanon, have materially improved global risk appetite.

“This has reduced concerns around a sustained spike in crude oil prices, which had earlier weighed on inflation expectations, currency stability, and overall market sentiment,” Hariprasad K, Research Analyst and founder, Livelong Wealth, said.

In Asian markets, South Korea’s benchmark Kospi, Japan’s Nikkei 225 index, Shanghai’s SSE Composite

index and Hong Kong’s Hang Seng index ended lower.

Markets in Europe were trading higher in mid-session deals.

US markets ended in positive territory on Thursday.

Foreign Institutional Investors (FIIs) bought equities worth ₹382.36 crore on Thursday, according to exchange data.

“The domestic market closed the day higher, supported by improving prospects of a Middle East resolution and a reversal in FII flows into net buying. A ceasefire between Israel and Lebanon helped keep crude below \$100/bbl, easing pressure on import-dependent economies,” Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Limited, said.

Rupee rises 29 paise to settle at 92.85 against US dollar

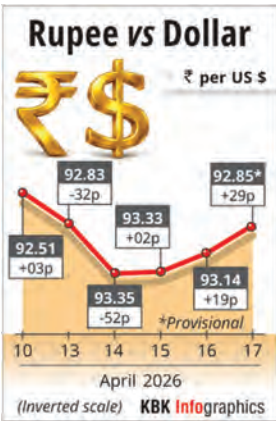
PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ Mumbai

The rupee appreciated by 29 paise to settle at 92.85 (provisional) against the US dollar on Friday, buoyed by a weakening American currency and retreating crude oil prices amid increasing hopes of easing geopolitical tensions.

Renewed buying in domestic equity markets and fresh inflow of foreign funds also supported the local currency, forex traders said.

At the interbank foreign exchange market, the rupee opened at 92.93 and touched an intraday high of 92.65 against the greenback. The unit also touched the day’s



low of 92.98 before ending the session at 92.85 (provisional) against the American currency, up 29 paise from the previous closing level.

On Thursday, the rupee

gained 19 paise to settle at 93.14 against the US dollar.

Anuj Choudhary, Research Analyst at Mirae Asset Sharekhan, said the rupee strengthened on improved global risk sentiments.

He said global markets rallied and the US dollar weakened amid declining safe-haven demand, while crude oil prices softened overnight.

“We expect the rupee to trade with a positive bias on expectations of the second round of talks between the US and Iran as well as the ceasefire between Israel and Lebanon,” Choudhary said, adding, “USD-INR spot price is expected to trade in a range of ₹92.50 to ₹93.20.”

Crude oil prices fall over 2% to ₹8,396/barrel in futures trade as Trump signals Iran deal

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Crude oil prices fell a little over 2 per cent to ₹8,396 per barrel in futures trade on Friday amid signs of a potential US-Iran agreement and easing geopolitical tensions dampening fears of prolonged supply disruptions.

Crude prices for May delivery decreased by ₹180, or 2.1 per cent, to ₹8,396 per barrel on the Multi Commodity Exchange.

“Crude futures declined after US President Donald Trump expressed optimism over a potential agreement with Iran, easing concerns over prolonged supply disruptions,” Kaveri More, Commodity—Technical Research at Choice Broking, said.



Trump indicated that Tehran may accept terms, including abandoning nuclear ambitions, reopening the Strait of Hormuz, and offering “free oil,” though there has been no official confirmation from Iran.

In the international market, oil futures remained below \$100 per barrel as investors turned hopeful about a near-term resolution to the conflict in West Asia.

West Texas Intermediate (WTI) for the May contract fell 1.02 per cent to \$93.72 per barrel on NYMEX, while Brent oil for the June contract dipped nearly 1 per cent to \$98.41 per barrel in New York.

More said that additional pressure on crude prices came after a 10-day ceasefire between Israel and Lebanon was announced, reducing immediate geopolitical risks.

On the outlook, she said the short-term trend remains pressured, with price action largely driven by ongoing geopolitical updates.

Silver prices jump ₹3,371 to ₹2.51 lakh/kg in futures trade amid strong global cues

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

■ New Delhi

Silver prices jumped ₹3,371 to ₹2.51 lakh per kilogram in the futures trade on Friday, tracking gains in global markets as easing geopolitical tensions in West Asia and a weak US dollar boosted investors’ sentiment.

On the Multi Commodity Exchange, the white metal for May delivery climbed ₹3,371, or 1.36 per cent, to ₹2,51,999 per kg.

Analysts said silver gained on the back of a weaker US dollar and easing geopolitical tensions.

“Silver rose over 1 per cent



on Friday, buoyed by a weak dollar and easing geopolitical tensions, particularly expectations of progress in the US-Iran situation, have lifted sentiment,” Hareesh V, Head of Commodity Research,

Geojit Investments Ltd, said.

The white metal’s industrial demand also adds an extra layer of support to its outlook, he added. Globally, Comex silver futures for the May contract gained 1.11 per cent

to \$79.58 per ounce in New York. Silver prices held steady near \$79 per ounce, marking a fourth straight weekly increase, Renisha Chainani, Head of Research at Augmont, said.

This rise is driven by improving prospects of a permanent US-Iran ceasefire, which has reduced inflation concerns and lowered expectations of further central bank interest rate hikes, she added.

US President Trump stated that Iran has agreed to key conditions, including abandoning its nuclear weapons programme, providing free oil, and keeping the Strait of Hormuz open.

Crude oil slumps 10% as, Wall Street rallies

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ New York

Oil prices are falling by more than 10 per cent, and Wall Street is rallying toward another record after Iran said the Strait of Hormuz is fully open, which would allow oil tankers to exit the Persian Gulf again and carry crude to customers worldwide.

The S&P 500 rallied 0.7 per cent as US stocks sprinted toward the finish of a third straight week of big gains. The Dow Jones Industrial Average rose 1 per cent, and the Nasdaq composite added



1 per cent. Stocks have rallied more than 11 per cent since late March on hopes that the United States and Iran can avoid a worst-case scenario for the global economy.

India targets ₹12,500 cr LPG pipeline buildout to cut road transport by 2030

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Oil and gas regulator Petroleum and Natural Gas Regulatory Board has initiated a large-scale push to develop liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) pipeline infrastructure, aiming to reduce dependence on road transport and strengthen energy security.

The move is intended to connect refineries and import terminals with bottling plants through pipelines, replacing bulk tanker movement and improving the safety, reliability and efficiency of LPG distribution.

As part of the initiative, the regulator said, it has identified nine pipeline projects and is currently in the process



of concluding bids for four key routes, with a combined length of about 2,500 km. These include the Cherlapally-Nagpur, Shikrapur-Hubli-

Goa, Paradip-Raipur and Jhansi-Sitarganj pipelines.

The projects are expected to attract investments of around ₹12,500 crore and play a critical role in streamlining LPG logistics, reducing transit losses and cutting greenhouse gas emissions.

The shift toward pipeline-based transportation is also aimed at phasing out bulk LPG movement by road by 2030, mitigating accident risks and enhancing supply chain resilience.

The regulator said that the initiative would support India’s broader energy transition goals by improving access to cleaner fuels while boosting infrastructure development and regional economic activity.

LPG bookings edge toward normal as summer season eases demand

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Cooking gas LPG demand is inching towards normalcy as domestic supplies increased as onset of summer chips away demand, a senior official said on Friday.

With the war in West Asia disrupting global energy supplies, cooking gas availability in India, too, was impacted. Following this, the government prioritised supplies to domestic household kitchens by cutting supplies to commercial establishments such as hotels and restaurants.

The cuts spark panic, prompting even domestic consumers to rush to secure LPG refills. Daily bookings

exceeded 88 lakhs at peak last month as against pre-crisis bookings of about 45 lakh a day.

Efforts to raise domestic output by diverting petrochemical pools into LPG production, led to a 40-50 per cent rise in output, prompting restoration of some of those supplies.

At a news briefing, Sujata Sharma, Joint Secretary in the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, said daily bookings are in the range of 46-50 lakh currently.

“Deliveries are normal. Yesterday (on April 16), about 50 lakh refill cylinders were delivered at doorsteps of users,” she said, adding that the data suggests gradual return to normalcy.



Also aiding is the onset of summer when heating requirements falls.

“There is certainly a dip in demand,” she said without giving absolute numbers.

She said India has maintained stable supplies of cooking gas and transport fuels despite disruptions

linked to geopolitical tensions, with the government prioritising household consumption and stepping up allocations to key sectors.

Domestic LPG deliveries remain normal, with no shortages have been reported at distributor points, she said.

Online bookings account for about 98 per cent of the total demand, and authenticated deliveries have risen to over 90 per cent to curb diversion.

Commercial LPG supply has been restored to around 70 per cent of pre-crisis levels, supported by targeted measures, including increased allocation of smaller cylinders for migrant workers and expanded distribution campaigns by state-run oil marketing companies.

Since March 23, more than 16.41 lakh market-priced 5-kg LPG cylinders have been sold to those without a proper domestic cooking gas connections, she said.

These include migrants, students and working profes-

sionals as well as small businesses.

A total of 1.5 lakh tonnes (equivalent to more than 79.14 lakh of 19 kg commercial LPG cylinders) of commercial LPG have been sold since March 14, she said, adding that this includes more than 8,850 tonnes of Auto LPG.

Authorities have also accelerated a shift towards piped natural gas (PNG), prioritising full supply to households and transport segments using compressed natural gas. Gas allocation to fertiliser plants has been raised to about 95 per cent of recent average consumption, while industrial supply has been increased to as much as 80 per cent.

India’s smartphone shipments drop 3% in Jan-Mar, mark weakest quarter in 6 yrs

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

Supply-side cost pressures and weak demand took a toll on India’s smartphone shipments, which fell 3 per cent year-on-year in Q1 2026, suffering its weakest quarter in the last six years, according to Counterpoint Research’s Monthly India Smartphone Tracker.

On the outlook, Research Director Tarun Pathak said India’s smartphone market is expected to remain under pressure in the near term, with Q2 2026 likely to see a double-digit decline, as elevated memory prices and weak entry-level demand continue to weigh on overall volumes.

“For the full year, the market is projected to decline by 10 per cent YoY, as sustained component cost inflation, particularly in memory, which has already increased 4x

over the past three quarters, continues to impact affordability and lengthen replacement cycles,” Pathak said.

Brands, he observed, are expected to stay disciplined, focusing on premium-led growth, tighter portfolio execution and channel efficiency. While premium segment should remain relatively resilient, ongoing weakness in the mass segment is likely to keep the recovery gradual and uneven, he said.

“India’s smartphone shipments declined 3 per cent YoY in Q1 2026, marking their weakest quarter in the last six years,” Counterpoint Research’s Monthly India Smartphone Tracker said.

It said this was a result of a mix of supply-side cost pressures, OEM-led price hikes and weak consumer demand, which weighed on retail conversions across channels despite higher



launch activity. As per Counterpoint’s latest tracker, nearly one-third of model launches were advanced to Q1 to primarily offset rising component costs, as OEMs aimed to mitigate further BOM (Bill of Materials) inflation, particularly due to memory prices and currency fluctuations. “The

market is facing a clear affordability squeeze, driven by sharp memory-led cost inflation and currency pressures that have forced OEMs to raise prices across key models,” Senior Analyst Prachir Singh said.

With average hikes exceeding ₹1,500, the sub-₹15,000 segment

has been hit the hardest, given its high price sensitivity.

“Rising energy costs amid ongoing geopolitical tensions in the Middle East are further straining household budgets, pushing consumers to prioritise essentials over discretionary purchases like smartphones. As a result, upgrade cycles are stretching, and a meaningful recovery in the mass segment is likely to remain gradual,” Singh noted.

Apple saw its shipment share reaching 9 per cent in Q1 2026, driven by sustained strong momentum of the iPhone 17 series, supported by aggressive offers such as long-term EMI schemes and exchange offers. Apple is better positioned to navigate memory price pressures, supported by its premium portfolio and efficient supply chain management, Counterpoint pointed out.

In terms of the India smartphone market volume share, vivo (excluding iQOO) led the charts with a 21 per cent share of India’s smartphone market in Q1 2026, driven by an expanded product portfolio with a higher number of launches, strong traction in the mid-premium segment and well-executed channel discipline.

Samsung was at the second spot, supported by strong traction in its mass-market portfolio, driven by attractive offers on key A-series models (A07, A36 and A56), alongside a positive early response to the Galaxy S26 series.

The quarter also reflected a phased flagship rollout and continued portfolio optimisation across price segments. Samsung clinched its highest shipment contribution from the ₹15,000-₹20,000 segment during the quarter, supported by a well-balanced portfolio across tiers.

OPPO (excluding OnePlus) retained its third position in Q1, 2026 with a 14 per cent share. It registered an 8 per cent year-on-year growth to become the fastest-growing brand among the top five.

Xiaomi (including POCO) ranked fourth in Q1 2026, with its ₹10,000-₹20,000 segment registering double-digit year-on-year growth. This was backed by improved channel execution (dual-channel approach) and a sharper portfolio focus on hero models, enabling better returns and retail traction.

According to the Q1 snapshot, realme saw strong traction in the ₹10,000-₹20,000 segment in online channels, ranking among the top two brands.

Nothing (including CMF) kept its strong growth momentum, emerging as the fastest-growing brand in Q1 2026 with 47 per cent growth.

PM Starmer furious over security blunder in Mandelson appointment

ADITI KHANNA
■ London

British Prime Minister Keir Starmer on Friday said he is “furious” over a security blunder that allowed the appointment of controversial peer Peter Mandelson as the UK’s ambassador to the US, who was later sacked over links with convicted sex offender Jeffrey Epstein.

The issue has been thrown back into the spotlight after a Guardian report claimed Lord Mandelson had failed the obligatory security vetting that is carried out for high-profile Government appointments. However, it emerged that the Foreign, Commonwealth and Development Office (FCDO) had overridden that intensive scrutiny to greenlight the appointment regardless last year. “That I wasn’t told that Peter Mandelson had failed security vetting when he was appointed is staggering,” Starmer told reporters in Paris, where he is hosting a summit to agree a defensive plan to secure the Strait of Hormuz.

“That I wasn’t told that he had failed security vetting when I was telling Parliament that due process had been followed is unforgivable. Not only was I not told, no minister was told, and I’m absolutely furious about that.”

“What I intend to do is to go to Parliament on Monday to set out all the relevant facts in true transparency, so Parliament has the full picture,” he said. The



Government has blamed Foreign Office officials, with the department’s topmost civil servant Sir Olly Robbins being sacked for the blunder. However, Opposition MPs and some of Starmer’s own Labour Party colleagues have questioned the credibility of the claims that the Prime Minister was made aware of the failed vetting by the UK’s security services only this week.

“All roads lead to resignation,” said Opposition Conservative leader Kemi Badenoch, who has insisted it was “simply not possible” Starmer wasn’t aware Mandelson had failed his vetting process.

Liberal Democrat leader Ed Davey has accused the UK PM of showing “catastrophically poor judgement” and questioned if he misled Parliament when he repeatedly insisted that all “due process” had been followed in Mandelson’s appointment.

Meanwhile, the House of Commons Foreign Affairs

Committee has summoned Olly Robbins to appear before the cross-party panel as some of the top civil servant’s previous statements about the appointment process have now been “called into question.”

Following the latest revelations, Chief Secretary to the Prime Minister Darren Jones stepped in to suspend the rules that allowed the Foreign Office to overrule a security vetting process.

“The fact that that process was allowed to happen is quite frankly flabbergasting,” he said. The issue of Mandelson’s appointment and subsequent sacking last year has caused much turbulence at the heart of the British Government, with repeated calls for Starmer to step down over the appointment despite known connections between the former Labour Cabinet minister and Epstein.

Earlier this year, Starmer issued an apology to the victims of Epstein in an effort

to move on from the scandal and also lost one of his topmost political aides, Morgan McSweeney, who took responsibility for the dubious appointment.

However, the issue has continued to plague his Government as a Metropolitan Police investigation was launched into further revelations around Mandelson’s ties with the late American sex offender. While he denied wrongdoing, Mandelson was sacked seven months into his role in Washington and the files related to his appointment process were released by the British Government under transparency norms.

Starmer’s premiership faced its biggest crisis in February after the release of millions of pages of Epstein-related documents by the U.S. Department of Justice showed the closeness of Mandelson’s relationship with the financier, even after Epstein’s conviction in 2008 for sexual offenses involving a minor. Emails between the men suggested Mandelson had passed on sensitive - and potentially market-moving - Government information to Epstein in 2009, when he was a member of Prime Minister Gordon Brown’s Government.

British police subsequently launched a criminal probe and searched Mandelson’s houses in London and western England. Mandelson was arrested on February 23 on suspicion of misconduct in public office. (PTI)

Pak, Saudi Arabia extend \$3 billion deposit

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Karachi

Saudi Arabia has reached an agreement with the State Bank of Pakistan which allows for an extension in the maturity of a \$3 billion deposit with the central bank, it was announced on Friday.

The announcement comes a day after the SaudiA Fund for Development deposited \$2 billion of the \$3 billion on Thursday with the State Bank of Pakistan (SBP), bringing a major boost to the country’s skewed foreign reserves. “The agreement, signed between the SaudiA Fund for Development (SFD)



and the State Bank of Pakistan (SBP), provides for the extension in the maturity of a \$3 billion deposit placed by SFD with the State Bank of Pakistan,” said a post on X by the Ministry of

Finance. The Finance Ministry said that the agreement was signed between SBP Governor Jameel Ahmed and Chief Executive Officer of the SFD Sultan bin Abdulrahman Al-Marshad.

Minister for Finance and Muhammad Aurangzeb witnessed the signing of an important financial agreement in Washington, DC, in the presence of Pakistan’s Ambassador to the United States. The development took place on the sidelines of the World Bank-IMF Spring Meetings. Saudi Arabia on Tuesday extended its USD 5 billion facility for a further three years and had also pledged the additional \$3

billion deposits for Pakistan.

With this fresh loan, Saudi Arabia has become the single largest country to have placed a total of \$8 billion in cash deposits with Pakistan’s central bank.

The ministry added that the extension of the deposit reflects “strong and long-standing economic partnership between Pakistan and the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia” and will support the country’s external sector stability. “This assistance aims at supporting Pakistan’s economy and strengthening its resilience amidst evolving global economic challenges,” the Saudi Press Agency reported.

Myanmar ex-President freed in broad prisoner amnesty

GRANT PECK
■ Bangkok

Myanmar’s former President Win Myint was freed on Friday as part of a broad prisoner amnesty by newly inaugurated President Min Aung Hlaing to mark the traditional New Year, State-run media reported.

The pardon order applied to more than 4,500 prisoners, but it was not immediately clear how many people imprisoned for opposing military rule were included, and there was no sign that 80-year-old former leader Aung San Suu Kyi would be freed. Win Myint is Suu Kyi’s longtime loyalist and was elected as president in 2018. He was arrested on 2021, the same day the military seized power and detained Suu Kyi.

He was later given a 12-year combined prison sentence for several offences, which was reduced to eight years in 2023. State-run MRTV television reported that Win Myint, who was in prison in Taunggoo township in Bago region, had received



amnesty. Outside Insein Prison in Yangon, buses carrying prisoners were welcomed by relatives and friends who had been waiting since early morning. Among those released was filmmaker Shin Daewe, who was sentenced to life imprisonment under a counterterrorism law in January 2024.

The amnesty comes a week after Min Aung Hlaing was sworn into office following an election that critics say was neither free nor fair and was orchestrated to keep the military’s iron grip on power. (AP)

Sri Lankan minister resigns after surviving no-confidence motion



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Colombo

Sri Lanka’s Minister for Power and Energy Kumara Jayakodi resigned on Friday soon after a high-powered Presidential Commission was announced to probe a state-owned entity’s coal imports for power generation.

Jayakodi, who survived a ‘No Trust’ vote last week, is the first resignation of the National People’s Power (NPP) Government since it was elected in late 2024 on an anti-corruption platform.

Along with Jayakodi, Ministry’s Secretary Udayanga Hemapala too resigned from the post, President Anura Kumara Dissanayake’s office said. According to the President’s Media Division (PMD), the move is to facilitate an independent investigation by the Special Presidential Commission appointed to probe matters related to coal imports, it said. Earlier in the day, Sri Lanka appointed the high-powered Presidential Commission to probe Lanka Coal Ltd from the time coal came to be imported for power generation going back decades until April 16, 2026, a release from the President’s Office said.

EU officials in Hungary seek release of billions blocked under Orban



SAM MCNEIL/ JUSTIN SPIKE
■ Budapest

European Union officials are meeting on Friday in Budapest with members of Hungarian election winner Peter Magyar’s team about pressing issues, including a massive loan for Ukraine, as well as unlocking about 17 billion euros (\$20 billion) of aid for Hungary withheld during the reign of outgoing Prime Minister Viktor Orban.

Magyar will take power in May, but the EU is hoping to jump-start talks to fast-track cooperation with the new Government, said European Commission spokesperson Paula Pinho in Brussels.

“The clock is ticking for a number of topics,” said Pinho. The “preliminary talks” in Budapest before Magyar takes office are to “make sure that once the Government is in place action can be taken, if appropriate, and that we do not waste any time.” The EU froze the billions in funding to Hungary over concerns of corruption and democratic backsliding

during Orban’s 16-year rule. But both the EU and Hungary’s incoming leaders have prioritised releasing them as soon as possible to give a much-needed injection of cash into Hungary’s ailing economy.

European Commission President Ursula von der Leyen wrote on X on Tuesday that “there is swift work to be done to restore, realign and reform” Hungary’s policies in order to unblock the funds.

“Restore the rule of law. Realign with our shared European values.”

And reform, to unlock the opportunities offered by European investments,” said the EU executive, who herself was often vilified by Orban during his campaign.

Magyar, whose party Tiszza won a super-majority in parliament, which will enable deep and quick reforms, has said his Government will prioritise policies affecting judicial independence, academic and media freedom and anti-corruption in order to get access to the money. (AP)

Bulgaria’s pro-Russian ex-President leads Sunday election

VESELIN TOSHKOV
■ Sofia (Bulgaria)

Bulgarians are heading to a new early election that could bring to power a left-leaning ex-president just days after Hungarian voters rejected the authoritarian policies and global far-right movement of Viktor Orban.

Rumen Radev’s new coalition is seen as favoured to win most of the votes in the April 19 poll, with some voters hoping that this could put an end to the country’s oligarchic corruption, while others are lining up behind Radev’s Eurosceptic and pro-Russian views.

Radev resigned from the mostly ceremonial presidency in January, a few months



before the end of his second term in office, to launch a bid to lead the Government as prime minister. The 62-year-old former fighter pilot and air force commander is seen as Bulgaria’s most popular politician and has promised to give the nation a fresh start if his centre-left Progressive Bulgaria coalition wins the upcoming election. Sunday’s snap vote

follows the resignation of a conservative-led Government amid nationwide anti-corruption protests in December 2025 that drew hundreds of thousands of mainly young people to the streets. Bulgaria, a European Union and NATO member country with a population of 6.5 million, joined the eurozone on Jan. 1 this year shortly

after entering the border-free Schengen travel area. But it has been plagued by political instability since 2021, when three-time conservative Prime Minister Boyko Borissov resigned following massive protests fueled by anger over widespread corruption and injustice. Since then, no Government has survived for more than a year before being brought down by street protests or backroom deals in parliament, resulting in seven inconclusive early elections in five years.

That’s led to growing mistrust in the institutions, voter apathy and a shrinking turnout at the elections. Last month, Bulgaria requested the assistance of

the EU diplomatic service to counter Russian attempts to influence public opinion through social media networks and propaganda websites. The request was based on expert warnings about active networks of Russian influence accounts that seek to sow division.

Opinion polls predict Sunday’s turnout to jump from an average of 35 per cent in the last few elections to over 50 per cent, partly because a new player has joined the race, but also due to efforts by the interim Government to boost confidence in the vote with nationwide police raids, arrests and pretrial proceedings for vote-buying. (AP)

Decorated Australian soldier bailed out on Afghan war crimes charges

ROD MCGUIRK ■ Melbourne

Australia’s most decorated living veteran, Ben Roberts-Smith, was granted bail on Friday, 10 days after he was charged with war crimes in the killings of five people while serving in Afghanistan. Judge Greg Grogin ruled in a Sydney court that the former Special Air Service Regiment corporal had established exceptional circumstances to justify his release from custody. Prosecutors had opposed bail and argued there was a risk that Roberts-Smith would flee Australia or interfere with witnesses and evidence.

Roberts-Smith, 47, was arrested on April 7 and charged with five counts of war crime murder involving the deaths of five Afghans in Uruzgan province in 2009 and 2012. Australian law defines war crime murder as the intentional killing in a context of armed conflict of a person who is not taking



an active part in the hostilities, such as a civilian, prisoner of war or a wounded soldier. Roberts-Smith was awarded both the Victoria Cross and the Medal of Gallantry for his service in Afghanistan and is only the second Australian veteran of the Afghanistan campaign to be charged with a war crime.

The charges follow a military report released in 2020 that found evidence elite SAS and commando regiment troops unlawfully killed 39 Afghan prisoners, farmers and other noncombatants. (AP)

Indian envoy appreciates US support for stronger bilateral ties

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Washington

Indian Ambassador to the US Vinay Mohan Kwatra held talks with US lawmaker Pete Sessions on issues of mutual interest and also appreciated his support for a stronger partnership between the two countries.

“Had a good conversation on issues of mutual interest with Congressman @PeteSessions, Chairman of the Subcommittee on Government Operations in House Oversight Committee today. Appreciate his steadfast support for a stronger India-US partnership,” Kwatra posted on X. Sessions is currently a senior



Indian Ambassador to the US Vinay Mohan Kwatra

member of the House Financial Services Committee and is the Chairman of the Subcommittee on Government Operations in the House Committee on Oversight and Government Reform. Kwatra also appreciat-

ed Sessions’s “steadfast support for a stronger India-US partnership.” On Thursday, Kwatra met US Trade Representative Jamieson Greer and former National Security Adviser Robert O’Brien.

Pope draws a record-breaking crowd of 6,00,000 for historic mass in Douala

NICOLE WINFIELD
■ Yaounde

Pope Leo XIV was marking the halfway point in his four-nation tour of Africa Friday with a day focused on encouraging Cameroon’s young people, first with the big Mass and then a visit to the country’s Catholic university.

Leo was travelling Friday to Douala, Cameroon’s main port city, to celebrate Mass and visit a hospital. The Vatican predicted some 600,000 people would turn out for the liturgy, the biggest crowd Leo is expected to draw on his 11-day odyssey, the first to Africa by history’s first American

pope. Later Friday, Leo has an appointment back in the capital Yaounde with students, professors and administrators at the Catholic University of Central Africa. Popes have often used such encounters, especially in the developing world, to rally young people to persevere in the face of poverty, corruption and other challenges.

Catholics represent about 29 per cent of Cameroon’s 29 million people. It is an overwhelmingly young country, where the median age is 18.

Leo has already offered words of encouragement to Cameroon’s youth, including in his opening speech to President Paul Biya, at 93 the



world’s oldest leader. In the speech, Leo demanded the “chains of corruption” in Cameroon be broken and said Cameroon’s youth represent the future and hope of the country.

But with Biya in power since 1982, Cameroon perhaps represents the most dramatic example of the tension between Africa’s youth and the continent’s many aging leaders.

Despite being an oil-producing country experiencing modest economic growth, young people say the benefits have not trickled down beyond the elites.

“Of course, when unemployment and social exclusion persist, frustration can

lead to violence,” Leo warned in his opening address to Biya and Government authorities earlier this week. “Investing in the education, training, and entrepreneurship of young people is, therefore, a strategic choice for peace. It is the only way to curb the outflow of wonderful talent to other parts of the world.”

According to World Bank data, the unemployment rate in Cameroon stands at 3.5 per cent, but 57 per cent of the labor force aged 18 to 35 works in informal employment. The dire economic outlook in Cameroon has led to significant brain drain and has strained an already understaffed health sector,

as many doctors and nurses are leaving the country for more lucrative jobs in Europe and North America.

In 2023, about a third of doctors who graduated from medical school in Cameroon left the country, according to the Ministry of Higher Education.

Growing frustration over Biya’s record and long-term rule intensified during last October’s tense presidential election, in which Biya secured an eighth consecutive term.

When Cameroon’s main opposition candidate, Issa Tchirama Bakary, contested the result of the poll, deadly protests erupted throughout the country. (AP)

Gadkari to inaugurate two-day Green Transport Conclave 2026

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Indian Federation of Green Energy (IFGE) is set to organize a landmark two-Day Conclave, the Green Transport Conclave: Accelerating Towards the Future of Sustainable and Green Mobility on April 21-22, 2026, in the national Capital.

The event is supported by the Ministry of Road Transport and Highways (MORTH) and the conclave will be inaugurated by Nitin Gadkari, Minister of Road Transport and Highways, Government of India, on April 21, 2026, according to a Press release. India's oldest national English daily The Pioneer (since 1865), Aviation World and Bharat Energy Compass are the media partners and Build India is the Knowledge Partner for the Green Transport Conclave.

The conclave will serve as a high-level platform for exchanging knowledge and highlighting emerging investment opportunities across the green mobility ecosystem, including Automobiles, Railways, Marine, and Aviation. Key discussions will focus on state and central transport models, green transport for



IFGE
Indian Federation of Green Energy

The Pioneer
SINCE 1865

cities (EVs and Biofuels), long-distance freight movement, and the application of AI and automation in modern transportation.

According to Sanjay Ganjoo, Director General, IFGE, India must look inward at its own abundant resources to build a sustainable fuel ecosystem for the transport sector. "In the true spirit of Atmanirbhar Bharat, we can significantly lower our dependence on energy imports, create jobs, build industries, and directly support our farmer communities.

The Green Transport Conclave will support in identifying India's own fuel options that can be systematically explored, developed, and utilised for a self-reliant and greener future," Ganjoo said.

The conclave will feature prominent leaders and policy-

makers, including Sanjay Bandopadhyaya (IAS Retd), Chairman, IFGE; Green Transport; Mobility Committee, Manoj Kumar Singh, CEO, UP State Transformation Commission (STC), Niharika Rai, Secretary-cum-Commissioner, Transport Department, Government of NCT of Delhi, Vikram Gulati, Country Head; Executive Vice President, Toyota Kirloskar Motor amongst others and top official from the Indian railways.

The initiative is further supported by organisations such as Praj Industries, All India Transporters Welfare Association (AITWA) and Bus and Car Operators Confederation of India (BOCI).

The Press release mentioned that India is currently at the centre of a historic energy transformation. As transportation contributes approximately 13-14 per cent of India's total greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions with road transport accounting for over 90 per cent of those emissions this conclave arrives at a critical juncture for the country's multi-fuel decarbonisation strategy.

In the ethanol space, blend-

ing in petrol reached the landmark 20 per cent milestone in November 2025, with OMCs blending 1,022.8 crore litres in ESY 2024-25, while the programme has saved ₹1,06,072 crore in foreign exchange and cut CO₂ emissions by 544 lakh metric tonnes since 2014.

On the maritime front, major ports handled approximately 855 million tonnes of cargo in FY25, backed by a ₹25,000 crore Maritime Development Fund announced in the Union Budget 2025-26. In aviation, India crossed ~239 million passengers in FY 2024-25 and is committed to producing 53 million litres of SAF by 2027 and 290 million litres by 2030. Rounding off this green transition, the nation's EV sector surpassed 2.45 million units sold in 2025-26, with EVs now accounting for over 8 per cent of the total automobile market together signalling an economy firmly on course toward a cleaner, self-reliant energy future.

IFGE is a dedicated national trade body engaged in policy advocacy for the green and bioenergy sector since 2014. It works closely with industry and government to support the structured growth of India's sustainable energy ecosystem.

Flex-fuel vehicles are critical for reshaping India's energy security: AIDA

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Having over 43 years of experience in sugar and ethanol industry Vijendra Singh has managed sugar & ethanol businesses in states of Uttar Pradesh, Karnataka, and Maharashtra in India, as well as in Brazil. He currently serves as the President of the All India Distillers' Association (AIDA)—the apex national body representing the distillery and ethanol industry in India—and is also the Executive Director & Deputy Chief Executive Officer of Shree Renuka Sugars Limited, one of India's prominent integrated sugar and bioenergy companies.

Singh was elected President of AIDA at the Annual General Meeting held on 8 August 2025. In his role, he represents the distillery and ethanol sector on policy, regulatory, sustainability, and industry-development platforms.

In a conversation with The Pioneer he gives his perspective on Flex-Fuel Vehicles (FFVs) — Strategic Imperative for India's Energy Security. Excerpts:

■ **India imports over 80% of its crude oil. In your view, how critical are Flex-Fuel Vehicles (FFVs) in reshaping India's long-term energy security strategy?**

Ans - Flex-Fuel Vehicles (FFVs) are highly critical for reshaping India's energy security by shifting the nation's transport dependency from imported fossil fuels to domestic agricultural resources.

The following points outline their importance: **Direct Reduction of Import Dependency** India's extreme dependence on crude oil imports can be mitigated because ethanol raw materials are entirely grown by Indian farmers. While current E20 blending (20% ethanol) is a major step, going beyond this threshold is "very difficult" without the rapid rollout of FFVs and Ethanol Hybrids. By enabling vehicles to run on much



AIDA President Vijendra Singh

higher percentages of ethanol (up to E100), India can utilize its "net realistic capacity" of 1,450 crore litres of ethanol. This internal supply helps insulate the economy from global oil price volatility and reduces the massive foreign exchange outflow required for 80%+ crude imports.

■ **Economic and Agricultural Stability** The critical role of FFVs extends to India's internal economic security by providing a stable market for surplus agricultural produce. With current maize production at 35 million tons, increasing the yield to 5 tons per hectare (closer to the world average of 6 tons) would provide an additional 15 million tons of maize. This surplus alone could generate 562 crore litres of additional ethanol. By creating a "Farm-to-Fuel" pipeline, FFVs ensure that national energy expenditures are redirected into the pockets of Indian farmers rather than foreign oil producers.

■ **Environmental and Health Security** Energy security strategy also encompasses long-term health of population. Ethanol is a high-octane fuel (109 RON) that acts as natural oxygenate, helping petrol burn more efficiently. This allows for replacement of harmful, cancer-causing synthetic aromatics like benzene, toluene.

■ **With increasing geopolitical disruptions affecting oil supply chains, do you see FFVs as a strategic hedge against global volatility, or merely a transitional solution?**

Ans - FFVs serve as a critical strategic hedge by decoupling the transport sector

from volatile global energy markets. Currently, India faces extreme vulnerability due to its heavy reliance on crude oil imports, which are often subject to geopolitical tensions and maritime supply chain disruptions. By shifting the fuel base to ethanol—a resource grown entirely by domestic farmers—FFVs ensure that national energy security is maintained regardless of international conflicts. This transition transforms energy from a geo-strategic liability into a manageable domestic commodity.

■ **How does AIDA position FFVs within India's broader clean mobility roadmap alongside EVs, hydrogen, and CNG?**

Ans - AIDA positions FFVs as a frontline defense against "disturbances in the Gulf region" and the resulting energy supply chain disruptions. FFVs are ready for "large-scale rollout" because several Original Equipment Manufacturers (OEMs) already have market-ready prototypes. This makes FFVs a primary tool for "proportionately reducing dependence on fuel imports" during critical periods of global volatility.

■ **Bridge to High-Blend and Pure Ethanol Usage** The roadmap identifies a need to move beyond the current E20 limit, with AIDA recommending a phased increase to 30% blending. FFVs are positioned as the essential vehicle technology to facilitate this transition, as standard engines cannot handle these higher concentrations. By enabling vehicles to run on everything from E20 to E100 (pure ethanol), FFVs unlock the "full potential of ethanol" as a strategic pillar for India's energy transition.

■ **Synergy with Rural and Industrial Economy** Unlike mobility solutions that rely on imported minerals or complex new gases, FFVs are positioned as part of a "unique model" where national energy goals converge with the rural economy. The roadmap sees

FFVs working in tandem with other ethanol applications—such as ethanol for cooking fuel in hospitals and industrial kitchens or future blending in diesel—to create a comprehensive bioenergy ecosystem. This ensures that energy expenditures directly support Indian agricultural resources and industrial capability.

■ **How prepared are Indian automotive manufacturers to scale FFV production at a mass level?**

Ans - Indian automotive manufacturers are technically prepared for a mass-level transition. As stated in AIDA's letter to the Ministry, several Original Equipment Manufacturers (OEMs) are already equipped with "market-ready prototypes" for Flex-Fuel Vehicles. This indicates that the core engineering, including ethanol-compatible fuel systems and engine calibrations, has already been developed and tested for the Indian market.

The readiness is particularly visible in the two-wheeler and passenger car segments. Major companies like Toyota, Suzuki, and TVS are actively developing and showcasing FFVs designed to run on higher ethanol blends (up to E85 or E100), aiming to reduce reliance on imported oil and lower emissions. These manufacturers are capable of scaling up production rapidly, as the transition leverages existing internal combustion engine (ICE) production lines, requiring only specific component upgrades rather than a complete overhaul of manufacturing infrastructure.

Despite being technically ready, mass scaling is currently hindered by economic barriers. Manufacturers are hesitant to move into high-volume production because FFVs currently face a high GST rate of 28% to 48%. Without "policy support, incentives, and tax concessions" to make these vehicles affordable for the public, manufacturers cannot justify the investment required for full-scale commercial rollout.



HN Sharma, Political Advisor to former Prime Minister Chandra Shekhar, Ram Bahadur Rai; Padma Bhushan, Chairman of the IGNCIA, and other dignitaries, on the occasion of the birth anniversary celebrations of former PM Chandra Shekhar at the Chandrashekhar Bhawan in New Delhi

PANKAJ KUMAR

DAILY SUDOKU

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1		7				5	8
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			4	1	5		
		3	2	9			7
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9	6	2				8	3
			6				

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9×9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3×3 box, using elimination and logical deduction—no maths involved.



SOLUTION (17.04.26)								
2	7	4	6	5	1	3	9	8
6	3	1	9	8	7	4	5	2
9	5	8	2	4	3	7	1	6
8	4	2	1	6	9	5	3	7
3	9	6	5	7	4	2	8	1
5	1	7	8	3	2	6	4	9
4	6	9	3	2	8	1	7	5
1	2	3	7	9	5	8	6	4
7	8	5	4	1	6	9	2	3

DOUBLE CROSSWORD

SATURDAY | APRIL 18, 2026

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10	11	12		13	
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34					
36					

ACROSS

- 4 It's nice and warm, for a change, in Ealing (6)
7 Such work may seem too much for a while (8)
8 Join to get the club promoted (4,2)
10 He's funny, as many will admit (5)
13 Dash off to fix things (4)
14 To me, a little house (4)
15 We're out to get in for a drink (4)
16 Favourite part of Peterborough (3)
17 The opposite of hen, in a sense (4)
19 It's useless putting one in a truck i(4)
21 The chap to flatter, perhaps, but it must be sincere (9)

DOWN

- 1 Affect just a little (5)
2 An oven faulty at the bottom end will do you no good! (5)
3 Knock out with a snooker cue? (4)
4 Be progressively friendly (3,2)
5 Practised without weakening (4)
6 Some faculty men have; call it insight (6)
9 A team of two, as the Romans would have figured? (6)
11 Like the setting sun, if you look west (3)
12 River flowing into a sewer? (5)
13 It's largely known as Wellingtonia (3,4)
15 In attrition, perhaps, endlessly wary (3)
16 After a poor start, it may yield coal (3)
18 Wildly contradicted (6)

- 23 It's of growing potential (4)
24 Current charge? (4)
26 Female of the cassowary (3)
27 Regarded as a bit of a key man (4)
29 State definitely it's the little turning on the right (4)
32 Run away and shelter at the welfare centre (4)
33 Spring gave heart to the Pharisees (5)
34 Where, abroad, Alma got mixed up with some Yanks (6)
35 Where the wealthy go on most Mondays (8)
36 Be a close thing! (6)

- 20 The Gibraltarian's table (5)
21 The way shown between two points (3)
22 Prevented a G-man from starving (3)
23 No hero in the cod war (6)
25 Like the French, he's free from deceit (3)
28 Desire strongly – yes, to join the Navy! (5)
30 Through which to see a girl's love for Romeo (5)
31 Prepared, once more, for the new day (5)
32 It's played a great deal for nothing (4)
33 Each can bring a yearning (4)

CPI(M) delegation stages sit-in outside Noida DM's residence

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A delegation of CPI(M) leaders staged sit-in protests twice in Noida on Friday, after they were stopped from meeting families of workers detained following agitations earlier this week. The delegation, led by Communist Party of India (Marxist) general secretary M A Baby, reached Noida on Friday morning, days after protests demanding fair wages and better working conditions turned violent, leading to a police crackdown and arrests. However, police initially stopped them at the Delhi-Noida border, citing a "tense situation" and denying permission for "political persons" to proceed. The leaders then held a roadside sit-in, without blocking traffic. "We had two bouts of sit-ins. First, when we were stopped at the Noida border by the additional commissioner, they said the DM cannot meet you, the situation is tense and we cannot allow political people to go any further," Baby said.

Baby was accompanied by Lok Sabha MP Amra Ram, Rajya Sabha MPs V Sivadasan, A A Rahim and the party's Politburo member Arun Kumar. They were later joined by Delhi CPI(M) leaders Anurag Saxena and Pushpendra Tyagi as well as Rajya Sabha MP John Brittas. Baby said police then assured them that district magistrate (DM) would meet them, but they were taken to a police camp instead.



Asom Gana Parishad leaders and Assam ministers Atul Bora and Keshab Mahanta called upon BJP President Nitin Nabin in New Delhi

Guru Nanak Dev University, Amritsar
Tender Notice
The Department of G.N.D.U. Amritsar invites online bids for the following:

Sr. No.	Reference No.	Item	Quantity	Closing Date & Time
1	GNDU/Gen/10/2026	Supply of various type of Photocopier Paper	6150 ream	27-04-2026 at 5:00 P.M.

For details log onto www.eproc.punjab.gov.in
Note: Any corrigendum(s) to the tender notice shall be published on the above website only.
2426/12/2026-27/10606 Dated CHD - 17/04/2026

कार्यालय नगर पालिक निगम, देवास (म.प्र.)
लि.क्र./E-T.PRO./ 1/DWS/2026 देवास दिनांक: 13.04.2026

// ई-निविदा सूचना //

निम्नलिखित कार्य हेतु केंद्रीयकृत प्रणाली में संबोधित टेकेंडरों में ऑनलाइन ई-निविदाएं आमंत्रित की जाती हैं। उक्त ई-निविदा का विस्तृत विवरण वेबसाइट <https://www.mptenders.gov.in> पर देखा जा सकता है।

क्र.	टेंडर क्रमांक जारी दिनांक	कार्य का नाम	कार्य की समयवधि वर्षांकाल सहित एवं लागत रु. लिखित में	निविदा प्रश्न : का मूल्य एवं EMD	निविदा की अंतिम तिथि
1	2	3	4	5	6
1	2026_UAD_499880_1 Date: 15.04.2026	Construction of Shopping Centre in Shalini Market at Shalini Road, Dewas.	1. समयवधि 12 माह 2. लागत रु. 328.29 लाख (निटिडाइट लाइसेंस)	1. रु. 15,000/- 2. रु. 1,64,148/-	6.05.2026

नोट:- निविदा में संबंधित किसी भी प्रकार के संशोधन का प्रकाशन ऑनलाइन <https://www.mptenders.gov.in> की वेबसाइट पर ही किया जायेगा, सूचक से समाचार पत्र में प्रकाशन नहीं किया जायेगा।

हस्ता/-

कार्यालय नंरी,

नगर पालिक निगम, देवास

PARADIP PORT AUTHORITY
MARINE DEPARTMENT
No.MD/ACCTS/W/R-03/2025/391 Date: 30.03.2026
Name of the Work: Hiring of 01 no. 25 Knots Speed-Cum-Chase Boat (RSV4/MS Act) along with Manning Crew for a period of 05 (five) years. Estimated cost put to tender - Total Estimated cost including Hire Charges & Fuel: Rs.14,37,86,157/- excluding GST. Estimated cost put to Tender towards Hire Charges only Rs.10,29,22,450/- excluding GST. Last date & time of submission of tender through on-line bidding is 17:00 Hours on 04.05.2026. Date & time for opening of Technical Bid is 10:30 hours on 04.05/05/2026. For further details, please log on to the Website: <https://eproc.ppa.gov.in/procure.asp>
Sd/- Deputy Conservator,
Paradip Port Authority
PPA/PR/06/2026-2027 dtd. 17.04.2026

 BRIEFLY

Australia to tour Pakistan in May-June for ODI series



The Australian cricket team is set to tour Pakistan in late May to play a three-match ODI series in Lahore and Rawalpindi, PCB sources said on Friday. The series is a part of the agreement between the two Cricket Australia (CA) and Pakistan Cricket Board (PCB) under which the Australian T20 side visited the country before the T20 World Cup and played three matches in Lahore. The details of the tour are being finalised with Cricket Australia but the matches will tentatively be held between May 30 and June 5. The source added that the Australian team will fly from Pakistan to Bangladesh to play an ODI series June 9. Cricket Australia had sent a depleted side to Pakistan for the T20 matches due to a number of their main players recovering from fitness issues or being rested for the World Cup in India and Sri Lanka. Australia eventually didn't fare well in the World Cup. Pakistan are due to visit Bangladesh for a two-Test series between May 8 and 20 after the conclusion of after Pakistan Super League (PSL) but their most important assignment this year is a three-Test series in England in August and September which is part of the ICC World Test Championship.

Aditi Ashok T-59 despite under-par round



Aditi Ashok began her week in Los Angeles with a round of 2-under 70 to find herself placed tied 59th on the leaderboard at the JM Eagle LA Championship on the LPGA Tour. Aditi began her round on the front nine and had made seven pars before dropping a shot on the eighth hole with a bogey. From 1-over after 10 holes, she recovered on the back nine she made birdies on the 11th, 16th and 18th holes to pick up three shots and finish at 2-under par, seven shots behind the leader Chizzy Iwai. Iwai had a fast start to her opening round. Having started on the back nine she made par on the 10th holes before making five consecutive birdies and an eagle to be seven under par after seven holes. Another set of birdies on the first and fifth holes would see her end the day at 9-under 63 with a two-shot lead over her closest rivals. Patty Tavatanakit, Suvichaya Vinijchaitam and Sei Young Kim are tied for second place with scores of 7-under par.

Ludvig Aberg leads at Hilton Head with a 63

DOUG FERGUSON
■ Hilton Head Island (USA)

Ludvig Aberg swapped out some sloppy mistakes at the Masters with pure iron play at Harbour Town in warm, swirling wind that produced an 8-under 63 for a one-shot lead Thursday in the RBC Heritage.

Aberg moved ahead of Harris English and Viktor Hovland with an 8-iron to about 15 feet on the back corner of the green on the par-3 17th and made the birdie. He closed with a par, pleasing because he felt that 8-iron confirmed how well he was swinging the club.

Houston Open champion Gary Woodland, Matt Fitzpatrick and Rickie Fowler were in the group of players



at 65. Masters champion Rory McIlroy skipped this \$20 million signature event for the second straight year, having said Harbour Town doesn't suit him.

Scottie Scheffler, the runner-up last week at Augusta after a 65-68 finish,

Aston Villa set for semifinal against Nottingham Forest

KAREL JANICEK
■ Birmingham

Ollie Watkins scored again as Aston Villa knocked out Bologna out of the Europa League in a 4-0 rout Thursday to set up an all-English semifinal against Nottingham Forest. Unai Emery's team reached its second European semifinal in three seasons with a 7-1 aggregate victory. Watkins had netted twice in last week's 3-1 win in the first leg of the quarterfinal in Italy, and the striker set the pace at Villa Park.

He tapped in a low cross from the left provided by Morgan Rogers for a 1-0 lead after 16 minutes for his 100th goal for Villa. Rogers had a

golden opportunity to increase the lead but Bologna goalkeeper Federico Ravaglia saved his penalty kick.

Only a minute later, though, Villa doubled its lead when Emiliano Buendia scored from a tight angle. Rogers made it 3-0 with another angled shot in the 39th, and Ezri Konsa finished the scoring seconds before the final whistle. Villa reached the Champions League quarterfinals last season and is on course to secure a spot in the lucrative top-tier competition next campaign while sitting fourth in the Premier League.

Big return to Europe: Forest made the semifinals by beating 10-man Porto 1-0 in



what's been a successful return to European competition after a 30-year absence. It advanced 2-1 on aggregate after last week's draw in Portugal. Morgan Gibbs-White put the hosts ahead in the 12th minute with a

deflected effort from outside the box after Porto defender Jan Bednarek was sent off for fouling Chris Wood, who then had to be substituted with a knee injury. Wood is a key striker for relegation-threatened Nottingham — and New

Theegala gets off to a good start at RBC Heritage

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Hilton Head Island (USA)

Sahithi Theegala started his week at the RBC Heritage with an opening round of 2-under 69 and was placed T-27 on the leaderboard in the \$20m Signature event here. Though Theegala was six shots behind the leader, Sweden's Ludvig Aberg, the start was encouraging as he made three birdies in the first four holes and four in the first seven.

However, he gave up a lot of those gains on the back nine. Two other players of Indian origin, Akshay Bhatia and Sudarshan Yellamaraju had much slower starts.

Bhatia carded 2-over 73 and was T-65 while



Yellamaraju carded 3-over 74 to be placed T-70.

Theegala started his round with consecutive birdies on the first two holes before dropping a shot on the third. He quickly recovered with another birdie on the fourth. He made birdies on the seventh and ninth holes to

put himself in a strong position at 4-under before the turn. On the back nine Theegala made bogeys on the 10th, 11th and 18th holes and had only one birdie on the 15th hole to end the day with a card of 2-under 69.

Bhatia carded 2-over 73 in a round where he made

three bogeys and one birdie. Bhatia has struggled after The Players Championship as he missed the cut at The Hero Indian Open and The Masters. Yellamaraju carded 3-over 74. He began his round with a triple bogey which was followed by his only birdie of the round. A bogey on the 14th hole saw him drop another shot and finish the day at 3-over par. Aberg, who has five consecutive top-25 finishes heading into this week, is seeking his third PGA Tour title.

His bogey free round of 8-under 63 gave him a one stroke lead as Harris English and Viktor Hovland are tied for second place after carding 7-under 64 each for their opening round.

Chizzy Iwai shoots 63 to take a 2-shot lead in Los Angeles

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Los Angeles

Chizzy Iwai played her first seven holes in 7 under, capped by an eagle on the par-5 16th, and shot a 9-under 63 on Thursday to take a two-stroke lead in the JM Eagle LA Championship.

The tournament at El Caballero Country Club — the tree-lined layout subbing for Wilshire Country Club for the second straight year because of course renovations - is the final event before the major Chevron Championship next week in Houston. Former UCLA player Patty Tavatanakit was tied for second at 65 with Sei Young Kim and Suvichaya Vinijchaitam.

Iwai opened her morning round with a par on No. 10,



then birdied the next five and eagled the 16th.

"Good tee time in morning, so very peaceful and I feel comfortable," the 23-year-old Japanese player said "I had a feeling so relaxing. I had a good feeling."

On her second nine, she added birdies on Nos. 1 and 5. She matched the lowest

score in the two years at El Caballero. "A little bit thinking 58 or 59," she said. "But golf is not easy." Iwai won the Mexico Riviera Maya Open last year for her first LPGA Tour victory. Twin sister Akie Iwai was second a year ago at El Caballero and won the Portland Classic last summer for her first LPGA

title. Akie Iwai shot 70 on Thursday, playing in the group ahead of her sister. Tavatanakit had eight birdies and a bogey in the morning session. "My ball-striking felt really good," Tavatanakit said. "Just a solid day. Made a lot of putts." Lauren Coughlin, the winner two weeks ago at Shadow Creek outside Las Vegas, topped the group at 66. Hannah Green, the 2023 and 2024 winner at Wilshire, shot 67.

"I just feel very comfortable when I'm back here in LA," Green said. "Doesn't really matter if it's Wilshire."

The Australian has three worldwide wins this year — the HSBC Women's World Championship on the LPGA Tour along with the Women's Australian Open and Australian WPGA.

Zealand's World Cup plans — and only recently returned from a long-term knee injury.

Porto has never beaten a Premier League club in England in 24 attempts. The last time Nottingham reached a European semifinal was in 1984 in the UEFA Cup. **Freiburg's first final four:** Freiburg marched into the semifinals by beating Celta Vigo 3-1. The Bundesliga team reached the last four in a European competition for the first time on a 6-1 aggregate score after last week's 3-0 victory in the first leg of the quarterfinal.

Freiburg has scored 11 goals in its last three games in the second-tier competition. Igor Matanovic put Freiburg 1-0 up

with a stunning left-footed volley from outside the area. Yuito Suzuki doubled the advantage with a deflected shot late in the first half and then beat goalkeeper Ionut Radu after interval. Williot Swedberg's consolation goal came in stoppage time for the Spanish hosts.

Freiburg's next opponent will be Braga, which came from two goals down to win 4-2 at Real Betis after those teams were tied 1-1 from the first leg.

Crystal Palace in Conference League semifinals: Crystal Palace clinched a last-four spot in the third-tier Conference League despite a 2-1 loss to Fiorentina in Florence. (AP)

Bernhard Langer shares lead at Senior PGA Championship



ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Bradenton (USA)

Bernhard Langer had a double bogey and still broke his age by two shots as the 68-year-old German posted a 6-under 66 on Thursday, giving him a share of the lead after the opening round of the Senior PGA Championship.

Langer, who already holds the record with 12 senior majors, played his final six holes in 5-under par, highlighted by an eagle on the par-5 17th hole at Concession Golf Club.

He was tied with Miguel Angel Jimenez, Brian Gay and Steve Allan of Australia. Langer now has shot his age or better 43 times. "It's fun to shoot my age," he said. "So whenever I shoot my age or better, usually I've played some good golf. That's one of the goals these days, especially when you play a difficult golf course, and these greens here are very difficult."

This is the first year of a three-year contract for Concession to host the Senior

PGA Championship, the oldest of the senior majors. It's also the only senior major Langer has won only one time, in 2017 at Trump National in Virginia.

The 62-year-old Jimenez had an eagle on the par-5 seventh hole and went out in 31 before cooling on the back nine. Allan played bogey-free, picking up birdies on all but one of the par 5s. Gay birdied three of his final four holes. They were one shot ahead of Ben Crane, Retief Goosen and Thammanoon Sriro, the 56-year-old Thai who had five wins on the Asian Tour. Crane is making his senior major debut having turned 50 last month.

Two-time Masters champion Jose Maria Olazabal, three-time major champion Padraig Harrington and Greg Chalmers were at 68. Henrik Stenson also made his senior debut — he turned 50 on April 5 — and opened with a 72. Stenson, the 2016 British Open champion, had been on Saudi-funded LIV Golf since 2022 but was relegated from the league last fall.

Pranavi best placed to make the cut in Joburg Open

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Johannesburg

Pranavi Urs carded a bogey free 3-under 70 in the first round of the Joburg Ladies Open on the Ladies European Tour and was best placed to make the cut among the five Indians at the event. At the end of Day 1, she was Tied-21st at the Par-73 Randpark Golf Club.

Tvesa Malik and Diksha Dagar ended the first round at 1-under 72 and were Tied-54th while Avani Prashanth shot 2-over 75 and Hitaashee Bakshi also had a disappointing day with 4-over 77.

Avani and Hitaashee will need to shoot very low



rounds to make the cut.

Tvesa, playing her first LET event of the season, was 4-under at one stage through the front nine but finished at 1-under 72 as he gave away

a double bogey and a bogey on the 15th and the 16th holes. Diksha, ninth on the LET Order of Merit, had five birdies, three bogeys and a double in her round of 72.

Rayhan Thomas makes slow start in Mexico

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Tulum (Mexico)

Rayhan Thomas carded an opening round of even par 72 and was T-60 at the Tulum Championship at the PGA Riviera on the Korn Ferry Tour.

Thomas began his round on the front nine and made birdies on the fourth and eighth holes along with a bogey on the fifth to be 1-under par at the turn.

On the back nine, Thomas made a late bogey on the 17th to end his day with an even par card with two birdies and two bogeys to be placed T-60 on the leaderboard. Julian Suri shot 5-over 77



and is placed T-132 on the leaderboard and has a lot of ground to cover if he hopes to avoid a third missed cut in a row. Caleb VanArragon and Jacob Solomon lead the field after both players carded rounds of 6-under 66.

Star sprinter Gout Gout qualifies fastest for 100 metres at Australian junior track titles

ASSOCIATED PRESS
■ Brisbane (Australia)

Star teenager Gout Gout has qualified fastest for Saturday's 100-metre semifinals at the Australian junior athletics championships, less than a week after setting an under-20 world record time in the 200 that was faster than Usain Bolt's best at that age.

The 18-year-old Australian sprinter finished Friday in a time of 10.19 seconds at the Queensland Sport and Athletics Centre. He entered the heats with the best qualifying time of 10.0 seconds.

Local media is reporting Gout has his eye on lowering Patrick Johnson's national open record for the 100 of

9.93, set in Japan in 2003. Last Sunday, Gout ran his 200-meter final at the open national titles in 19.67 seconds, taking 0.02 off Erriyon Knighton's world under-20 mark of 19.69 set at Eugene in 2022.

Knighton also ran a 19.49 in 2022, which World Athletics says is the fastest time ever by an under-20 athlete despite it not being ratified as a world under-20 record. Gout's time last week placed him above sprinting great Bolt at No. 2 in the all-time under-20 list.

It was the first time that Gout had gone under the 20-second mark officially, after a wind-assisted 19.84 last season, and is the leading



time in the world this year. Gout previously had the quickest time by a 16-year-old, setting an Australian record of 20.06 in 2024.

Last Sunday's mark in Sydney put him ahead of eight-time Olympic champi-

on Bolt's time of 19.93 in 2004. Bolt was 17 when setting what was then a world junior record and never bettered that time as a teenager. "This is what I've been waiting for," Gout, who was born in Queensland

state to parents from South Sudan, said after his 200-meter win. "There's a big weight off my shoulders knowing I ran it legally, and I have the speed and my body to run times like that. So, it definitely feels great, and ready for more."

Gout's 200 time in Sydney was met with skepticism from several sprinters, mostly in the US, who said the record was achieved under questionable wind conditions. Some said that up to seven runners achieved season-best times in the race — although that often happens in national championships. "There are always going to be haters, if you've got haters it means you're

doing something right," Gout told the Brisbane Times on Friday, referring to the critical comments. "It is what it is, I never take it (to heart), I just keep running, and obviously, it was pretty fast so that's maybe why they were a bit mad."

It motivates me to do it in even bigger races, for sure." Gout will go into Saturday's semifinal as a firm favorite. "I definitely have more in the tank. Last week was a great run, and I'm hoping to keep the same" in Brisbane, he said. "Hopefully, the wind stays pretty calm, and anything's possible. It was a good run, definitely saved myself for finals. I can't wait for tomorrow."

Gill's 86, Rabada-Siraj burst help GT win over KKR

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Ahmedabad

Shubman Gill's elegant 86 complemented a probing new-ball spell from Kagiso Rabada and Mohammed Siraj as Gujarat Titans registered a commanding five-wicket win over laggards Kolkata Knight Riders in the Indian Premier League here on Friday.

Gill was in complete command, firing on all cylinders as he steered the Titans to their third win of the season. This was after the pace duo of Rabada (3/29) and Siraj (2/23) had ripped through the KKR top order, exploiting movement with the new ball to bowl them out for 180. KKR's total was largely

propped up by Cameron Green's fighting 79 off 55 balls, his first significant contribution with the bat this season. The former champions continue to remain winless in the ongoing edition.

The two powerplays told the tale of the match. While KKR limped to 37 for 3, Gill powered GT to a commanding 71 for 1, seizing early control of the chase.

Chasing a below par total, Gill set the tone from the outset, striking three boundaries, including a pristine straight drive, and a six in the first three overs.

He then anchored the innings with poise, pacing his knock to perfection. His innings was peppered with



eight fours and four sixes. While KKR managed to pick up a few wickets, they were never able to stem the flow of runs or apply sustained pressure.

When Sai Sudharsan departed, Jos Buttler ensured there was no let-up, announcing his arrival by cracking a boundary off his first ball before following it up with a six and another four in quick succession.

Earlier, KKR were rocked early, losing three wickets in the first four overs.

Rabada and Siraj bowled with precision, while Ashok Sharma (2/45) and Prasidh Krishna (1/32) provided able support. Green, who found it hard to

get going in the beginning, weathered the early storm before breaking free in the middle overs, smashing seven fours and four sixes in his 55-ball stay.

He stitched together a 55-run stand with Rovman Powell and followed it up with a 60-run partnership with Anukul Roy.

Green particularly relished facing Rashid Khan, taking him apart for five boundaries and four sixes but the Afghanistan spinner had him caught behind off the final ball of the innings.

Luck, too, favoured him. He survived an early LBW appeal, saw an outside edge fly to the boundary, and was dropped on 62 by Washington Sundar

off the very next ball. However, he waged a lone battle as no other KKR batter could survive in the middle for long.

To add to KKR's woes, Green was starved of strike towards the fag end of the innings, watching wickets tumble at the non-striker's end.

Siraj and Rabada had set the tone of the match in the powerplay itself.

Ajinkya Rahane was the first to fall, dismissed for a golden duck in the opening over by Siraj. Rabada then struck with the ball, producing a lovely outswinger that drew young Angkrish Raghuvanshi into a tentative poke, only to find the edge through to the wicket-keeper.

Canada's T20 World Cup match against NZ under ICC scrutiny

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

The ICC is investigating Cricket Canada for alleged breach of its anti-corruption code, including the national team's loss to New Zealand in a T20 World Cup match held on February 17 in Chennai, a media report has stated.

The game at Chepauk, which Canada lost by eight wickets, has come under scrutiny from the ICC's Anti-Corruption Unit (ACU) following allegations of corruption highlighted in a recently-aired documentary.

Electing to bat, Canada had posted 173/4, before New Zealand chased it down in just 15.1 overs. Glenn Phillips (59 not out off 39 balls) and Rachin Ravindra (76 not out off 36) sealed the win to confirm the Black Caps' Super Eight berth.

According to ESPNcricinfo, the ACU is probing multiple allegations linked to Cricket Canada and "two active investigations that span elements of Cricket Canada and allegations of breaches of the ICC's anti-corruption code at international and domestic level as well".

The allegations came into light in a 43-minute documentary, Corruption, Crime and Cricket, produced by Canadian investigative programme 'the fifth estate' and aired by CBC on Friday.

The film makes wide-ranging claims about corruption and governance issues in Canadian cricket.

As per the documentary, the World Cup match against



New Zealand is under scrutiny, particularly the fifth over of the chase bowled by Canada captain Dilpreet Bajwa.

Appointed captain just three weeks before the tournament, Bajwa, a batting all-rounder who bowls off-spin, came on to bowl with New Zealand at 35/2.

He began the over with a no-ball, followed it with a wide down the leg side, and went on to concede 15 runs.

"Consistent with its established operating procedures, the ACU is not in a position to comment on the substance of any allegations contained within it (the documentary)," Andrew Ephgrave, interim General Manager of the ICC's Integrity Unit, said in a statement to ESPNcricinfo.

"Governance matters in relation to ICC Members are considered by the ICC, where they fall under its jurisdiction, in accordance with the ICC's

standard constitutional processes.

"The ICC's Anti-Corruption Unit operates across three core functions: intelligence, prevention and education, and investigation. These functions operate concurrently and are applied wherever there is a credible basis to believe the integrity of the sport may be at risk."

Canada had started with pace in the match through Jaskaran Singh and Dilon Heyliger, who conceded 15 and 14 runs respectively.

Spin was introduced in the third over, when Saad bin Zafar bowled a wicket maiden, while Heyliger picked up a wicket in the fourth over.

The second investigation relates to a leaked phone recording involving former Canada coach Khurram Chohan, in which he alleges that senior (now former) board members pressured him to select certain players.

RCB eye dominance over inconsistent Delhi Capitals

G UNNIKRISHNAN ■ Bengaluru

Almost a month into IPL 2026, Royal Challengers Bengaluru have evolved into the most complete unit in the competition and they will be eager to strengthen their hold on this tag when they face the struggling Delhi Capitals here on Saturday.

Focus has largely remained on Virat Kohli, and the batting talisman has not disappointed his fans either, holding the Orange Cap for the time being. But even Kohli would acknowledge that the RCB batting no longer solely depends on him.

Skipper Rajat Patidar, Devdutt Padikkal, Phil Salt and Tim David have all left their indelible marks on RCB's victories this season with buccaneering batting efforts, and they will be eager for an encore against DC.

Patidar, in particular, has been impressive with his awesome six-hitting spree, leading the chart with



21 maximums from five matches and three ahead of the marauding Vaibhav Sooryavanshi of Rajasthan Royals.

These efforts have probably freed up Kohli to pursue his craft, calm in the knowledge that there are more shoulders to carry the side's batting.

In contrast, the Capitals are still

We need to take some tough calls: Hardik Pandya

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Mumbai

Skipper Hardik Pandya did not mince his words after Mumbai Indians crashed to their fourth successive defeat in IPL 2026, warning about taking a few "difficult calls" and reminded his misfiring teammates of the need to take "ownership" of the team's poor outings.

In their latest debacle, the five-time champions lost to Punjab Kings by seven wickets and are now languishing ninth on the table with just two points. "To be very honest, I don't have much to say right now. I think we really need to go back on the drawing board and see where we are lacking. Is it individuals? Is it as a group? Is it planning? We'll just figure it out and see what we can do next," said Pandya after another morale-shattering loss on Thursday night.

Indirectly, Pandya might have been



hinting at the faltering show of MI seniors like Suryakumar Yadav, Jasprit Bumrah and Tilak Varma.

"No, I think we need to see, do we need to make some difficult calls or do we need to keep continuing and hope that we'll turn things around. These are some harsh questions

which eventually we need to answer and yeah, ownership has to be taken," he said. Suryakumar has scored a fifty but his other scores have been 16, 6, 33 and 0 and Tilak Varma has a modest sequence of 20, 0, 14, 1 and 8.

The talismanic Jasprit Bumrah is yet to take a wicket in five games and has given away runs at 8.63 per over.

However, Pandya credited the opposition for out-thinking them in all departments of the game.

"I think we need to give credit to them as well. The ball started reversing. In the second inning the dew came and it slightly got better but having said that, they just outbeat us. They bowled better, they batted better, they fielded better definitely and that talks to us again.

Punjab captain Shreyas Iyer, who made a 35-ball 66 in the successful chase against MI, said staying grounded has helped the side execute their

Balanced SRH face resurgent Chennai Super Kings

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Hyderabad

Having unleashed two exciting pace prospects in Praful Hinge and Sakib Husain, a balanced Sunrisers Hyderabad will head into their IPL match against Chennai Super Kings with renewed confidence, here on Saturday.

Drafted in place of seasoned campaigners Harshal Patel and Jaydev Unadkat, the uncapped duo made an instant impact, reducing Rajasthan Royals to 9 for 5 inside the first three overs, pushing them to their first loss of the season.

The 24-year-old Vidarbha pacer Hinge has been the standout bowler after dis-



mantling the Royals' top-order consisting Dhruv Jurel, Lhuan-dre Pretorius and skipper Riyan Parag in his fiery first two overs. He finished with 4/34.

Generating bounce from a

back-of-a-length spot, Hinge was impressive, while Husain, an unheralded 21-year-old from Bihar who was previously overlooked by Kolkata Knight Riders, complimented him well on debut.

Using clever variations in the middle overs, Husain also returned with four wickets as Rajasthan were bowled out for 159 while chasing 216.

The emergence of the young duo has lifted SRH's pace attack, which had been a concern early in the season, and brought better balance to a side otherwise loaded with batting firepower in Abhishek Sharma, Travis Head, Ishan Kishan and Heinrich Klaasen.

Fresh from their breakout performances, Hinge and Husain will look to pile more pressure on CSK skipper Ruturaj Gaikwad, who has struggled for runs this season. His highest so far is 28 across five innings.

However, there is some relief for CSK with Sanju Samson rediscovering his T20 World Cup form, smashing an unbeaten century against Delhi Capitals and following it up with a 48 in their win over Kolkata Knight Riders.

With Gaikwad out of touch, CSK could consider pushing him down the order and promoting young Ayush Mhatre, who has impressed with two fifties in his last four innings.

After a poor start with three consecutive defeats, the five-time champions — still without MS Dhoni, who is expected to be fit for the next game in Mumbai — have bounced back with two successive wins.

Yuvraj Singh inks partnership with UAE-based realtor

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ New Delhi

World Cup-winning former India all-rounder Yuvraj Singh has been roped in by a UAE-based real estate developer for a brand partnership.

The campaign, titled 'Against All Odds', traces Yuvraj's journey, aligning it with BNW Developers' growth in the UAE.

Yuvraj said the collaboration reflects his philosophy of carving an individual path to success.

"It's about taking charge and winning on your own terms. This film is for anyone who's been underestimated and proved people wrong,"



he was quoted as saying in a press release.

Commenting on the partnership, BNW Developers Chairman and Founder Ankur Aggarwal said the association reflects a shared belief in challenging the status quo.

Going back to basics worked for Arshdeep Singh: Bahutule

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
■ Mumbai

India and Punjab Kings' pacer Arshdeep Singh did not have the brightest of starts in the IPL this year but a back-to-basics approach, including a lot of "target bowling" in the nets, has helped him regain his form, says his franchise coach Sairaj Bahutule.

For the first time in three matches at the Wankhede Stadium, where batters have ruled the roost, Arshdeep turned up with a terrific

opening spell accounting for Ryan Rickelton (2) and Suryakumar Yadav (0). He later dismissed Sherfane Rutherford (1) to return 4-0-22-3 on Thursday night.

Apart from striking in different spells, Arshdeep got the new ball to swing and move off the surface precariously while nailing most of his yorkers correctly at the death.

"He started off with his first two games really well and then because of the (nature of) pitches, there are lots of



demands in terms of variations and sometimes, what happens is (that) you forget to bowl your stock ball," Bahutule, who is PBKS' spin bowling coach, told reporters after the match.

"But he is a very self-aware (bowler) and understands the nuances of the game. He went back to his basics in the last couple of days, did a lot of spot and target bowling and he really came back with understanding that he has to just focus on what he does best. "He was very clear in his

mindset...understand what works for you, what your strengths are and precisely that is what he did," the former India player added.

Bahutule said Arshdeep's action and the pace with which he bowls were together responsible for his performance. "I think it is a mixture of both. He is a leading bowler in T20 cricket, in terms of wickets also, as well as the one who has the ability to swing," he said about Arshdeep who became the first bowler to

complete 100 wickets for Punjab Kings in IPL.

Bahutule credited head coach Ricky Ponting's presence for the change in Prabhsimran Singh's approach, who smacked a match-winning 80 not out off 39 balls (11 fours, two sixes).

"(It has) a lot to do with Ricky also being in the changing room. He himself being so positive, he rubs it across to all the batters in terms of approaching innings and Prabh has responded really well to that," Bahutule said.



World Cup is scheduled to be held in South Africa, Zimbabwe, and Namibia in October and November, next year.

"The World Cup is a long way to go but yes one has to think about managing one's schedule and workload. If I feel it (break) can help me in preparing for the World Cup and Tests I will do it," Salman told reporters here.

Salman has been the national T20 captain for a year now but questions are being raised on his position due to his recent struggle in the format.